

ANYTIME INC.

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Enjoy the journey.

Prologue

The golden sun ascended over the horizon, casting its warm embrace upon the vast kingdom of Ramses the Great. From his grand throne, Ramses carefully examined the dusty scrolls of ancient Egyptian scholars who spoke of time with a reverence and wisdom beyond his comprehension. They spoke of time as if it were a tangible entity—something that could be grasped and understood. These scholars believed that the sun was the keeper of time, rising and setting with unfailing regularity, marking the

passage of the hours, days, and seasons. As Ramses delved deeper into the texts, he couldn't help but feel a sense of wonder and awe at the intricate workings of the universe. He glanced up at the sun and realized that it was a force to be reckoned with, far beyond the reach of mortal man. Yet, his curiosity was piqued, and he couldn't help but wonder what secrets it held, what mysteries it could unlock.

As he stood on his balcony overlooking the Nile, he felt a sense of pride and accomplishment. He had achieved great things in his life, conquered new lands, constructed magnificent temples, and ruled with an iron fist. However, as he gazed at the sun, his thoughts turned to his beloved wife, Nefertari. To him, she was more precious than all of his accomplishments combined. Without her, his world would be as dark as the night before the sun's rise.

A knock at the door interrupted his thoughts. A man entered the room, bowing low before the great Pharaoh. "Your Majesty, they have finished it," the man said.

Ramses turned to face him, his expression a mask of stoicism. He looked at the rising sun one last time, feeling that this was the way it always should be.

For Ramses the Great, the sun rose for Nefertari.

The Chase

The sun dipped low in the sky, casting long shadows over the rugged peaks of the Dolomite Mountains. The air was crisp and fresh, with a light breeze blowing through the valleys and stirring the branches of the trees. The afternoon sun bathed everything in a golden light, warming the rocks and grass with its gentle rays.

As the day wore on, the light shifted, casting new shadows and highlighting different features of the landscape. The rocky outcroppings that had seemed so

forbidding in the harsh morning light now glowed with a soft, warm radiance. The verdant meadows that lay in the valleys were transformed, their colors shifting and blending with each passing moment.

Despite the beauty of the scene, there was a certain tension in the air. It was as if the mountains were holding their breath, waiting for something to happen. The wind picked up, sending a shiver down the spine of anyone who happened to be standing in its path. And yet, even with this sense of foreboding, there was also a feeling of possibility. It was as if the mountains were on the brink of something, something that could change everything.

The silence shattered as a large, boxy contraption hurtled down the hill at break-neck speed. It weaved and dodged, avoiding the trees and rocks that dotted the mountainside. It kicked up snow and dirt, sending it flying into the air.

It was a strange and ungainly thing, cobbled together from a mishmash of mismatched parts, as if it were the brainchild of a mad inventor. Large, boxy, and covered in a tangle of wires and gadgets, it looked like it could fall apart at any second. Yet, for all its haphazard appearance, there was a certain charm to it. It seemed to be an extension of its creator, a reflection of his quirks and oddities. In a way, it was comical, but at the same time, there was something undeniable and impressive about its ability to zoom through the air like a bird, carrying its passengers to destinations unknown.

The machine was not alone. Ari Buktu, a 17 year old high school student, sat atop it, perched on an old movie theater chair that looked as though it had seen better days. The rusted metal frame had been welded onto its roof, and a makeshift wooden plank served as the floor beneath his feet. In front of him was a pirate's wheel, the sole means of steering the ramshackle vehicle as it careened through the snowy canyon. It was a precarious perch, but Ari had little choice but to hold on for dear life and hope that it would hold together.

Professor Lionel Raventhorpe and Julius were clinging to the back of the machine, their bodies twisted in awkward angles as they worked to repair the contraption with urgency. Welding tools and spare parts were scattered all around them, and the professor's face was twisted with determination as he tinkered with the engine. Julius, meanwhile, was using all four paws to help, scurrying back and forth to retrieve tools and offer his assistance. Amid the chaos around them, the two maintained unwavering focus on the task at hand, their eyes never leaving the wires and gears as they sped down the mountain.

The noise was deafening, a cacophony of metal and fire tearing through the peaceful landscape. The animals of the Dolomites were startled and frightened, taking cover in the trees and caves.

And as the box and its passengers disappeared over the crest of the hill, the silence of the Dolomite Mountains was

restored once again. The peace and tranquility of this hidden paradise returned, as if the strange, noisy interruption had never happened.

Ari's thoughts were racing as he struggled to keep control. He had always been skeptical of the professor's ideas, but he couldn't deny the excitement of their latest adventure. Now, as they careened down the mountainside, he wasn't so sure. He wasn't sure how much more of this he could take.

As they hurtled down the mountain, Raventhorpe turned to Ari with a playful grin." You know, Ari, if we survive this, we'll have a story to tell for the ages."

Ari was too panicked to respond, but he couldn't deny the thrill of the adventure. As they dodged a falling tree, Ari yelled out to the professor.

"Ya think we lost 'em, Professor?"

Raventhorpe replied, "That would take a miracle. And since I'm a man of science, I'm gonna have to say...not a snowball's chance in hell."

Ari couldn't help but feel a twinge of doubt. The professor was brilliant, but sometimes he seemed more interested in the thrill of adventure than in the practical details. As they hurtled towards an uncertain fate, Ari wondered if they were ready for what lay ahead.

Ari's hands were slick with sweat as he gripped the wheel, feeling every bump and twist of the contraption as it careened through the snowy canyon. The wind whipped

at his face and stung his eyes, making it difficult to see the looming cliffs ahead. He tried to keep his focus, but the distant thunder of hooves behind them reminded him that they were being pursued.

Ari's heart raced as he dodged left and right, trying to keep the machine from smashing into the rock walls. The horsemen on their tails were closing in, the sound of their horses' breaths and the clinking of armor growing louder by the second. He couldn't help but glance over his shoulder, catching glimpses of the menacing figures.

"Stay sharp, Ari!" Raventhorpe called out, his voice strained over the din of the wind and hooves. "We can't let them catch us!"

Ari gritted his teeth, trying to keep his focus on the pirate wheel. His mind was racing with questions: Who were these horsemen? Why were they chasing them?

As they swerved around a sharp turn, Ari felt his nerves fraying. His fingers slipped on the wheel, and for a moment, it seemed like they were going to crash. But at the last second, he managed to right the wheel, and they careened down the canyon once more.

The horsemen were getting closer. Ari could hear their snarls and shouts now, and the clang of their weapons. He didn't know how much longer they could hold them off.

But as they rounded a bend in the canyon, Ari caught sight of something in the distance. A glimmer of light, like a beacon in the storm. And he realized, with a sudden burst

of hope, that they might just have a chance.

"We're almost there!" he shouted to Raventhorpe, his voice strained over the din of the wind and hooves. "We can make it!"

But even as he spoke the words, Ari knew that the danger was far from over. The horsemen were still hot on their heels, and the canyon walls were closing in. It was like they were trapped in a nightmare, trying to outrun death itself.

Raventhorpe had his hands full. His metalworking tools lay scattered around him, and the blowtorch flames flickered and jolted as they danced back and forth. His eyes were locked onto the machine's insides, searching for the faulty component that had given up on them. Meanwhile, Julius, his pet chinchilla, clung to Raventhorpe's shoulder, chattering with fervor.

"Are you sure it's the timing belt, Professor?" Ari called out over the whistling wind.

"Positive, Ari. I can't fix it if you don't keep us alive," Raventhorpe retorted, his eyes fixed on the wires and gadgets.

"I'll give it my best shot. Not like we got a whole lotta options here, huh?" Ari muttered under his breath, feeling the weight of responsibility bearing down on him.

The situation was dire. Raventhorpe and Julius scrambled to patch the faulty electronics, with the chinchilla proving to be as much of a genius as

Raventhorpe. Julius chattered in agreement, pointing out a wire or a gear that Raventhorpe had missed. "Of course I tried that! You think I'd forget something as obvious as —" the professor bickered, only to be interrupted by Julius' emphatic squeaking and pointing at a section of the engine. Raventhorpe's realization was immediate, "Wait! Julius, you're a genius!" The chinchilla responded in a straightforward manner with another squeak.

Raventhorpe's face was a portrait of frustration, sweat dripping down his forehead despite the cold. "We think we found it. Hold steady, Ari," he said, gesturing for the blowtorch.

Ari gritted his teeth, gripping the wheel tighter. His arms ached from the strain, and his breath came in ragged gasps. The horsemen behind them were closing in, their figures looming closer and closer in the canyon's shadows.

The sound of the horseman's approach was thunderous, their galloping hooves echoing off the walls of the canyon and drowning out any other sound. Ari felt as though he was being pushed forward, forced to keep moving by an invisible hand. It was a sensation he had felt before, with the professor, but this was different. The horseman seemed almost inhuman, relentless in their pursuit, and Ari couldn't help but compare them to the professor. Were they so different? Both were pushing him forward, both seemed to have their own agenda. Ari was unsure of what to do. Should he continue to follow the professor with

unquestioning obedience, or should he try to find his own way? The horseman's approach only made the decision more urgent, and Ari felt a sense of desperation well up within him.

"Hurry up, Professor. They're almost on us!" Ari shouted. Raventhorpe worked at breakneck speed, his hands a blur of motion as he tinkered with the machine's insides. Julius chattered encouragement, his tiny paws clutching Raventhorpe's coat with determination.

The sound of an Irish voice cut through the air, its tone ringing with authority. It was the voice of a man accustomed to giving orders, and this one was clear: "Nowhere to go. Give up." The words echoed through the snowy canyon, bouncing off the rocks and filling Ari with a sense of dread. It was true, they were trapped with no escape in sight. The man behind the voice knew it, and he seemed to relish in their defeat.

At last, Raventhorpe straightened up, wiping his brow. "It's done. Julius, hit the button now!"

The chinchilla sprang into action, his tiny paws maneuvered over the wires to reach the button. The box shuddered and hummed as the wings sprouted from its sides, lifting them off the ground and into the air.

Ari breathed a sigh of relief, his heart pounding in his chest. But he knew that their troubles were far from over. The horsemen were still behind them, and the chasm yawned below, waiting to swallow them up. It was a

desperate gamble, one that he hoped would pay off.

The wind rushed past them, whipping their hair and clothes into a frenzy. They were airborne, soaring over the snowy canyon, but the horsemen were still on their tail. Raventhorpe's repairs had given them a fighting chance, but it was up to Ari to steer them to safety.

It was a white-knuckle ride, they were swerving and dodging like a wild animal. Raventhorpe clung to his tools, while Julius clung to Raventhorpe's coat, chattering in excitement.

"Julius, we did it! Wait — Watch out for that rock, Ari!" Raventhorpe called out, as he pointed.

Ari gritted his teeth, yanking the wheel to the left. The box lurched, wings flapping, as they avoided colliding with a jagged boulder in the nick of time.

The engine jolted and groaned, struggling to gain altitude as they pulled away from their pursuers, leaving them teetering on the edge of the cliff. The machine's engines roared to life, their power lifting them all higher and higher. Furious shouts and the sound of horses' hooves pounding against the ground filled the air. Ari's grip on the wheel tightened, his heart pounding in his chest as he watched the ground fall away beneath them. The machine shuddered and swayed, threatening to topple at any moment, but Ari kept his focus. He could feel the wind rushing past him, sending his hair flying and ice crystals stinging his face. As the machine gained altitude, the

horsemen became smaller and smaller, their angry voices fading into the distance.

Ari breathed a sigh of relief, grateful for the respite, but his sense of triumph was short-lived.

A loud, ominous sound echoed through the canyon. The engine shuddered with violence, and Raventhorpe tried to control it. His hands jerked to the auto-stabilizer controls. Ari felt the wind rushing past him, the world spinning out of control as they careened toward the canyon wall.

He tried to hold on, his fingers clutching at the metal wings, but it was no use. He lost his grip and tumbled from his seat, hurtling toward the chasm below. His mind raced with thoughts of his impending doom, wondering if this was the end for him.

As he fell, he caught a glimpse of Raventhorpe's horrified face, his friend reaching out in a vain attempt to save him. Ari could feel himself slipping away, the wind whipping around him, the world a blur of snow and rock. But then, as if by some miracle, his hand found purchase on the edge of a wing, and he clung on for dear life, his heart pounding in his chest. He saw Raventhorpe reach out for him, and he reached back, their fingertips brushing against each other's, but it was too late. He was slipping away, the wind tearing at his fingers, threatening to send him plummeting to his death.

"ARI!" Raventhorpe's cry echoed through the canyon, filled with anguish and desperation. Ari could feel the tears

stinging his eyes, his friend's voice ringing in his ears. He knew that this might be it, that this might be the end of the road for him.

And then, with a sickening lurch, the wing broke free, and Ari fell, tumbling into the abyss. The wind rushed past him, his body twisting and turning as he hurtled toward the unknown.

He closed his eyes, the wind howling around him, and braced himself for impact.

Ari Buktu

Ari Buktu, a 17-year-old high school student, boasted a wiry, athletic build that outshined his shorter-than-average stature. His body was put together like a ballet dancer, with lean muscles that allowed him to move with grace and precision. He wore a blue hooded sweatshirt that seemed to blend into the shadows and green sneakers designed for speed, mirroring his quick-wittedness. Ari's face was youthful and expressive, with eyes that sparkled with intelligence and a mischievous grin that hinted at his

resourcefulness and charm. Ari had always preferred a comfortable, stress-free life, and his laid-back demeanor could sometimes come across as slackerish.

Ari's life began under the most improbable circumstances. In the small, unremarkable town of Glendale, as an infant, he was adopted by Victoria Bartholomew-Featherington-Dimwhitten III, a wealthy and self-absorbed woman who saw him as little more than a means to elevate her social standing. She was in love with a man who adored children, and so she adopted Ari to win his affections. Unfortunately for Victoria, the man quickly lost interest. Ari's adoptive mother was known for her ostentatious displays of wealth and her insistence on showcasing her "artistic genius" at every opportunity.

Victoria was a tall, gaunt woman with leathery skin, thin blonde hair, and cold crusty blue eyes that seemed to pierce right through you. She had no discernible shape and was constantly adorning herself with expensive clothing and accessories in a futile attempt to appear more attractive. Her mannerisms were exaggerated and affected, often fluttering her bony hands in the air as she spoke, as if her words alone were not enough to convey her overblown sense of self-importance. Ari sometimes couldn't help but compare her to a marionette puppet, with her jerky movements and tendency to talk down to him.

With her big tobacco inheritance in hand, she became the owner of an art school. Victoria used her influence and

wealth to force people to buy her paintings, which she believed to be masterpieces. Each painting featured her own face in various historical and fantastical scenarios. She regularly held art openings featuring her work, making sure that her creations found their way into the homes and offices of the town's most influential residents.

Ari could still recall the countless times Victoria had spoken about her favorite subject: herself. She would drone on about her family's tobacco business, the source of her wealth, and her self-proclaimed genius as an artist. The town's residents had to endure her lavish, self-serving art openings, their walls adorned with her so-called masterpieces.

It was during this time in his childhood that Ari first realized he had never actually seen Victoria paint or create any of her so-called masterpieces. He had asked her about this once, his eyes wide with genuine curiosity.

"Why have I never seen you paint, Victoria?"

Victoria had scoffed, her expression a mixture of amusement and disdain as she replied, "Oh, Ari, my dear, the great Geoffrey Doots has never been witnessed making his brilliant creations. For all the world knows, Doots has touched more suits than canvases. Remember, Ari, great artists wear suits and never get their hands dirty."

Even as a child, Ari had found this response both absurd and suspicious. Nevertheless, he had kept his thoughts to himself, knowing that questioning Victoria's artistic

prowess would only lead to trouble.

Victoria's art school, which she had purchased to legitimize her artistic pursuits, was just another means to an end, allowing her to further manipulate and control the people around her. Ari knew that the school was just another extension of her vanity, and he couldn't help but feel a pang of pity for the students who genuinely wanted to learn and grow as artists.

Whenever Victoria looked at Ari, it was as if she were examining an unfortunate stain on her otherwise pristine life. Her constant belittling and dismissal of him only served to fuel his determination to prove her wrong. He longed to break free from her oppressive shadow and carve out his own path, a life that would not be dictated by Victoria's whims and ego.

Victoria was constantly lecturing Ari on what would or would not make money and how lazy everyone was, despite never having worked a day in her life. Her very own art school was losing money hand over fist, a fact that Ari discovered when he saw the financial statements on her desk one day. In a fit of denial, Victoria had scrawled "LIES" across the papers in giant red letters, as if that would make the problem disappear. Ari couldn't help but chuckle at the absurdity of her reaction.

Despite living in a luxurious home filled with expensive furnishings and "original" artwork, Ari's small, cramped bedroom was a far cry from the opulence that surrounded

him. The walls were lined with Victoria's paintings – a constant reminder of her self-centered nature and the expectations she had for him to live in her shadow. Ari often wondered if she secretly hoped her "artistic brilliance" would seep into his dreams at night, transforming him into a more suitable heir to her artistic empire.

One evening, as Ari sat quietly in the living room, Victoria walked in and addressed him with a sneer. "You know, Ari, I've been thinking about my will lately, and I just wanted to remind you that you'll never inherit a single penny of my wealth. You simply weren't born with the talent and refinement required to manage my fortune."

With a dismissive wave of her hand, she continued, "And as for my name, well, you were never deserving of the Dimwhitten legacy. No, you'll keep the name I bought you with, Buktu or whatever it was – After all, that's all you've ever been to me."

Ari's life was a constant struggle to find his own identity and purpose, separate from the stifling influence of his adoptive mother. He longed for something more than the mundane existence Victoria had planned for him, and he was determined to prove her wrong.

Ari sat quietly in the living room holding his latest physics

exam, which bore a large red "F" on the front, Victoria entered the room. She spotted the paper over his shoulder and couldn't help but comment on his failure.

"Another failed exam, Ari?" she said, a condescending smile playing on her swollen, freshly injected lips. "Well, it's a good thing we've accepted that you're never going to amount to much. You could always get a job as a mailman. They seem to always misplace my art critics' weekly newsletter. I suspect the neighbor is stealing it. If you were a mailman, you could see to it that everything comes and goes as scheduled. I don't want to miss any accolades for my latest works."

Ari rolled his eyes. He very much wanted to live a real life on his own terms, and perhaps that's why, out of the blue, he decided to talk to his physics professor about extra credit. A chance to prove to himself and everyone around him that he was more than just Victoria Dimwhitten's forgotten adoptive son. She treated him as though he were a mere possession, a trinket she had picked up on a whim, rather than a human being with hopes, dreams, and aspirations.

As Ari lay in bed the night before his meeting with his peculiar physics teacher, Professor Raventhorpe, he found himself admiring the man who always seemed to have everything in order. Raventhorpe's genuine passion for his work and his students' success was a stark contrast to Victoria's self-centered ways. He often stayed late in his

lab, immersed in intriguing projects.

Bathed in the gentle moonlight streaming through his bedroom window, Ari felt a spark of determination flare up inside him. He knew there was something more to life than the stifling existence Victoria had planned for him, and he sensed that Professor Raventhorpe might hold the key. Little did Ari know that this simple decision, driven by his quiet resolve, would soon lead him down a path of remarkable adventures that would forever change the course of his life.

The Verge of Bankruptcy

Professor Lionel Raventhorpe was a curious sight to behold. His short, stocky frame was topped with a balding head, save for two large cones of white hair shooting off the sides like festive party hats. His beard, also white, obscured much of his mouth, leaving only a small gap through which he spoke. He wore an odd combination of clothing - a yellow trenchcoat that could have been seen as fashionable in some distant future, but in the present day looked almost comical. His choice of footwear was equally

questionable, with worn-out Berkinstocks and dirty white socks that had a hole where his big toe poked out. Yet despite his unconventional appearance, there was something endearing about Raventhorpe that drew people to him. An earnestness that couldn't be faked.

Nestled in the heart of the sleepy town of Glendale, Professor Lionel Raventhorpe's house stood as a testament to his boundless creativity and insatiable curiosity. From the outside, the quaint Victorian-style abode appeared ordinary, with its muted colors and neatly trimmed hedges. However, once one stepped through the front door, it became apparent that this was no ordinary residence.

The entrance hall was a labyrinth of gadgets and gizmos, with whirring machines and blinking lights filling every corner. Tinkering contraptions lined the walls, intricate mechanical devices that seemed to serve no apparent purpose other than to mesmerize and delight. The floors were covered with a patchwork of rugs, hiding a network of wires snaking their way from one experiment to another.

To the left, the living room had been converted into a makeshift laboratory, teeming with beakers and test tubes bubbling with mysterious liquids. In the center, an enormous chalkboard took up an entire wall, filled with complex equations and diagrams that documented Raventhorpe's ongoing research. Overhead, a model of the solar system dangled from the ceiling, each planet rotating

on its axis in perfect harmony.

The dining room had long since been overtaken by a sprawling collection of antique artifacts and relics, each meticulously cataloged and displayed under glass. Time-worn maps covered the walls, their edges frayed and corners curling with age. In one corner, a dusty bookshelf overflowed with leather-bound tomes, their spines cracked and faded from countless readings.

The kitchen, too, had been transformed into a workspace for Raventhorpe's culinary experiments. High-tech appliances and scientific equipment sat side-by-side with traditional cookware, showcasing the professor's penchant for blending old and new. The countertops were cluttered with jars of exotic spices, vials of aromatic extracts, and an assortment of experimental ingredients, all waiting to be combined into the next gastronomic creation.

Upstairs, Raventhorpe's bedroom was a sanctuary of sorts, a place where he could retreat after a long day of tinkering and inventing. The walls were adorned with posters of famous scientists and inventors, their stern faces watching over him as he slept. A large telescope stood by the window, its lens pointed towards the heavens, ready for a night of stargazing.

The backyard was no less impressive, with every square inch dedicated to a dizzying array of experiments and projects in various stages of completion. Greenhouses filled with exotic plants, some of which seemed to defy the laws

of nature, stretched towards the sky. A small pond teemed with unusual aquatic life, their vibrant colors and strange shapes hinting at Raventhorpe's expertise in genetic engineering. Scattered throughout the garden, an assortment of peculiar contraptions whirled and hummed, their gears and pistons working tirelessly as they carried out their enigmatic tasks.

In this wonderland of science and invention, Professor Lionel Raventhorpe was in his element. Every corner of his home told a story of discovery, innovation, and an unrelenting pursuit of knowledge. It was a place where the impossible seemed within reach, and the boundaries of human understanding were continually pushed and expanded. And amidst this extraordinary chaos, Raventhorpe and his trusty chinchilla sidekick, Julius, worked tirelessly to unlock the mysteries of time itself.

Of course, a sanctuary of such a caliber came at great cost. Raventhorpe sat at his cluttered desk, his hands trembling as he reviewed a stack of bankruptcy papers. The dimly lit room cast eerie shadows on the walls, only adding to the sense of gloom that enveloped him. He was running out of time – if he didn't come up with the money by Friday, he would lose everything. His home, his lab, and any chance of salvaging his once-promising career would be gone forever. The pressure weighed heavily on him, his thoughts consumed with finding a solution to his dire situation.

As he sat there, agonizing over his impending financial ruin, the shrill ring of the telephone cut through the silence. He jumped, startled, glanced at Julius, shrugged his shoulders and picked up the phone.

"Raventhorpe, this is Principal Pellingbottom speaking," she said, her voice cold and condescending. "I noticed your classroom door today displaying 'Professor' in bold letters. Trying to impress someone, Lionel?"

He gritted his teeth, trying to maintain his composure. "Principal Pellingbottom, I assure you, it's just a harmless display of passion for my subject and as you know I once was a —."

"Passion has its place, Lionel, but remember the consequences it brought you previously," she said, her tone dripping with disdain. "You're no longer a university professor — you're a high school teacher. Oh and that reminds me, the science department mentioned some missing supplies. I'll be conducting a surprise inspection of your lab this week. I expect everything to be in order, understood?"

"Of course not," Raventhorpe replied tersely, his grip on the phone tightening. "You're more than welcome to inspect my lab."

"You mean my lab, remember you work for me. Very well, then," Pellingbottom said, her tone dripping with smug satisfaction. "I look forward to our little visit. Good day, 'Professor.'"

After hanging up the phone, Raventhorpe looked at Julius, who had now returned to his shoulder. Julius squeaked indignantly, sharing his disapproval of Pellingbottom's attitude. "What do you think, Julius? Can we finish it tomorrow?" Raventhorpe asked, seeking reassurance from his small friend. Julius squeaked affirmatively, his eyes brimming with wisdom beyond his small stature.

As Raventhorpe stood up and closed the back of a grandfather clock he had been working on, Julius gently tugged at his ear, squeaking insistently. Raventhorpe pondered the advice from his loyal companion. "Of course, Julius," he said, a soft smile crossing his face. "And I'm going to tell Dolores how I feel about her."

The Caged Bird

Under the dimmed light of a rising sun, Professor Raventhorpe steered his rickety old van – a hulking mass of metal, large enough to transport his countless inventions and experiments – into the parking lot of Kasdan High School. As he pulled into the lot, he couldn't help but cast a bitter glare at Principal Pellingbottom's sleek vehicle, smugly parked in the closest spot to the school entrance.

At the far end of the parking lot, as he approached his designated spot, Raventhorpe's frustration mounted when

he noticed someone had parked their car ever-so-slightly in his space, making it difficult for his cumbersome van to squeeze in. He gritted his teeth and carefully maneuvered his van into the tight gap, the sound of the engine barely audible above the cacophony of his thoughts. In many ways, today was no different than others; the van, the parking lot, and his unfortunate lot in life only served to remind him of the glory days that seemed so far out of reach. Yet, Raventhorpe's focus was on something more profound. Love.

Raventhorpe's past as an esteemed university professor felt like a distant memory. The 10 minute walk from his parking spot to the front door of Kasdan High School gave him ample time to get lost in thought. The catastrophic accident that had caused his dismissal still haunted him, but he was determined to redeem himself through his work done inside the walls Kasdan High School. With the support of Julius he continued his research university research on temporal displacement, hoping to achieve a breakthrough and redeem his many failures.

In the heart of the Kasdan High School science wing, there was a place that stood apart from the rest - a realm of wonder and possibility where one man pursued his life's crowning achievement. Raventhorpe's laboratory was a place of ceaseless activity, where every corner was crammed with books and equipment related to his never-ending quest to unlock the secrets of the universe. The

shelves and desks groaned under the weight of tomes such as "In Search of the Edge of Time" and "The Brief History of Treasures," while curiously empty photo frames adorned with captions for legendary artifacts like the Holy Grail and Poseidon's Trident littered the room. With his faithful companion Julius always at his side, Raventhorpe worked tirelessly, to push the boundaries of what was possible, to uncover the hidden treasures that lay waiting to be discovered, and on the rare occasion, teach and grade papers.

Kasdan High School was a sprawling institution of concrete and glass, with hallways that seemed to stretch on forever and lockers that never seemed to open quite right. The students were a mix of eager young minds and disinterested adolescents, milling about with backpacks slung over their shoulders and cell phones perpetually in hand. The walls were adorned with posters advertising upcoming events and showcasing the accomplishments of the student body, while the classrooms themselves were a hodgepodge of outdated technology and well-worn desks. It was a far cry from Raventhorpe's previous job, but he found solace in the potential of his creations and of Dolores Dabbledots.

As he ambled past Dolores's homeroom and glanced in his heart skipped a beat. Dolores was a beacon of warmth and kindness in the cold, sterile halls of Kasdan High School. With her silver-streaked auburn hair and eyes that

sparkled like the finest emeralds, she seemed to embody the very essence of compassion. She moved gracefully through the crowded corridors, her smile a lighthouse guiding lost souls toward refuge. Her voice, soft and soothing, carried with it the power to calm even the most restless of hearts.

It was this unassuming, nurturing presence that had drawn Raventhorpe to Dolores like a moth to a flame. He felt a magnetic pull toward her, the need to be near her, to share in the light she so effortlessly radiated. Dolores was a balm for his bruised soul, a salve for the wounds of his tumultuous past. Dolores was more than a history teacher; she was the embodiment of the history he longed to rewrite, a chance to start anew in a world that had turned its back on him.

And yet, for all his yearning and desire, Raventhorpe could never muster the courage to truly speak to Dolores and reveal his heartfelt feelings. Time and again, he would rehearse the words he longed to say, but whenever he found himself in her presence, his heart would race, and his tongue would grow heavy with unspoken emotions. The world seemed to conspire against him, creating a chasm between them that he could never bridge. But today he had a secret weapon.

He continued on until he approached Principal Pellingbottom's office. Her stern warning from last night still fresh on his mind. He stopped, listening for any signs of her shrill voice.

“Students are students and students are stupid,” explained Pellingbottom on the phone like she had just split the atom. Most likely she was on the phone with the superintendent. “No he’s not here yet, rest assured I’ll get to the bottom of this.”

He noticed the librarian pushing a large stack of books down the hallway and he ducked behind it and slipped into the lab, stopping to slap a sticky note with the word, “Professor” written sloppily in black marker in front of the printed placard that read, “Lionel Raventhorpe, Physics.”

“Can’t even spell my name right,” Raventhorpe said to Julius who squeaked shaking his head. We don’t have much time.”

He approached a large box, large enough to fit 15 people inside, covered in looked like a science grade bedsheet and yanked it off and fell into a seat right next to it grabbing a blowtorch and mask.

Raventhorpe began to weld, he knew he had to finish his AE temporal device before Pellingbottom came to inspect the lab. That is if it didn’t exploded like it did at the University. "Julius, we're almost there," he said, holding up a piece of metal to inspect it. "Just a few more tweaks and we'll be ready to go. No more mishaps like last time." To which Julius squeaked in concern. “Of course it will hold together.”

Raventhorpe nodded, knowing that Julius was right. He couldn't wait to show Dolores what they had created. He

had been dreaming about taking her somewhere special on a flash first date, like in the movies, but he had to finish it first. "We'll get it done, Julius, safety first." he said, determination in his voice. "We'll get it done before school is out."

Today was the day that Raventhorpe would tell Dolores how he felt about her. No more cold feet, no more wandering off reading bulletins about chess club at the last second. Today was the day.

But, before Raventhorpe could even consider what he would say to Dolores in person, he spent countless hours agonizing over the perfect way to express his love for her in written form. Draft after draft, he wrote and rewrote letters, pouring his heart into each one, only to find himself dissatisfied with the results. With each attempt, he would crumple the letter in frustration, tossing it towards the ever-growing pile.

During one of his many failed attempts, Julius watched with concern, sensing the mounting frustration in his friend. Finally, he could no longer hold his silence and let out a squeak that seemed to suggest that perhaps Raventhorpe should just tell Dolores how he feels in person.

Raventhorpe sighed, reluctantly acknowledging Julius's point. "Alright, Julius, maybe you have a point," he said begrudgingly. "But it's not easy, you know. Putting your heart on the line like that."

Raventhorpe pondered the idea and decided to give it a try. He looked up from his welding, his goggles atop his shiny bald head, and practiced speaking softly into the air. "Dolores, the first time I saw you, I knew I loved you." Julius, ever the skeptic, responded with a high-pitched squeak, shaking his small head covering his ears.

Raventhorpe paused for a moment, considering his words. "Too much?" he asked, to which Julius nodded in agreement. "Okay, how about this?" Raventhorpe continued, "The first time I saw you, I knew we were destined to be together forever and ever and ever."

Julius, confused, squeaked and mimed himself vomiting into the note laden trashcan before Raventhorpe took the plunge and asked, "Marry me?" Julius shrieked in disgust and Raventhorpe quickly backtracked, "Dolores, I like you. Do you want to go out with me some time?"

Julius stopped and stood straight up, seemingly pleased with this iteration, squeaked his approval. "So keep it simple, huh? I can do that," Raventhorpe said with a grin, feeling proud of his progress. With newfound determination, Raventhorpe set aside his pen and paper, ready to face Dolores and reveal his true feelings for her.

Raventhorpe couldn't help but feel a twinge of irony as he looked at Julius, his trusty assistant. It was a sad truth that the only being in the world who seemed to fully understand him was not even human. Julius, with his high-pitched squeaks and inquisitive nature, had been by

Raventhorpe's side for years, assisting with everything from calculations to welding. He may not be human, but he was the closest thing Raventhorpe had to a kindred spirit in this world. And for that, he was grateful.

Suddenly, Raventhorpe's thoughts were interrupted as the sound of someone entering his lab broke through his concentration. "What's up, Pr--" a voice called out. It was Ari Bukt, one of his more lackadaisical physics students, failing the class by a wide margin. Before he knew it, Ari had waltzed into the lab, only to trip over a mantel clock on the floor with a resounding CRACK.

"My clock!" Raventhorpe exclaimed, scurrying over to tend to the timepiece. Ari picked himself up off the ground, brushing himself off. "I'm okay," he reassured Raventhorpe.

As he inspected the clock, Raventhorpe saw that there was a lightning bolt crack across the glass. "You gotta be more careful," Raventhorpe admonished him. "This clock is the centerpiece of my life's work."

Ari shuffled his feet awkwardly, feeling guilty for his earlier carelessness. He hadn't intended to disrupt Raventhorpe's work or damage his precious clock. "Sorry," he muttered, "Hope I didn't mess up anything." Raventhorpe, in his usual calm and collected manner, assured Ari that everything was alright and that he could fix any damage. Ari was always impressed with Raventhorpe's composure, even in the face of unexpected

interruptions.

Trying to make amends, Ari brought up an extra credit assignment they had discussed before. "So, we still on for that extra credit assignment? Professor I really need to pass this class." he said.

Raventhorpe nodded, his attention diverted for a moment. "Sure, just come by the lab later toni-- Wait, what time is it?" he asked suddenly, his focus shifting back to the present moment.

Ari checked his watch and replied, "3:45."

Raventhorpe's face contorted with a look of alarm as he realized that he had lost track of time and that school was already out. "Oh no," he muttered to himself, feeling the pressure of responsibility weighing heavily on his shoulders.

Ari, noticing the change in Raventhorpe's demeanor, asked if everything was alright. "Yeah, didn't you hear the bell?" he queried.

"No, I didn't hear the bell," Raventhorpe replied, hastily gathering his things and scurrying out the door with Julius perched on top of his head. Ari watched him go, wondering what it must be like to be so consumed by one's work and intellect that the rest of the world fades into the background.

As Raventhorpe darted through the bustling halls of Kasdan High School, his mouth mechanically muttering apologies and explanations, his actions were speaking a

different language entirely. He elbowed past students, side-stepped groups of chatting teens, and vaulted over abandoned backpacks with single-minded determination. This was a man on a mission, and nothing - not even a throng of chattering students - could stand in his way. His thoughts were consumed by Dolores, his heart racing as he drew closer to her.

"Julius I hope we aren't too late," Raventhorpe said clutching his heart.

Every second felt like an eternity, his mind racing with anticipation and excitement. He was a man who operated on impulse, and right now, his impulses were leading him to Dolores - to see her, to be with her, to tell her what he truly felt in his heart.

Nothing was going to stop him from reaching Dolores, not even his own labored breathing.

He got to her door and stopped peering inside but it was empty. "She must be in the parking lot already, quickly Julius. Quickly!"

He burst through the front door of Kasdan High School, heart racing with anticipation, only to have it shattered at the sight of Dolores climbing into a car with another rather dashing man. Raventhorpe's world crumbled around him as he stood frozen in disbelief, watching the car drive away. "Dolores," he whispered to himself, unable to fathom what he had just witnessed. He turned away, defeated and heartbroken, as he trudged back inside the school.

Raventhorpe didn't recall how he got back to his lab but somehow he ended up there, a dejected figure with his head hung low. His eyes remained glued to the ground, as if searching for answers that would never come. "You okay, man?" Ari's voice pierced through Raventhorpe's despondent thoughts, interrupting his train of thought.

"Oh, Ari, you're still here. Just come back tonight for the extra credit," Raventhorpe muttered, his voice barely audible.

Ari nods uncertainly and leaves the lab with a slam of the door. Raventhorpe hears the sound, but he is lost in thought, his mind drifting aimlessly through a sea of unanswered questions.

As Raventhorpe sits in silence, a book falls from the shelf, landing open on the floor. The drawing of a solid gold tiara catches Julius's attention, but Raventhorpe fails to notice it, shuffling through bankruptcy papers on his desk. "Oh and the bankruptcy, Julius we have til Friday."

Julius tried to draw his attention to the book, but Raventhorpe brushed him off, pleading to be left alone. Julius tugged at Raventhorpe's hair more firmly, prompting him to snap out of his thoughts. "Ow! What'd you do that for--" Raventhorpe's eyes lock onto the drawing of the tiara. He picks up the book, realizing that it's William Saturno's *The Brief History of Treasures*. Julius squeaked, his tiny paws resting on the edge of the open book. Raventhorpe smiled down at him and a thought

darted into his idea faster than any that had ever hit him. He glanced up at the lightning bolt cut into the grandfather clocks face and then back to the drawing.

"Wait a minute..." Raventhorpe whispered, lost in thought. Suddenly, he jumped up from his chair, his eyes filled with excitement. He started walking all sorts of direction seemingly at once. Leaping up and down and up and down again and smiling. Though it couldn't be seen under his beard, a grin larger than any other to ever grace the halls of Kasdan High School formed on his face. Exuberant laughter sounding more like long lost relief erupted from Raventhopre. "I've got it! My little friend I've got it!" he declared, grabbing Julius and rushing out of the lab.

Raventhorpe's mind was racing as he hurried through the now empty hallways of Kasdan High School, his newfound idea to win Dolores back had filled him with unlimited excitement and energy. He knew that the key to her heart lay in the Tiara of Nefertari, the painting of which adorned the wall of her classroom. As he burst through the door, the painting came into view, and Raventhorpe's eyes lit up. Dolores's framed drawing of Tiara was even more beautiful in person, its intricate gold designs and sparkling jewels shining in the light almost like it was real. Julius waited patiently as Raventhorpe's mind whirled with possibilities.

"This painting on Dolores's wall...the Tiara of

Nefertari," he mused, lowering the book to reveal the painting. "It's the same artifact as in Saturno's book. She'd really love this thing." Julius chirped in agreement, waiting for Raventhorpe to fully form his idea. Suddenly, it hit him like a bolt of lightning. "That's my in!" he exclaimed. "That's how she'll fall in love with me! We'll use Saturno's book, travel back in time to the Tiara's last known location in the AE and grab it for Dolores. We'll be in and out." Julius applauded the idea with excited squeaks.

"With Saturno's book we'll know exactly where to go, what to look for, and even better we'll know when to go to."

Raventhorpe felt a renewed sense of purpose as he set to work his mind fixated on the Tiara. He knew that he had to make a grand gesture, something that would show her how much he cared. "Or at least appreciate the gesture," he thought to himself. "Either way Julius, let's get to work. I need you to finish the floor guide!"

He raced faster than ever as he ran back to the lab, but he slowed as he passed by Principal Pellingbottom's new empty office, and he felt relief. "It'll be a lot easier without her breathing down our necks tonight Julius."

His gaze fell upon a small cage near the door. A bright and beautiful bird fluttered its wings in agitation. As the bird's eyes met Raventhorpe's, a pang of empathy resonated deep within him. He saw himself in the bird, trapped in a dead-end job, confined by Pellingbottom's

authority, just as the bird was confined by the bars of its cage.

Julius looked at Raventhorpe and squeaked in pain. “My thoughts exactly Julius. Who dares to cage a bird when it can fly so very high.”

Raventhorpe unlatched the cage door. The bird hesitated for a moment before spreading its wings and soaring out of its prison. As it disappeared through her window, Raventhorpe couldn't help but smile. This time it would all be different. He'd come so far since his time at the University.

“Get there, get the Tiara and ride back victorious to a life of love. A life of freedom.” His love for Dolores was the fuel for his escape. In the lab Raventhorpe and Julius prepared to leave Kasdan High School behind, they had just one thing left to do. Make sure the elevator works.

The Extra Credit

Ari lounged in the cramped bedroom that Victoria begrudgingly allowed him to inhabit. The walls were lined with her "original" artwork, a constant reminder of her self-centered nature. Despite the opulent surroundings of the rest of the house, Ari's thoughts were filled with dreams of making his own way in the world, leaving his own mark, and being his own person. However, he didn't quite know how to achieve that yet.

Lost in his daydreams, he played video games with his

friends, trying to forget the stifling atmosphere of Victoria's home. Suddenly, her shrill voice pierced the air. "Ari, come to the living room immediately!" she demanded.

"Hang on a second guys, Victoria's yelling at me again," said Ari Reluctantly as paused his game and went to the main room, where he found Victoria surrounded by servants carrying an array of camera equipment. She was preparing for one of her photo expeditions to remote parts of the world, which she used as material for her "paintings." Victoria, busy directing the servants on how to pack her belongings, didn't even notice Ari's entrance until she had finished barking orders.

With a dismissive wave of her bony hand, she told Ari, "I'll be gone for a week, and you are to stay in your bedroom and the kitchen only. If I find that you've been anywhere else in this house, I'll know. I can smell your presence, and I won't tolerate it," Victoria stuck her nose up into the air and began sniffing exaggeratedly, as if she's concerned Ari had already been in other parts of the house while she was preparing to leave.

Ari rolled his eyes and nodded, eager for her departure. As soon as Victoria left, he retreated to his bedroom and resumed his video game session, seeking solace from his friends.

Ari's voice echoed through the headset as he spoke to his friends while playing. "Guys, I don't think I can play for

too long tonight. I have to meet up with my physics professor or I'm going to fail the class." His determination to pass the class represented his desire to escape Victoria, Glendale and her dream of him becoming a mailman.

His friends groaned in unison, realizing that their virtual adventure would be cut short. "Come on, man, we need you tonight," Bubby protested.

"I know, I know," Ari said, his eyes fixed on the screen as he navigated the virtual world. "But I've got to pass this class or I won't ever get outta this place."

As he continued playing, the power began to flicker, causing his game to freeze and stutter. The outages grew more frequent, creating an eerie atmosphere in the dimly lit room. It was highly unusual for the power to go out in Victoria's home, as she had installed a backup generator years ago during a massive thunderstorm that had left the house without power. Victoria couldn't bear to see her paintings not lit up under the hundreds of spotlights that littered the house, each one illuminating her so-called genius works.

Ari decided to check the generator, which was located in a narrow outdoor portion of the house that required a small climb. As a child, Ari developed an unusual talent for hiding in the most unexpected places. He could fit into every crevice and climb atop the large antiques in Victoria's home, making him nearly impossible to find during games of hide and seek. This skill seemed rather useless to

Victoria, who preferred to play the game from the comfort of her couch with her lizard-looking feet elevated for an at-home pedicure. Using his unique skill, Ari nimbly navigated his way to the generator.

Upon reaching the generator, Ari discovered something very odd happening. The generator appeared to be working in reverse, sending all of the electricity back out of the house and into the grid. He paused for a moment, perplexed by the bizarre occurrence, and thought, "What the heck is going on here?"

Finally, the power went out entirely, plunging Ari's room into darkness. He couldn't help but feel that this was a sign, an omen from the universe, urging him to start out on his own.

Confused and reminded of his meeting with Professor Raventhorpe, Ari grabbed his backpack and prepared to leave, hoping that this extra credit opportunity might be the key to unlocking a future beyond Victoria's control.

Little did he know that his decision, driven by his quiet resolve, would soon lead him down a path of remarkable discoveries that would forever change the course of his life. As he pedaled through the streets, the power flickered back on, bathing the houses in a warm glow. But the relief was short-lived as the power went out again, plunging the streets into darkness. This time, however, Ari heard a loud, unfamiliar sound. The noise grew louder, and Ari's heart rate began to quicken. He couldn't quite make out where

the sound was coming from, but it was definitely getting closer.

He pedaled faster, the sound growing louder with each passing moment. It was a low rumble, like an old diesel engine. The shadows seemed to reach out towards him, and Ari felt as though he was being followed. He glanced over his shoulder, but he couldn't see anything in the darkness.

"Who's there?" he yelled over his shoulder but he heard nothing in return. Suddenly, the power came back on, and the sound faded away. Ari let out a sigh of relief, but he couldn't shake the feeling that something wasn't right. He pedaled faster towards the school, eager to get to the safety of his physics class. As he rode, he kept his eyes and ears peeled for any sign of what he was hearing.

As Ari pedaled onward, the power outages transformed into a mesmerizing light show, with the streetlights flickering on and off in a rhythmic dance. He couldn't help but notice that the mysterious rumbling sound seemed to harmonize with this peculiar symphony of light. As the lights glowed brighter, the deep, bone-shaking rumble crescendoed, only to fade away as the darkness returned. This eerie synchronization sent shivers down Ari's spine, making him wonder if there was some hidden force orchestrating these events. The sound seemed to be coming from the direction of the school.

Another odd thing was there were no cars on the road. As he got closer, the power outages became more frequent,

and the sound grew louder until it was almost deafening. He felt a chill run down his spine, and for the first time, he considered turning back. But the thought of his bedroom, lined with paintings of Victoria compelled him forward. Plus he wanted to know what was causing this disturbance.

The sound was unlike anything Ari had ever heard before. It was a low rumble, like the growl of a massive beast in hibernation, building in intensity and then abruptly cutting off. It was as though some great power source was struggling to ignite, only to fizzle out moments later. Ari couldn't shake the feeling that the sound was coming from deep within the earth, as though some ancient machinery had been activated after eons of dormancy. It was a sound that made the hair on the back of his neck stand on end, and left him with an uneasy feeling in the pit of his stomach.

As he reached the school, the strange sound grew louder than ever, making Ari's heart race. The power outages continued, but this time, when the power went out, one light remained on. This was strange; on his way over to the school, all the lights had gone out when the power failed.

As his eyes adjusted to the darkness, he could see where it coming from. The science wing of Kasdan High School.

The Anytime Elevator

The red brick walls of Kasdan High School loomed in the twilight, their arched windows casting sinister shadows as the power outages continued to plague the city. In the moments when the lights flickered back to life, the school briefly returned to its familiar appearance, but the ominous feeling refused to disperse. Ari navigated the school parking lot by muscle memory, his sense of direction toyed with by the sporadic darkness. His attention was drawn to an odd glow emanating from one of the buildings – a

strong, pulsating orange and yellow light that overrode his fear and kindled his curiosity.

"Is it fire?" He wondered out loud but it seemed entirely different — More like an energy pulse. As Ari approached the science lab, the source of the mysterious light, he noticed the door was ajar. He hesitated, his heart racing as muffled voices emanated from within the dark room. "Is that the Professor?" he murmured to himself. Despite his trepidation, Ari felt compelled to investigate. He parked his bike, took a deep breath, and stepped into the deserted school building.

The persistent hum of machinery filled the air as Ari made his way down the dark, deserted halls. As he neared the lab, the sound grew louder and more disconcerting. The flickering fluorescent lights cast eerie shadows on the walls, and Ari could feel his heart pounding in his chest. He had to cover his ears as the deafening hum threatened to make his head ring. Though he couldn't identify the source of his unease, he knew something was terribly wrong.

The lab door creaked as Ari pushed it open, peering inside. "Professor?" he called cautiously. The room was bathed in an eerie blue light, its source a large, strange-looking machine in the center of the room. The bizarre contraption consisted of wires and gears and glowing lights, both fascinating and terrifying. Ari could sense a presence in the room, a tangible force that made his skin crawl. Taking a step forward, the floorboards creaked

beneath his feet, the sound echoing through the silent room and momentarily drowning out the hum of the machine. "Professor?" he called again, his voice stronger.

A faint rustling sound betrayed the presence of another person in the room. Ari's heart leapt into his throat as he realized he was not alone. He backed up slowly, his eyes fixed on the machine in the center of the room. He couldn't shake the feeling that something was about to happen. Suddenly, the machine whirred to life, and a blinding light filled the room. Ari shielded his eyes, stumbling backwards as the light grew brighter and brighter. And then, just as suddenly as it had started, it stopped. The room was plunged into darkness once again, the only sound the furious pounding of Ari's heart.

As the machine's doors slid open like an elevator, Ari was struck by disbelief. The display was winding through numbers at an impossibly fast pace before settling on "ANY:TIME". What kind of contraption was this? His shock was short-lived, however, as the second door creaked open to reveal Professor Raventhorpe, with his chinchilla Julius perched atop his head like a fuzzy crown. Raventhorpe looked equally surprised to see Ari, as if he had completely forgotten their arrangement.

"Ari, my boy! I had forgotten you were coming by tonight," the professor said, beaming. "But, as they say, the more the merrier!" Ari couldn't help but feel unnerved by the professor's cheery demeanor. "What the heck is going

on here, professor? This thing has been taking out the power in the entire city!"

Raventhorpe chuckled without breaking a beat as he pickup up an instrument from his toolbox and began tightening bolts on the side of the machine. "Yes, yes, that was...the intention. It's all part of the experiment."

"Experiment? What experiment?" Ari demanded, growing more frustrated by the second.

The professor leaned in, a mischievous twinkle in his eye. "The extra credit, my boy. It has everything to do with the extra credit."

Ari's heart sank. "So this was all just some crazy experiment for my extra credit?"

Raventhorpe nodded, still smiling. "Indeed it was, my dear boy. Plus, Julius and I could use all the help we can get."

"Well what the heck is that thing?" asked Ari.

"Yes, my boy. The Anytime Elevator is a marvel of modern technology. It's the culmination of years of research and development. With it, we can explore the past and future of our universe, witness history in the making, and perhaps even change it."

Ari stared at Raventhorpe with a mixture of confusion and disbelief. "Wait, The Anytime Elevator? You're telling me this thing can travel through time? To any place in the universe?"

Raventhorpe's eyes glinted with an intensity that Ari

had never seen before. He stood there, hands clasped behind his back, his gaze fixed on the Anytime Elevator with a mixture of pride and sadness. "This," he said, "is the culmination of my entire life's research."

Ari was struck by the professor's passion and conviction.

Ari shook his head, still trying to wrap his mind around what he was hearing. "But...how is that possible?"

Raventhorpe chuckled. "Ah, you see, the elevator doesn't actually move through space-time in the traditional sense. Instead, it shifts the temporal coordinates of its passengers, transporting them through the many floors of the universe to their desired destination. Kinda like a temporal elevator. Hence the name."

Ari's eyes widened. "Right...So you're saying you can just...go anywhere? Anytime? Like the name."

"Indeed, my boy. The possibilities are endless. We could witness the birth of the universe, the fall of empires, the invention of groundbreaking technologies. The possibilities are truly limitless."

Ari's mind raced with excitement and fear. The idea of traveling through time was both exhilarating and terrifying. He couldn't help but wonder what kind of consequences such a device could have.

"But...what about the risks? What if we change something in the past and it alters the course of history? You know all of the time travel stuff in the movies. More importantly, what about the extra credit. I need to pass this

class.”

Raventhorpe waved a dismissive hand. “Nonsense, my boy. The universe has a way of balancing itself out and you’ll pass physics with flying colors.”

Despite his reservations, Ari found the prospect of exploring time and space too tantalizing to pass up. He took a deep breath and nodded. "Alright. Let's do it. A small experiment sounds like a good way to get the extra credit."

Raventhorpe grinned, his eyes sparkling with excitement. "Excellent. Now, you might be asking yourself, where to first? The dawn of civilization? The far future? The possibilities are endless...Be that as it may, we have a much simpler maiden voyage in mind."

"What?" Ari asked as Raventhorpe ushered him inside the elevator.

The display on the elevator changed from "ANY:TIME" to "2023", causing Ari's heart to skip a beat. He couldn't believe what he was seeing.

“See Ari we’re currently on the 2023 floor of the universe inside Kasdan High School.” As they stepped inside the elevator, Ari couldn't help but notice the clock he had knocked over earlier, fixed to the back of the elevator internals.

"Hey, that's the clock from earlier." Ari asked, still in shock.

“Yes this clock is the centerpiece of The Anytime

Elevator. Keeps great time,” said Raventhorpe as he wiped his hand over the glass trying to smudge out the crack from earlier.

Ari looked at Raventhorpe and Julius, who were both grinning from ear to ear with a sense of excitement and anticipation that was infectious. Ari found himself unable to resist their enthusiasm, and he felt a thrill of excitement building in his chest. He felt like one of the video game characters in “Far Away” but different because this was real and it was really happening to him.

“And Julius here will do the honors,” said Raventhorpe.

“What happened last time you guys tried it?” asked Ari.

Julius, perched on top of Raventhorpe's head, jumped down and landed on a button, causing the elevator to start coming to life.

“It exploded.”

“What?” Ari screamed as he tried to squirm free but it was too late. He looked over to see Raventhorpe's face, illuminated by the flickering lights of the elevator, was a sight to behold. His eyes, usually obscured by his thick eyebrows, seemed to light up with a spark of excitement. Ari could see the professor's mind racing, his thoughts churning with the possibilities of what lay ahead. Despite his previous doubts about the man, Ari couldn't help but feel a tinge of respect for the passion that was now emanating from him.

As the elevator doors slid closed with a clang.

Raventhorpe let out a small chuckle before speaking in a deep, commanding voice. "Goodbye Kasdan. Going down!"

It was as if he was an elevator operator in a grand hotel, announcing the departure of his esteemed guests from their current floor. Ari couldn't help but feel a sense of apprehension mixed with excitement, as if he was about to embark on the adventure of a lifetime. A charging sound, growing in intensity move from bottom to top in the elevator. The elevator lurched downward, and the floor beneath them seemed to drop away as they hurtled into the unknown.

"Don't worry Ari it's just the Universe. It's what we're made out of ya know!"

Ari's stomach churned as the feeling of falling intensified, like being on a rollercoaster or a hilly country road. The walls of the elevator began to shimmer and blur, and Ari felt as though he was being pulled in a million different directions at once. The sound of the machine was deafening, and Ari's heart pounded in his chest as the elevator began to move.

"I want 100 on the final exam!" screamed Ari.

"Done deal," said Raventhorpe, "now enjoy this Ari, you're alive and on one hell of a ride."

He looked around in awe as the walls of the elevator became a blur, and the sound of the machine grew louder and louder. He wondered where they were going and what

they were going to see. He couldn't believe that this was happening - that he was actually traveling through time and space.

The elevator jolted to life with a sudden burst of energy, and they all screamed as they were thrown around inside the small space. Ari's mind raced as he tried to process what was happening. Was this really happening? Was he really flying through time and space with his physics professor and a chinchilla on his head? He felt like he was in some kind of fever dream.

The elevator was hurtling through the floors of the universe, and Ari couldn't see anything outside of the small window on the door. He closed his eyes and braced himself for the worst. This was it; he was going to die in some kind of time-traveling mishap.

But suddenly, there was a loud ding, and the elevator came to a sudden stop. They all stumbled and fell to the floor. Ari's head was spinning as he looked up at the display on the wall, which now read "1817."

Raventhorpe turned to Julius and let out a loud whoop of joy. "We're still alive!" he shouted.

Ari groaned and rubbed his head. "What the hell just happened? Does that 1817 mean what I think it does?" he asked.

Raventhorpe turned to him, a huge grin on his face. "We're here."

The Great Belzoni

The sun beat down on the hot desert expanse, casting a harsh glare on the mountains of sand that towered above like giants. The sand whipped into the air, creating a yellow haze that bled into everything one could see. Tropical palm trees dotted the landscape, their green leaves swaying gently in the breeze. The air was thick with the smell of spices and sweat, and the sounds of camels and men haggling in a foreign tongue filled the air. It was a place of mystery and wonder, a land where time seemed to stand

still and ancient secrets lay hidden beneath the shifting sands.

The Luxor Nile port in 1817 was a bustling hub of activity, despite its remote location in the middle of the desert. Boats of all sizes and shapes were moored at the docks, while their crews unloaded cargo and made repairs. Men from all over Europe and, for that matter, the world could be seen milling about, clad in exotic clothing that hinted at their far-flung origins. The sound of shouting and clanging filled the ears. This was a place where fortunes could be made or lost in an instant, and where danger lurked around every corner.

Amidst the hustle and bustle of port workers and merchants, a hulking figure emerged from an Italian ship's ramp. Giovanni Battista Belzoni towered over the crowd, his broad shoulders and barrel chest making him an imposing figure. He seemed as wide as he was tall and wore a rugged explorer's outfit, complete with a pith helmet and a canvas vest adorned with all manner of pouches and straps. Beside him, his British wife Sarah Belzoni emerged, looking just as intrepid as her husband. They both surveyed their surroundings with a sense of purpose and determination, as if the vast expanse of sand and palm trees held all the answers to their quest. Giovanni leaned in to his wife, his voice low and rumbling as he spoke, "This is it, my love. The land of treasures untold. The land of the pharaohs. This is where we will find it. It's good to be

back.”

He seemed a man of immense strength, capable of lifting twenty men with ease. In his hand, a bullwhip coiled like a serpent, ready to strike at a moment's notice. The mere sight of him sent a shiver down the spines of the onlookers, who knew this man was not to be trifled with as his reputation proceeded him.

Yet, behind the burning determination in their eyes, a hidden motive simmered beneath the surface. Giovanni Battista Belzoni sought not only wealth but also recognition; he yearned to leave a lasting legacy in the annals of history, to be remembered as a man who discovered the secrets of the ancient world. His wife, Sarah, shared this desire, hoping to challenge the expectations of her time and prove her worth in a male-dominated field. Their pursuit of the Tiara of Nefertari was not merely for personal gain, but also a way to cement their names in history.

Sarah Belzoni, with her striking features and sharp tongue, was a woman not to be trifled with. As an Englishwoman married to the great tomb raider, she had tasted the sweet intoxication of power and the thrill of capturing ancient treasures. Her blonde locks cascaded down her shoulders, framing her delicate features, while her eyes sparkled with a fierce determination. Sarah was not content to merely be a spectator in her husband's adventures; she was a force to be reckoned with, and woe

to any man who dared underestimate her. She could hold her own in any situation, whether it be a heated debate or a fierce battle, and her wit was as sharp as the knives her husband used to open ancient tombs. For Sarah Belzoni, the world was her playground, and the treasures of the ancient world were hers for the taking.

“Yes, you mean we as in, all of us, right?” Said James Curtin in an Irish accent. To which Belzoni didn’t respond.

James Curtin was a small man, no more than five and a half feet tall, with a sharp wit and an even sharper tongue. He hailed from the Emerald Isle and had a thick Irish brogue that only grew thicker when he had a pint or two. Despite his small stature, James was a formidable figure, and his intellect was his greatest weapon. He was a master at finding and recruiting henchmen for Belzoni's tomb raiding expeditions, using his charm and wit to persuade even the most reluctant of souls to join their cause. With his piercing blue eyes and wild, curly red hair, James was an invaluable member of Belzoni's team.

Belzoni glared at James, his gaze heavy enough to sink most ships and Curtin relented not to mention it again.

As Belzoni walked onto the dock, the hulking figure stopped most in their tracks just to get a glimpse of the giant. His reputation preceded him.

Belzoni was a legend among the tomb raiders in 1800’s Egypt. He had a way of getting out of danger that no one else could quite replicate. In one story, he was attacked by a

group of bandits while camping in the desert. They came at him with swords and daggers, but Belzoni used his brute strength to fight them off, sending them all fleeing into the night. In another, he was double-crossed by his own hired men, but he was able to outsmart them and escape with the treasure.

Kings and queens were fascinated by him and his odd ideas. One such idea was to steal a several ton statue of Ramses from the Valley of the Kings for the British Museum where it remains to this very day, an undertaking that many thought was impossible. But Belzoni was undaunted, and he managed to do it with the help of hundreds of local workers. His reputation as a daring adventurer and explorer only grew with each passing year.

James slid past him on the dock and began speaking to a local merchant who turned and ran into the crowd. Belzoni stood scanning the crowds for any sign of their henchmen. In the distance, they saw a group of men riding towards them on camels. The henchmen dismounted from their camels and approached Belzoni, who stood tall and imposing with his bullwhip in hand.

Belzoni addressed the group with a commanding voice. "Listen up, men. You all know who I am, and what I'm capable of. I'm not here to make friends or exchange pleasantries. We have a job to do, and we're going to do it. But let me be clear: anyone who crosses me will suffer the consequences. I'm looking for Henry Salt, and I want him

found. Anyone who can lead us to him will be greatly rewarded. But remember, if you try to deceive me, you'll regret it."

The henchmen looked intimidated but also impressed by Belzoni's confidence and power. No one dared double cross The Great Belzoni, at least while he was awake. They nodded in agreement and began to load the equipment onto the camels. Sarah and James watched in amazement as Belzoni took charge and led the group towards their next adventure. They knew that with Belzoni at the helm, they were in good hands.

One of the henchman approached Belzoni, his eyes darting nervously around the group of henchmen. "I know where Henry Salt is," he said, his voice barely above a whisper.

Belzoni turned to face him, his expression unreadable. "And why should I believe you?"

The man swallowed hard. "I swear it on my life, sir. I overheard some men talking about him in a tavern last night. They said he's holed up in the Valley of the Kings. My friend will meet us there and guide us to Henry Salt."

Belzoni studied the man for a moment, then nodded. "Lead us there. And if you're lying, you won't live to regret it."

The man nodded, relief washing over his face. "Yes, sir. I won't let you down."

Belzoni turned to his henchmen. "We have work to do."

The men moved quickly, gathering Belzoni's gear and loading up the camels. Soon they were on the move, following the man through the winding paths in the desert.

As Belzoni and his men rode out towards the Valley of the Kings, Sarah couldn't help but wonder how he could be so certain that Henry Salt would be of value in what they were seeking. She voiced her concerns to Belzoni, who responded with a chuckle.

"My dear, you underestimate the power of connections and rumors in this line of work," he said, his deep voice carrying across the desert. "Salt may not have the information himself, but I have it on good authority that he knows someone who does. And if he doesn't, well, we'll simply have to convince him to find out."

Sarah nodded, understanding that Belzoni's methods were sometimes unorthodox, but always effective. She knew better than to question his judgement, and instead focused on scanning the horizon for any signs of trouble. The desert was beautiful but unforgiving, and they were far from any civilization.

As they continued their journey, Belzoni led the group to a secret location he had discovered during a previous expedition. It was a small cave hidden within the vast desert landscape, its entrance nearly indistinguishable from the surrounding rocks. Belzoni dismounted from his camel, motioning for the others to stay back as he ventured inside.

"Wait here," he said and his massive frame disappeared

through the cracks and was gone.

Inside the dimly lit cave, Belzoni slid a boulder which must have weighed 500 pounds out the way and retrieved a set of ancient scrolls, hidden away from prying eyes. He carefully unrolled the scrolls, his eyes scanning the ancient hieroglyphics and illustrations. Among the depictions of gods and pharaohs, there was an unmistakable image of the crown resting upon the head of a beautiful queen. Belzoni's eyes lit up with excitement as he traced his fingers along the ancient text, a grin forming on his face.

He reappeared and they continued their quest through the desert.

"What was that about?" asked James, trying to get a glimpse of what Belzoni had found.

Belzoni simply smiled, keeping the scrolls close to his chest. "Just a little something to help us with our mission," he replied cryptically, mounting his camel once more. "Now, let's not waste any more time. Onward to the Valley of the Kings!"

"Giovanni, aren't you even gonna tell me what this is all about?" Curtain rattled off from a camel behind him.

Belzoni reached into his coat and pulled out a small leather case. He flipped it open to reveal a drawing of a crown that glinted in the light. It was one of the most beautiful things that James Curtain had ever seen. Solid gold with intricate designs and sparkling jewels, it looked incredibly expensive. Belzoni held the drawing up to the

light and gazed at it with a look of intense concentration. "This," he said, "is what we're after. And I know that Salt knows where it is." He closed the case and tucked it back into his coat. James stared at him in awe. Despite all the danger and uncertainty, he couldn't help feeling a thrill of excitement at the thought of what they might find.

"This thing's gotta be worth a fortune. Now we're talking. Drinks are on me tonight boys!" yelled Curtain to a group of cheering henchman.

"What's it called? Whose is it?" asked Curtain.

Belzoni listened to James Curtain with a furrowed brow, contemplating his words for a moment before raising a hand to his lips, taking a swig of fine wine from his chalice. He let out a low growl, his dark eyes sparkling with an intense fire as he spoke. "It's the Tiara of Nefertari," he said slowly, his voice deep and menacing.

"And soon it will be ours."

With those words, he threw his head back and let out an evil, maniacal laugh, the sound echoing across the desert sands. The other men looked at him with a mixture of awe and fear, knowing that he would stop at nothing.

Floor 1817

The Anytime Elevator jolted to a sudden halt, and Ari's stomach lurched with a sickening feeling of weightlessness. He was flung into the air before landing back on his feet with a thud. The harsh sound of metal grinding against metal filled the air as the elevator settled, and sparks flew from the control panel. Panic set in as Ari realized they were no longer in the safety of the modern world, and the thought of being stranded in an unfamiliar place gripped him with fear. His throat felt raw, and he realized he had

been screaming without even knowing it. His heart raced as he tried to make sense of the situation, but the unfamiliar surroundings left him feeling disoriented and vulnerable.

As Ari's screams subsided, he looked around the elevator, disoriented and confused.

"We're here," Raventhorpe announced, his voice filled with excitement.

Ari looked at him incredulously. "Where is here?"

Raventhorpe gestured to the wall. "The beginning of the rest of your life."

Ari's face contorted with disbelief as Raventhorpe smiled enigmatically, and the door slid open. "Welcome to..."

Julius squeaked with disappointment as Raventhorpe stepped forward and opened the elevator door, revealing a golden sandstone wall.

"Well, that was anticlimactic," said Raventhorpe.

"Wait, what? Where..." Ari stammered.

"Egypt, apparently."

Ari's face went blank. "Egypt? How'd we get all the way to Egypt? We were in there for ten seconds."

"We were in there for over two hundred years," said Raventhorpe without skipping a beat.

"What?" exclaimed Ari, and he glanced at the elevator in a feeble attempt to figure out what was going on.

"Well, we traveled over two hundred years, so technically we were in there for...well, you get it," Raventhorpe said.

Ari's heart raced as he looked up at the floor indicator on the elevator. "1817" glared back at him, mocking his disbelief. He couldn't believe it. Ancient Egypt? Time travel? It all seemed so surreal. He tried to wrap his head around the fact that he was standing in a rocky valley with barely any sun, surrounded by towering walls, in a time long gone. His mind couldn't make sense of the situation, but his body knew it was in danger. His palms were slick with sweat, his heart pounded against his chest like a hammer against steel. He was scared, but more than that, he was angry. Angry at Raventhorpe for dragging him into this mess, angry at himself for getting caught up in the professor's wild schemes. He needed to find a way out of this and fast. But as he looked around at the vast expanse of ancient Egypt, he knew that escape was not going to be easy.

"We—we--we—we—we—we—we—" stammered Ari.

Julius, who was sitting atop Raventhorpe's shoulder, braced his little paw on his ear and laughed hysterically.

"Time traveled? We—in—that?!" Exclaimed Ari.

Raventhorpe let out a deep breath, his eyes fixed on the ancient walls surrounding them. For a moment, he was lost in thought, marveling at the sheer impossibility of their situation. Then, his attention snapped back to the elevator, and he turned to Ari with a broad grin on his face.

"That's right, Ari," he said, his voice booming with pride. "The Anytime Elevator. I designed it myself."

Julius shrieked in disagreement.

"Sorry, Julius and I designed it." said Raventhorpe as he mopped his brow. "And I can't believe it actually worked!" He chuckled, almost in disbelief, and attempted to run a hand through his wild and matted beard.

He turned back to the elevator, his eyes scanning over it carefully, as if he were expecting it to suddenly vanish into thin air. "I mean, I knew the theories were sound, but I never imagined it would actually work. This changes everything."

Raventhorpe's excitement was palpable, his whole body practically vibrating with energy.

Ari's mind was reeling, trying to come to terms with the fact that he had just time-traveled. He needed reassurance, so he asked the question once more, "And it worked?" He hoped that maybe he had just imagined the whole thing and was still in the elevator, back in his own time.

Raventhorpe replied, "Appears so," with a slight shrug of his shoulders. Julius, however, was quick to chime in with a high-pitched squeak of admonishment. Raventhorpe shot him a look, then said, "It's not like I intentionally landed us here, Julius."

The two began to bicker, and Ari felt like he was in the middle of a weird dream. He tried to focus on what was happening, as Raventhorpe finally addressed his question.

"Ok, ok, ok," Ari said, trying to cut through the arguing, "you're going to take us back to Glendale, right?"

"Absolutely," Raventhorpe replied, his voice calm and reassuring, "just give me a second."

Ari felt a glimmer of hope, but as he looked around at the desolate valley, he couldn't shake the feeling that something was wrong.

Raventhorpe and Julius huddled around the Anytime Elevator, inspecting its inner workings. Every once in a while, Julius let out a high-pitched squeak, as if he was making some important observation. Raventhorpe nodded his head and continued pulling and tugging at various parts of the machine.

Suddenly, sparks began to shoot out of the side of the elevator,

"Uh oh," said Raventhorpe bent over studying the source of sparks.

"Uh oh? What do you mean uh oh?" Ari asked, but Raventhorpe was too focused on the elevator to answer him right away.

After a moment, Raventhorpe dusted off his hands and turned to face Ari. "Well, Ari, we have good news and bad. Which do you want first?"

Ari thought for a moment, then said, "Good. No, bad. Wait no, good. Bad. Give me the bad."

Raventhorpe's face took on a grave expression. "We're not going anywhere for at least a couple of days."

Ari's heart sank. "Couple of days?! Oh man, Victoria's gonna kill me. What's the good news?"

Raventhorpe brightened up a bit. "The good news is we get to explore 1800s Egypt. Isn't that exciting?"

Ari's face fell. "No, no, no, no, we have to go home."

Raventhorpe placed a hand on Ari's shoulder. "Don't worry, as soon as the Anytime Elevator is back up and running, we'll just return to the exact moment of departure. It'll be like you never left. It's a foolproof plan."

Ari wasn't convinced. "Yeah, and I'm the fool."

Ari couldn't believe he was stuck in 1817 Egypt with Professor Raventhorpe, a man he hardly knew and now distrusted. In his mind he went from stuck in Glendale, shackled Victoria's beck and whim to stuck in a different and perhaps more dangerous time. How had he let himself get dragged into this mess?

Maybe Victoria was right and he should have just been a mailman. What was he thinking? Was the extra credit really worth all of this? He should have known better than to trust a man who claimed to have invented a time-traveling elevator. It was insane, and yet here they were, stranded in a strange land with no way home.

Raventhorpe had been acting strange since they arrived, as if he knew something that Ari didn't. And the fact that they were stuck here, for days or potentially forever, made him even more suspicious.

Was Raventhorpe telling the truth about the elevator being broken down? Or had he deliberately sabotaged it to trap them here? The situation was so bizarre that he

couldn't help but wonder. He looked around at the peaks and saw what looked like mini-caves cut in perfect rectangular, door-way sized holes all along the canyon. It certainly didn't look like Glendale or feel like it. Somehow the place managed to threaten both immense heat and winter cold within minutes of each other.

A sense of calm began to wash over him as he looked out at the breathtaking scenery before him, he couldn't help but feel a sense of wonder and excitement. Deep down he knew it what the professor had told him was true. He was in ancient Egypt. He thought about the power outages and how it had beckoned him to Raventhorpe's lab like an omen from the universe and the pain he had felt for so long being under Victoria's judgmental nose. In this place, standing just a few meters from his physics professor and a cobbled together service elevator in the depths of an Egyptian valley, Ari felt free.

Just then, Julius climbed up his leg and hopped onto his shoulder and squeaked in a reassuring way and Ari relaxed slightly. He gazed out at the ancient ruins and the endless expanse of sand, Ari felt a mix of fear and excitement wash over him. He didn't want to let his guard down around Raventhorpe, couldn't let himself be fooled by the professor's wild schemes. He was determined to make it back to his own time, to his own life, no matter how impossible it seemed.

Raventhorpe stood up, dusting off his hands while

looking at the high peaks that towered over their heads, muttering. "Alright, now help me find a way out of here Ari. We need to get a better look at this place."

Henry Salt

Henry Salt sat in his luxurious tent, surrounded by the spoils of his conquests. The thick canvas walls were adorned with priceless artifacts and ancient relics, collected from the dusty tombs and crumbling ruins of the Valley of the Kings. The air was filled with the scent of exotic spices and the faint aroma of frankincense, adding to the sense of mystery and intrigue that permeated the space.

Salt, a tall, lean man with piercing blue eyes, sat at a large oak table covered in maps, scrolls, and notes. His role as the

leader of the raiders was to bring back as many Egyptian antiquities as possible to the British Museum, and he excelled at it. He had a reputation for being ruthless and cunning, willing to do whatever it took to get his hands on the treasures of the pharaohs.

The tent itself was a marvel of modern engineering, with intricate patterns and designs woven into the fabric. It was furnished with plush carpets, comfortable chairs, and a massive four-poster bed, fit for a king. Outside, the sun beat down relentlessly on the vast desert landscape, shimmering with heat waves and mirages.

Salt sipped a cup of strong coffee, his eyes flickering over the maps and charts spread out before him. He was planning his next move, searching for a new tomb to plunder. Treasure hunting in Egypt in 1817 was a dangerous game indeed, but one that he relished. The thrill of the hunt, the excitement of the chase, the satisfaction of victory – it was all worth the risk.

As he sat there, surrounded by the wealth and opulence, he couldn't help but feel a sense of awe at the power and majesty of the ancient Egyptian civilization. These people had built great pyramids and temples, created art and literature that had stood the test of time. And now, Salt and his team were here to take it all for themselves.

Suddenly, the sound of approaching footsteps drew Salt's attention. He sat up straight, his eyes narrowing as he recognized the familiar silhouette of Giovanni Battista

Belzoni cast on the outside of the tent followed by, Sarah Belzoni, James Curtin, and their henchman. He knew that their presence could only mean trouble, and he braced himself for the worst.

Belzoni was a towering figure, his size dwarfing Salt and intimidating him. As he stormed into the tent, Salt could see Belzoni's face was twisted in anger, and Salt knew the fury simmering just beneath the surface could erupt at any second. He knew that whatever Belzoni wanted, it was not going to be good news.

"How may I help you Giovanni?" Salt asked, his voice trembling slightly despite his efforts to remain composed.

Belzoni's face twisted into a sneer as he stepped forward, his henchman flanking him on either side. "What do I want? I want what's rightfully mine, Salt. The credit for the antiquities that I've uncovered for your precious British Museum."

Salt's heart sank at the mention of the museum. He knew that Belzoni had carved his name into half of the artifacts he had found for the British Museum, it was clear the museum's deal with the Italian explorer had not been enough to appease him.

"I assure you, Belzoni, the museum values your contributions greatly," Salt said, trying to calm the raging explorer.

Belzoni snorted. "Values my contributions? I think not. You have no idea the risks I've taken, the dangers I've

faced, all for what? A meager paycheck and a few scraps of recognition? I deserve more, Salt. I deserve to be remembered as the greatest explorer of this age."

Salt swallowed hard, knowing that Belzoni's anger was not going to be easily quelled. He had hoped that the Italian explorer wanted only credit, but it seemed that he was after much more.

"How did you even find me?" Salt asked, his mind racing to come up with a solution.

Belzoni smirked. "Oh, we have our ways. Let's just say that the desert is full of secrets, Salt."

Salt's stomach churned at the thought of Belzoni and his henchmen lurking around in the shadows, watching his every move. He knew that he was in a precarious position, and that he needed to find a way out before things turned violent.

"I understand your frustrations, Belzoni," Salt said, trying to reason with the angry explorer. "But we can't just go changing the terms of our agreement now. It's not fair to the museum, or to the other explorers we've partnered with."

Belzoni sneered again. "Fairness? Who cares about fairness, Salt? The only thing that matters is power. And right now, I hold all the cards."

Salt's heart sank as Belzoni's words echoed in his head. He knew that he was in trouble, and that he needed to find a way out before it was too late. But with Belzoni looming

over him like a giant, his options were limited.

"What is it you want, Belzoni?" Salt asked, his voice trembling with fear. He knew Belzoni was a notorious tomb raider, and he feared for his life.

Giovanni Belzoni slammed the drawing of the Tiara of Nefertari onto the table in front of Henry Salt, his beady eyes fixed on the Englishman. Salt, eager to get Belzoni out of his hair, reluctantly listened to the Italian's demands.

"I want the map to the Tiara of Nefertari," Belzoni growled, his massive frame looming over Salt. "I know you have it, and I want it."

Salt hesitated for a moment, but the fear in his eyes was palpable. "I don't know what you're talking about," he said weakly.

Belzoni's eyes narrowed. "Don't play games with me, Salt. I know you have the map. And I know you keep it in that locked treasure chest over there," he said, pointing to a corner of the tent.

Salt gulped. He knew there was no use in denying it any longer. He retrieved the key and unlocked the chest, revealing the map inside.

Belzoni snatched it up eagerly, his fingers tracing the lines and symbols on the parchment. "Ah, yes," he said with a smile. "This will do nicely."

As Belzoni rolled up the map and tucked it into his coat, he glanced around Salt's luxurious tent, taking in the priceless artifacts and ancient relics surrounding him. With

a cruel smile, he addressed Salt, "You may have taken credit for my previous finds, but the Tiara of Nefertari will be the discovery that solidifies my name in history."

Salt's eyes widened at Belzoni's words, realizing the Italian explorer's determination to prove himself.

Belzoni continued, "My father was a humble barber who dreamed of unearthing lost treasures and making great discoveries. He always believed that the greatest treasures were still hidden, waiting to be found. But he never had the chance to pursue his passion and make his mark on history. I refuse to let that be my fate."

With that, Belzoni stormed out of the tent, leaving Salt to contemplate the depth of the rivalry he had ignited and the lengths to which Belzoni was willing to go in order to claim his rightful recognition.

Mahgdi

Ari, Raventhorpe, and Julius made their way up the treacherous path leading to the summit of the Valley of the Kings. The sun bore down on them, yet as they ascended, the air grew crisp and cold in the shadows of the towering peaks. Ari was grateful for the respite from the heat, but he shivered as the wind whipped around him, sending chills down his spine. Without knowing, he had come prepared for the climb, wearing a hooded sweatshirt that was perfect for the sudden shift in temperature.

Raventhorpe, on the other hand, seemed unfazed by the cold. He still wore his strange yellow trench coat, which flapped wildly in the wind, almost as if it were alive. Ari wondered how the professor could stand the chill, but he pushed the thought aside and focused on the climb ahead.

As they ascended higher, the path grew more perilous, with steep drops and loose rocks threatening to send them tumbling to their deaths. Raventhorpe, always quick with an excuse, insisted that Ari go first in the dangerous spots, claiming that he needed to observe Ari's technique for future reference. Ari knew better than to trust the professor's excuses, but he was relieved to have someone else leading the way.

As they climbed higher, Ari felt a sense of awe at the sheer size and majesty of the ancient peaks surrounding them. He had never seen anything like it before, and he wondered what secrets lay hidden within the valley. But his thoughts were quickly interrupted as Raventhorpe called out to him, pointing to a particularly treacherous spot ahead.

"Looks like you're up, Ari," he said with a sly grin.

Ari gritted his teeth and stepped forward, trying to block out the fear and focus on the climb ahead. With each step, his heart pounded in his chest, and he could feel the wind tugging at his sweatshirt, threatening to send him off balance. But he pushed on, determined to make it to the top.

As they climbed higher and higher, the wind grew stronger, and the air grew colder. Ari wondered what lay waiting for them at the top, but he pushed the thought aside and focused on the climb ahead. He knew that whatever awaited them, they would face it together.

“Hey professor aren’t you cold?” Ari asked as Raventhorpe’s coat flapped in the wind.

“No, I don’t have time to be,” the professor said. He seemed to be enjoying the climb.

They came upon a wooden structure, that spiraled upwards over the top of the valley peaks.

“Up there Ari,” said Raventhorpe over the howling winds, “that’s where we’ll get the view we need.”

Its rickety structure creaked in the wind as they walked up what seemed like dozens of flights of wooden stairs until they reached the top. Ari stood, marveling at the sweeping view of the desert. The vast expanse of sandy dunes seemed to stretch out endlessly before him, punctuated only by the blazing sun that beat down relentlessly from above.

Ari finally reached the top of the tower, sweat dripping from his brow, and stared out over the seemingly endless expanse of rolling dunes. "It's nothing but desert," he muttered to himself.

As Ari caught his breath, Raventhorpe and Julius joined him at the summit, both panting heavily from the climb.

"Ari, not that way," Raventhorpe gasped, pointing to the view behind them.

Curious, Ari walked over to the other ledge and stopped in his tracks, utterly amazed by the sight before him. "Whoa..."

Raventhorpe grinned, his eyes sparkling with excitement. "We did it, Julius. We're in The Valley of the Kings."

The valley stretched out before them, a mammoth maze of tombs beset on all sides by towering cliffs. It was a sight that would strike awe in even the most jaded of hearts.

Julius whispered something into Raventhorpe's ear, and the professor nodded in agreement. "You're right, we're close. We should start looking."

"Start looking? For what?" Ari asked, his curiosity piqued.

But before they could answer a voice called out from below. "Hello! Hello, up there!"

They glanced down to see a man in his thirties, his skin tanned and weathered from years in the sun. He stood next to a pair of camels, a friendly grin on his face.

"A local," Raventhorpe murmured, his voice filled with wonder. "Our first contact with humans from another century."

"Weren't you born in the 1900s?" Ari asked, raising an eyebrow.

Mahgdi laughed, the sound echoing across the vast desert. "How's it going up there? American?"

They climbed down to speak with Mahgdi, who greeted

them warmly. "You are American, yes?"

Raventhorpe nodded. "Very astute. And you are..."

"Egyptian," Ari interjected, earning a glare from the professor.

"I was asking for his name," Raventhorpe snapped, before turning his attention back to Mahgdi. Ari retreated much like he would in Raventhorpe's physics class after one of his wisecracks was met with stern disinterest.

"Mahgdi, at your service," the man replied, offering a small bow. "I help Americans cross the desert."

"That's exactly what we need," Raventhorpe said, extending his hand for a shake. "Lionel Raventhorpe. This is Julius, and that there's Ari Buktu."

Ari waved, and Mahgdi continued, "I know. I help."

"Thank you, Mahgdi. You're just delightful," Raventhorpe replied, his voice filled with gratitude.

"Anything for Americans," Mahgdi assured them.

Ari frowned, a hint of suspicion in his eyes. "Whoa-whoa, why do we need to cross the desert?"

"To get to Valley of the Queens, of course," Mahgdi explained, gesturing to his camels. "Thuya and Khalifa, fastest camels in all the land. Get us there before sunset."

Raventhorpe seemed eager to set off, but Ari hesitated, his gaze flicking back to the tower they had just climbed. "What are you waiting for, Ari?"

"Professor..." he began, uncertainty lacing his words.

"Ari, don't you want to go on an adventure?"

Ari hesitated for a moment more, his thoughts clearly racing. "But home... and the Elevator?"

Raventhorpe's expression softened, and he reached out to clasp Ari's shoulder. "Home will still be there when we get back, Ari. And the Elevator? It'll be there too, and I'll fix it. I promise."

With a small, hesitant nod, Ari accepted Raventhorpe's outstretched hand and climbed up onto the camel.

"We're off to find the treasure!" said Raventhorpe
"Wait... treasure?"

The camels bounded off to their destination, their riders swaying with the motion as they made their way through the relentless heat. Ari's curiosity was insatiable, and he pressed Raventhorpe for more information. "Come on, level with me. What's this treasure thing?"

"We're going to find the Tiara of Nefertari," Raventhorpe revealed, a faraway look in his eyes.

Ari stumbled over the unfamiliar name. "What's the tiara of Netetefari--?"

"Nefertari," Raventhorpe corrected, his voice tinged with reverence. "A tiara fit for a queen. The most beautiful crown in all of history."

"Very pretty," Mahgdi agreed, a smile tugging at his lips.

"So we're treasure hunters now?" Ari asked, disbelief evident in his tone. "Must be worth a lot of money."

Raventhorpe shook his head. "I'm not doing it for money, Ari."

"Then why are we in olden days Egypt before the invention of air conditioning? Why are we looking for this tiara?"

Julius squeaked, as if providing the answer, and Raventhorpe sighed. "So I love her. Sue me, Julius."

"Love? You're doing this for love?" Ari asked, incredulous.

Raventhorpe's expression turned somber. "Ari, not all of us are born gifted with luck and charm."

Julius let out another squeak, as if to say "no kidding," and Raventhorpe shot him a glare. "Very funny," he muttered, before turning back to Ari. "Some of us need to find other ways to ask people to love them."

"So you're going to buy someone's love with this Tiara? That doesn't make sense."

"Well, sense and love don't always mix, Ari," Raventhorpe replied philosophically.

Ari's curiosity got the better of him once more. "Who is it?"

Raventhorpe hesitated, then admitted, "The most beautiful woman who ever lived... Dolores Dabbledots."

"Ms. Dabbledots, my history teacher?!" Ari exclaimed, his eyes widening in shock. "Holy... wow... okay. You and Dolores..."

"If we pull this off, then yeah," Raventhorpe confirmed, a determined glint in his eye.

"Look you said back at the lab that we could witness the

birth of the universe, the fall of empires, the invention of groundbreaking technologies. That the possibilities are truly limitless. Why didn't you just show her that stuff in your elevator."

"Love is complicated Ari," said the professor. "I needed to make a bigger statement. One that would mean the world to her."

"Ms. Dabbledots...okay okay. Well you know what. I can respect that. We'll pop in grab the tiara and get back to the elevator. How hard could it be, I mean it's 1817 Egypt," said Ari.

"My thoughts exactly," said Raventhorpe.

As they continued their journey, Mahgdi couldn't help but comment on the unusual nature of their quest. "You do not seem like typical tomb raiders," he observed. "You speak of love."

Raventhorpe shook his head. "Oh, we're not tomb raiders."

"Sure," Mahgdi replied, clearly not convinced.

"We're not," Raventhorpe insisted.

"My brother sends me to pick up Americans and bring them across desert to Nefertari's tomb to find Tiara," Mahgdi explained, his tone somewhat defensive. "With that, I can restore my pastry business."

As they continued their journey, the desert stretched out before them, seemingly endless and unforgiving. Yet the promise of adventure and the lure of the Tiara of Nefertari

spurred them onward, deeper into the heart of ancient Egypt.

Ari glanced at Raventhorpe, clearly wanting to voice his concerns, but the professor's stern expression made him think better of it. Instead, he turned his attention to Mahgdi, who was now leading the small caravan through the desert.

Mahgdi's story had clearly struck a chord with Ari. "Your brother sent you to get us? Why would he do that?" he asked, struggling to understand the motives behind their journey.

"We're not tomb raiders, Mahgdi. We're adventurers," Raventhorpe declared with pride, hoping to set the record straight.

"Oh... well, that is different," Mahgdi replied, his tone noticeably softer. "I cannot tolerate thieves and robbers. I am a merchant, selling my pastries and my yummy treats. I bother no one. One day, my merchandises are ransacked by a strange Italian man. Greed in his eyes and evil on his mind. Left me with only stale baklava."

He patted a sack of baklava hanging off the camel, his expression a mixture of sadness and determination.

"So now I hear about Americans needing to cross the desert, with lots of money to pay me. With that, I can restore my pastry business," Mahgdi continued, his eyes focused on the horizon.

"A noble venture, my friend," replied Raventhorpe.

Ari, unable to resist saying something, started to speak. "We don't have any mon—"

Raventhorpe quickly interrupted him with a throaty cough. "Ixnay on the oneymay, Ari."

Ari fell silent, but his eyes conveyed his unease about the entire situation. Regardless, the group continued their journey across the Egyptian desert, the sun's relentless heat making their journey all the more challenging.

As the hours wore on, the conversation between the travelers turned to lighter topics, with Ari asking Mahgdi about his pastries and the professor sharing stories of his previous escapades. Even Julius occasionally joined in with a well-timed squeak or two.

Despite the daunting task ahead of them, and the various concerns that weighed on their minds, the small group of adventurers couldn't help but feel a sense of camaraderie as they made their way toward the Valley of the Queens, the Tiara of Nefertari, and the destiny that awaited them in the sands of ancient Egypt.

Nefertari's Tomb

The entrance to Nefertari's tomb loomed ahead, its ancient sandstone façade casting an ominous shadow over the group. Ari couldn't help but feel a sense of unease as they approached the threshold of this sacred place. The afternoon sun beat down with a relentless fury, yet the entrance was cloaked in a deep shade that made it feel even colder than before.

Mahgdi stood off to the side, petting his camels and murmuring to them in a language that Ari couldn't quite

place. It was a strange sight to see this desert dweller now lavishing such tender care upon his animals. Yet, as Ari observed Mahgdi's love for his camels, he couldn't help but see the parallel to the Professor's affection for Julius.

"Do you love your camels?" Ari asked Mahgdi, drawing his attention away from the animals for a moment.

Mahgdi turned to him with a twinkle in his eye. "Of course, they are my friends. They help me cross the desert and never complain. And besides," he added with a smile, "they are very handsome." Thuya leaned his head into Mahgdi's hand as he brushed against it. Ari chuckled, charmed by the Mahgdi's affection for his animals.

As they approached the entrance to the tomb, the air grew colder, and Ari wrapped lifted his hoodie to his head and pulled the strings to wrap it tight. The entrance was decorated with intricate carvings and hieroglyphs, their meaning lost to time. Ari couldn't help but wonder what secrets lay hidden within those walls, waiting to be uncovered.

Suddenly, Mahgdi stopped in his tracks, visibly uneasy. "Okay, this is where I leave you," he said, his eyes darting nervously around the entrance of the tomb.

Ari was confused. "Wait, you're not gonna bring us in?"

"It's bad luck for me to enter the tomb," Mahgdi explained. "I go no further, but I hope I have done my duty well and you will pay me kindly."

Raventhorne, however, had some bad news for the

pastry merchant. "Well, slight hiccup on that, Mahgdi. We're not going to be able to pay you now."

Mahgdi's face fell. "What?"

Raventhorpe tried to make amends. "But...we promise whatever we find inside that tomb that isn't the Tiara is yours."

Mahgdi hesitated for a moment, weighing the offer. "Deal!" he exclaimed, and they shook on it. "I'll wait for you out here," he said with a smile.

As Mahgdi wandered off, lost in his thoughts, Raventhorpe turned to Ari and said, "Okay, let's find that Tiara, Ari. Here take this." He handed Ari a flashlight, "you're gonna need it inside."

As they entered the sound of the winds blowing through the desert landscape shifted and it was quite peaceful with the the air growing warmer and more thicker as they went. The walls were adorned with ornate carvings, their meaning lost to time.

"What's all this stuff mean Professor?" Ari asked.

"Well in this time they don't have the Egyptian language deciphered yet. Won't be for another five or ten years before they can read it, but between you and me most of it is about the gods and Nefertari's life."

They soon came across a strange structure, a puzzle that seemed to bar their way. Raventhorpe consulted his well-worn copy of William Saturno's book, "A brief history of treasures," studying the pictures and diagrams with a

furrowed brow.

"According to Saturno, this is a test," Raventhorpe said, tapping his finger on the page. "It's designed to weed out the unworthy, to ensure that only the truly worthy can make it to the Tiara."

Ari raised an eyebrow. "Who's William Saturno?"

Raventhorpe's face lit up with excitement. "Only one of the greatest archaeologists and historians of our time," he explained. "He's written extensively on ancient artifacts and specifically the one we're searching for. His knowledge is our secret weapon in this expedition."

As they examined the puzzle, Ari noticed a small alcove hidden in the shadows. Curiosity piqued, he approached the alcove and carefully shone his flashlight on the wall. To his surprise, he discovered a beautifully crafted amulet adorned with intricate engravings of two figures entwined, representing Ramses and Nefertari.

"Professor, come take a look at this!" Ari called out, excitement in his voice.

Raventhorpe hurried over, examining the amulet closely. "Incredible," he muttered. "This amulet symbolizes the eternal love between Ramses and Nefertari, transcending time itself. It's said that the amulet grants its bearer the ability to see the truth in matters of the heart."

Ari carefully removed the amulet from its resting place, holding it up to the light and started to speak, "Dearest amulet, will Dolores fall in love with the professor here

when he gives her the Tiara of Nefertari.”

“Ari I was thinking more that the amulet can help us solve the puzzle,” the professor said as he moved past Ari to the blockage, surveying for clues.

Raventhorpe pondered for a moment, "Ancient Egyptian tombs often contain hidden clues and symbols. This amulet could be one such clue."

Ari sighed, embarrassed and feeling a bit spoken down to like he was in the physics classes at Kasdan High School. There was no arguing with Raventhorpe when he got like this. He stepped forward and studied the puzzle more intently, trying to make sense of the cryptic symbols and stones. The hieroglyphs seemed to be arranged in a spiraling pattern, converging at the center of the puzzle.

"Uh, maybe there's some sort of pattern we need to follow?" Ari suggested hesitantly, scanning the puzzle for any hints or clues. "Or something in the hieroglyphs?"

Raventhorpe squinted at the symbols etched into the stone, his finger tracing the lines as he searched for a hidden meaning. "I don't see anything obvious," he admitted. "But it's worth a try. Shine a light over here will you?"

Ari hesitated, then pointed his flashlight at the outermost hieroglyphs, working his way inward along the spiral.

“Wait there’s a spot where it looks like the amulet goes,” said Ari. Ari stepped forward, handed his light to Raventhorpe, “Alright here we go.” He pulled it out and placed it at the center of the spiral and stones began rising

from the ground. A low rumbling sound echoed through the chamber, and the melodic sound of a rocks sliding back and forth started come from the ground.

“What did that do?” Asked Ari.

“Wait, Ari,” said the professor his face filled with anxiety as he studied one of the heiroglyphs . “I think it’s a timer! We have to solve this before it runs out!”

Ari’s eyes widened. “What do I do?”

“Quick, keep going! Follow the spiral pattern! Push the stones,” Raventhorpe barked.

Ari pushed the first stone block. Nothing seemed to happen. “Hurry, Ari. Hurry,” urged Raventhorpe.

His heart raced as he continued to push the blocks, the seconds ticking away on the timer. The chamber shook with each successful move, as if the ancient tomb itself were urging them to hurry. Julius began to scurry on the wall pointing out where Ari should push next.

“Yeah thanks buddy,” said Ari, “I’m moving as fast as I can.”

With only seconds left on the timer and the temple now shaking like a small earthquake was happening, Ari reached the final hieroglyph in the spiral pattern. His hands trembled as he pushed the stone block and pulled a lever.

“Hopefully this is it,” he said. “Julius was the right?” Julius nodded and looked up at Raventhorpe.

The chamber remained silent, and then, with a low rumble, a hidden door slowly opened, revealing a new

passageway.

Ari fell flat on his back his arms raised in celebration.

Raventhorpe patted Ari on the back, his eyes shining with pride. "Excellent work, my boy! You kept your cool under pressure, and we made it through. Now let's see what lies ahead."

Ari still out of breath, panting heavily, "Yeah, your welcome."

As they ventured deeper into the tomb, Ari couldn't help but glance back at the amulet, now an integral part of the ceiling fixture.

As Ari followed Raventhorpe deeper into the tomb, he couldn't help but feel confused about the whole situation. They were supposed to be testing the elevator, to see if time travel was possible, and yet here they were, searching for the Tiara of Nefertari. And then there was the book from William Saturno, the renowned archaeologist and historian. Ari couldn't help but wonder why Raventhorpe had brought it with him to Egypt. Had this been the plan all along? Was the elevator truly broken, or had they just used that as an excuse to come here and search for the Tiara?

He shook his head, trying to clear his thoughts. He couldn't let his doubts get in the way besides he needed the extra credit. They were here now, and they had a job to do. The Tiara was the key to Raventhorpe's happiness, and Ari wanted to help him find it.

"He professor something doesn't add up. If you only wanted to come to 1800's Egypt and then go back to Kasdan, why'd you bring that book from Saturno?"

Raventhorpe could sense Ari's hesitation, the uncertainty in his eyes as they delved deeper into the dark and ancient tomb. He knew that this wasn't Ari's usual line of work, and that the young man was feeling out of his depth. With a reassuring hand on Ari's shoulder, Raventhorpe stopped and turned to face him.

"You know, Ari," he said, his voice calm and steady, "it's the things you do for love that sometimes give you the most meaning in life. Nefertari was Ramses' everything, and he did everything in his power to make her happy. And look at what he achieved - he's remembered even today as one of the greatest pharaohs to ever rule Egypt."

Ari looked up at Raventhorpe, a hint of confusion in his eyes. "What does that have to do with me and the book?"

Raventhorpe smiled, patting him on the back. "It means that there's more to life than just treasure and fame or a silly experiment, Ari. You'll find love of your own someday, and that will be the thing that makes everything else worthwhile. And don't worry, we'll get out of here in one piece, so that you can go back to Glendale. Back home."

Ari thought of his home life with Victoria for the first time and noticed something strange. He didn't miss it at all. Ari followed Raventhorpe further into the depths of the

tomb, the shadows of the past enveloping them as they pressed onwards. The Tiara of Nefertari lay hidden somewhere within these ancient walls, and together, they would uncover its secrets and bring it back to the world, back to Dolores.

Dolores

Nestled in the picturesque small town of Glendale, Dolores Dabbledots' cozy two-story house stood proudly on a tree-lined street, its white picket fence and well-kept garden a symbol of the community's charm. Her home was just a few blocks away from the bustling Kasdan High School.

Glendale seemed to exist in a time capsule of idyllic Americana, with its quaint architecture and friendly, tight-knit community. The town's residents went about their daily lives with a sense of familiarity and warmth, as if they

were all part of an extended family, united by the shared experience of living in this charming corner of the world.

Dolores Dabbledots, a history teacher in her 50s with a kind heart and gentle demeanor, sat in the sanctuary of her living room, bathed in the warm, golden lamplight that cast a gentle glow on her surroundings. Her love for history was evident in the room's decor, with shelves full of books on various historical eras and drawings of artifacts from ancient civilizations tastefully displayed. The walls were adorned with warm beige paint and showcased artwork inspired by her travels. A half-finished knitting project rested on the coffee table, the soft yarn, and a pair of needles ready for her skilled hands.

The plush brown couch and matching armchair were strategically placed before a large flat-screen TV which on most nights beckoned her to relax but on this night was turned to local news channel 10, which was reporting on the strange power surges felt and heard throughout Glendale earlier that evening. She tried to dismiss it, even as her eyes darted between her knitting and the news on the TV.

However, a newsanchor caught her attention as he mentioned the mysterious sounds and power surges seemed to originate from a 3-square-mile area, which included Kasdan High School. Dolores felt a shiver run down her spine as she interviewed those who heard the sounds coming from the school. All claiming their clocks have

stopped working even as power was restored and the sounds stopped.

"No why would the clocks stop," mused Dolores under her breath.

It was then that the phone rang, the shrill sound slicing through the room's peculiar tension. Dolores picked up the phone, hearing the stern voice of Principal Pellingbottom on the other end.

"Dolores, I need you to head to Kasdan High School and make sure everything's alright. I have a feeling that those power surges earlier tonight might have caused some damage."

Dolores was taken aback by the request, knowing Pellingbottom to be a tough, no-nonsense individual who prioritized her own well-being over others.

"Now? It's 9:30," Dolores said, glancing at the clock. "I can go early tomorrow to make sure everything is okay."

Pellingbottom sighed, her selfishness apparent even over the phone. "Fine, but make sure you're there first thing in the morning."

"Alright, I'll be there," Dolores agreed, her concern growing.

Hanging up the phone, Dolores eyed her car keys resting in their usual spot within the bowl on the kitchen table. The unsettling sensation intensified, and an inexplicable urge bubbled within her, urging her to take action.

Dolores couldn't help but recall her turbulent history

with Principal Pellingbottom as she clutched the phone. Their disagreements over school policies and teaching methods had often left Dolores feeling disheartened and frustrated.

Beside her sat a man, completely engrossed in the screen of his phone, seemingly oblivious to the undercurrent of unease that permeated the room. Realizing that she needed to address her concerns, Dolores put down her knitting and turned to him, a frown etched on her face.

"Everything alright," he said as though half asleep and barely caring at all, eyes never leaving the flickering lights from his phone.

"Hey, do you feel that?" Dolores asked, waving her hand vaguely through the air.

He looked up, his brows furrowing in confusion. "Feel what?"

Dolores hesitated, realizing how difficult it was to convey this unsettling sensation. "It's hard to describe," she admitted, "but something just feels... off."

She looked over at her clock and it read 9:33. "That's odd our clock's still working. The lady on the news said they all stopped."

The man shrugged. "Clocks generally work Dolores besides I don't feel anything out of the ordinary."

For now, she decided he was right, perhaps it was just her history with Pellingbottom getting the better of her.

Hours later as Dolores lay restless in her bed, her mind

raced, and the unshakable feeling that something was off with the universe persisted. She looked at her clock, it was 2 in the morning and there she lay, and unshakable feeling told her she needed to go to Kasdan High School right now.

The Treasure Room

Raventhorpe cautiously ambled down the dim corridors of Nefertari's tomb, his eyes scanning the intricate hieroglyphs on the walls. He paused at an image of the sun rising and remarked, "Even the ancient Egyptians were obsessed with time." Julius, who had been trailing behind, squeaked in agreement. "Ra was the sun god for the ancient Egyptians and one of the most important, the god of all living things. They used sundials to track the sun and measure time," he said, sounding more professorial than he

had in some time to Ari.

Raventhorpe marveled at the immaculate presentation of the tomb, its walls adorned with stunning paintings that exuded a palpable sense of grandeur. "If the tomb is this beautiful," he said, "I can only imagine how exquisite the tiara must be," he whispered to Julius, who squeaked in agreement.

Ari, initially hesitant about the whole adventure, found himself caught up in the excitement. As they ventured deeper into the tomb, he couldn't help but feel a sense of wonder and awe. "Hey, uh professor, how long did it take them to make this place? And uh, did they do it?" He asked, backpedaling and looking up, hardly watching where he was going.

Raventhorpe's caution resurfaced. "Be careful," he warned. "The ancient Egyptians were known to set booby traps to protect their tombs. We must tread carefully."

"Sorry," said Ari, gathering his bearings.

Raventhorpe's eyes lit up as he entered a new chamber. "Ari, imagine this: back then, workers chipped away at limestone to shape the tomb, and skilled artists brought the walls to life with their carvings and paintings. Ten years of hard work, all done with simple tools, and yet, here it stands, centuries later. Isn't that amazing?"

"Totally, professor," said Ari, his voice filled with awe as he studied a painting.

"Now, it has to be somewhere close by." Raventhorpe

said, squinting at the markings. Ari asked, "What does Saturno say?" Julius squeaked in agreement, eager for any insight.

Raventhorpe frowned. "Actually, he doesn't say anything about this part of the tomb. It's collapsed in our time, so we're unfortunately on our own." They continued down the dim corridors, their footsteps echoing against the walls. The air thickened with the smell of dust and the sense of ancient secrets waiting to be uncovered.

As they searched for the treasure room, Raventhorpe, Ari, and Julius took a moment to appreciate the intricacies of the tomb. In one room, they discovered delicate pottery and statues, which hinted at the lives of those who had once inhabited the palace. In another, a beautiful fresco depicted a scene of daily life, giving them a glimpse into the world of ancient Egypt. The tomb's mysteries seemed to hold countless secrets, and the trio felt a growing sense of reverence and awe as they delved deeper into its depths.

They reached a dead end, standing before a wall of hieroglyphs.

"Hang on, nobody move." Raventhorpe searched for a clue, while Ari looked around nervously, concerned about triggering a trap. "There has to be something here," Raventhorpe muttered. "Some way to get through."

Ari frowned, his heart racing. "What if we trigger something? What if we set off a trap?"

Julius squeaked in agreement, clearly frightened.

Raventhorpe shook his head. "We don't have a choice. We have to keep going."

"Hey, what's this?" Ari said, pointing.

They discovered a sundial surrounded by hieroglyphs. At its center was a stone block, and as they approached it, they could see depictions of a booby trap that would send spikes from the ceiling if they got it wrong.

Raventhorpe smiled, pointing at the spikes. "See, I told you."

"Saturno never wrote about this," Ari said, half hoping he was wrong.

Raventhorpe nodded. "We'll have to figure it out on our own, Ari. I need your help to move this block on the sundial."

Taking a deep breath, they pushed the stone block across the face of the sundial. The hieroglyphs around the dial began to spin, and the trio watched as a trap door in the floor opened, revealing a small chamber.

"Hey, that was easy!" Said Ari, relief evident in his voice.

Entering the chamber, the door began to close. They heard the grinding of stone as it slowly sealed them inside. Ari panicked. "It's closing! We're not going to make it!"

Raventhorpe remained calm. "We just have to find the way out."

Frantically searching the chamber, they found a wall with a small indentation. Raventhorpe pushed on it, and

the wall swung open to reveal a narrow passageway.

"Quickly!" Raventhorpe shouted, and they rushed through just as the door closed behind them.

Ari collapsed, gasping for breath. "That was too close," he said, his voice trembling.

Raventhorpe grinned. "But we made it. That's all that matters."

"Wait a second, is this what I think it is..." Raventhorpe trailed off as they entered what could only be the Treasure Room. Julius began to squeak excitedly as their eyes widened.

A sense of awe enveloped them. The cavernous space stretched out before them, its walls adorned with intricate carvings, shimmering gold leaf, and precious gems that sparkled in the dim torchlight. The air was thick with the scent of ancient history, and the very atmosphere seemed to pulse with the energy of a time long past.

In the center of the room stood an enormous, ornately carved sarcophagus, its surface glistening with intricate inlaid patterns of gold and lapis lazuli. Surrounding the sarcophagus were stone pedestals, each one designed to hold a precious artifact, a testament to the wealth and power of Queen Nefertari.

However, as Raventhorpe and Ari moved further into the room, the scale of the devastation became apparent. Her once-magnificent artifacts were gone, the pedestals left empty and forlorn. The walls, once covered in vibrant

paintings depicting scenes from Nefertari's life and reign, were now marred with evidence of the looters' greed – deep gouges where priceless jewels had been pried from their settings, and faded, damaged frescoes where delicate pigments had been scraped away.

As they surveyed the damaged frescoes, one of the remaining paintings caught Raventhorpe's eye. It depicted the sun shining brilliantly above the god Ra, his arms outstretched, and on top of the sun was an exquisite tiara, its gems glinting in the painted sunlight. Raventhorpe turned to Ari, his voice filled with a mix of excitement and reverence. "Look, Ari, this painting shows the Tiara of Nefertari, placed atop the sun, signifying its divine connection to Ra, the sun god from before. This is the treasure we seek."

Ari stared at the painting, his eyes wide with wonder. The Tiara seemed to radiate power and majesty, even in its painted form. As he looked upon it, he could have sworn he heard the beautiful serenade of singing angels.

Their hearts pounded with anticipation as they took in the remnants of the once-glorious treasure room. However, their excitement was short-lived, as it became apparent that the room had been ransacked, with not a single treasure in sight.

Raventhorpe sighed as he cursed their misfortune, "Darn, someone already took all of Nefertari's treasures." The disappointment in his voice echoed through the

chamber, as they were forced to come to terms with the fact that their journey had led them to an empty room.

Ari's heart sank. "So what does that mean? It's gone?"

"Gone, slipped through the cracks of history. If it's in anyone's possession, it's never been recorded. Darn, darn, darn!" Raventhorpe kicked a rock in frustration, which skidded across the ground and clanged against something in the corner.

Julius scurried over and picked it up, handing it to Raventhorpe. "What's this?"

Inspecting it, Raventhorpe's eyes widened. "It's a gold compass. Engraved on the back: an X marks the spot made out of lit matches." Ari was puzzled. "Didn't know Egyptians even had compasses back then."

Raventhorpe shook his head. "They didn't. Not like this. This compass didn't belong to an Egyptian."

Ari studied it. "So whose is it?"

Raventhorpe grinned. "Captain Edward Teach."

Ari furrowed his brow. "Who?"

"You know him by another name--Blackbeard. My boy, we're going pirate hunting."

As Julius let out a small squeak of concern, the thrill of the hunt had already taken hold of Raventhorpe and Ari. Stepping out of the Treasure Room and navigating the dark corridors of the Nefertari Tomb, a sudden whip cracked out of nowhere, extinguishing their torch. As they looked up, a giant silhouette covered their bodies, only to

be outdone by the man it belonged to who stood blocking their path. Ari couldn't believe his eyes; this man was the largest person he had ever seen.

"Where is the Tiara?" Belzoni bellowed, his voice echoing through the tomb. It seemed to shake the tomb like a minor earthquake.

"No idea what you're talking about, big guy," Raventhorpe replied, trying to conceal the compass behind his back. Belzoni noticed and cracked his whip again, forcing Raventhorpe to spin around and drop the compass. Sarah deftly snatched it from the air and handed it to Belzoni.

"No one takes a clue from Giovanni Battista Belzoni!" he thundered, his eyes gleaming with madness.

"Or Sarah Belzoni," she added.

"Yes, or Sarah. Sorry," Belzoni said.

"Or James Curtin," mustered Curtin.

"Who?" Raventhorpe asked.

"James Curtin? Come on. Jim Curtin, assistant adventurer to--"

"Nobody knows who you are," Belzoni cut in, his patience wearing thin.

"You, on the other hand, are The Great Belzoni. Wow, an honor," Raventhorpe said, trying to distract him.

"Of course it is your honor," Belzoni sneered.

"But someone already ransacked the tomb. You're too late, the Tiara's gone," Raventhorpe said, hoping to

discourage him.

Belzoni inspected the compass closely. "It's never too late for The Great Belzoni. For you, however, this is the end." He kicked a column, breaking it in two and causing the tomb to start collapsing in around them.

The ground trembled beneath their feet as the tomb began to collapse around them. Raventhorpe's eyes met Ari's and he yelled, "Follow me!" They raced through the crumbling corridors, dodging falling debris and jumping over chasms. Finally, they reached a room filled with minecarts. Raventhorpe hopped on one and motioned for the others to follow.

"These lead out of the tomb, right?" Ari asked, trying to keep his voice steady as he climbed onto a minecart next to Julius.

"Let's hope so," Raventhorpe replied as he kicked the rocks out of the way that were keeping the carts parked in place.

They shot forward, racing down the track as the tomb continued to crumble around them. They had to change tracks several times as the one ahead was destroyed, causing hair-raising moments of tension and fear.

Raventhorpe braced them for a large jump that would hopefully get them to the exit. "On my count, pull up!" he yelled. They all grabbed onto the edges of the minecart and pulled up at the exact moment Raventhorpe had counted down. The cart launched off the edge of the track, soaring

through the air as they held their breath. They made it!

As they landed, they saw that the exit was boarded up with large planks. The group braced themselves as the minecart blasted through the planks, sending them flying into the Egyptian desert. They landed in the sand with a thud, right next to Mahgdi and his two camels.

"Looks like we made it out," Raventhorpe said with a grin.

Ari couldn't believe it. They had survived. He felt a rush of adrenaline mixed with relief as he looked back at the tomb. "I can't believe we made it out alive," he said, a newfound respect for Raventhorpe growing within him.

"It was touch and go for a moment there," Raventhorpe agreed as they climbed out of the minecart.

Mahgdi approached them with a smile. "I knew you would find a way out," he said, patting Raventhorpe on the back. "Welcome back to the land of the living."

Ari took a deep breath of the fresh desert air and looked up at the night sky. They had just escaped certain death, and he couldn't help but wonder what other dangers awaited them on their journey.

As Raventhorpe, Ari, and Julius stumbled out of the minecart, landing in a heap of sand, Mahgdi and his camels waited for them. "I thought you might be needing Mahgdi again," he said with a sly smile.

"Right you are, Mahgdi," Raventhorpe chuckled.

As they dusted themselves off, Mahgdi asked hopefully,

"Also, hope you found treasures?"

Raventhorpe's face fell. "Negative."

He then inquired if Mahgdi's brother had described the group of travelers they were supposed to escort through the desert. "Yes, he said leader of group very big man," Mahgdi said with a pause.

"Uh-huh," Raventhorpe noted Mahgdi's expression. "Come to think of it, you are not giant like brother describe. And usually he is very good with details..."

Raventhorpe made a mental note, then turned to the group. "Okay, let's get back to the Elevator." As they rode off into the night, Ari couldn't shake the feeling that they were being watched.

"Hey, Professor," Ari asked Raventhorpe as they rode on camelback through the desert. "Is Blackbeard the same notorious pirate I read about as a kid?"

Raventhorpe chuckled. "Yes, the one and only. But you have to understand, Ari, most descriptions of historical figures are exaggerated for effect. Blackbeard was a formidable pirate, no doubt, but much of what people think they know about him is just legend."

Ari nodded, but he couldn't shake the image of the infamous pirate he had read about in his youth. "But what about Belzoni?" he asked, still in awe of the towering Italian explorer. "He was as big as a refrigerator. I can't imagine him being described any crazier than he actually was."

Ari was flipping through Saturno's book and found many chapters about The Great Belzoni. "I mean this guy was a serious tomb raider, professor. It says he could lift 10 men over his head and was likely the greatest tomb raider of all time."

Raventhorpe smiled knowingly. "Ah, but that's the thing, Ari. People love a good story, and they're always willing to embellish it for dramatic effect. Belzoni was certainly a force to be reckoned with, but I'm sure some of the stories about him have been exaggerated over time."

Elevator Out

The first rays of dawn broke over the horizon, casting a warm golden glow upon the ancient sands. Raventhorpe, Ari, Julius, and Mahgdi arrived back at the Elevator in the Valley of the Kings, their camels plodding steadily beneath them. The valley was a sight to behold, with its towering cliffs and mysterious tombs etched into the landscape. Ari's eyelids drooped, every muscle in his body ached, and his fingers throbbed from the intricate mechanisms they had encountered in the Tomb of Nefertari. He glanced at

Raventhorpe, whose energy seemed undiminished despite the long journey, and admired the man's resilience and passion for history and adventure.

The air in the Valley of the Kings was still thick with the scent of history and the whispers of long-forgotten stories. The sandstone cliffs bore the marks of generations of skilled craftsmen, their intricate carvings depicting the lives and legends of Egypt's greatest pharaohs.

Having ventured deeper into the valley during their previous visit, the trio couldn't help but feel a sense of familiarity with the surroundings. The juxtaposition of the ancient tombs and the Anytime Elevator only served to highlight the incredible achievements of humanity across the ages.

As they approached the Elevator, they could see that it was exactly how they had left it—a testament to the unseen forces that seemed to guide their path. The Elevator, with its red and yellow finish and intricate gears visible through glass panels, was their ticket out of this treacherous desert and the key to unlocking the mysteries that lay ahead. Ari's heart swelled with a mix of relief and awe at the sight.

"Sorry about the lack of payment, Mahgdi," Raventhorpe said as they prepared to part ways.

Mahgdi, who had been invaluable since they arrived in Egypt, waved a hand dismissively. "It's okay. Have a good feeling our paths shall cross again," he replied with a grin as

he rode off, determined to rebuild his life after the encounter with Belzoni.

Ari sighed and slumped against the Elevator, memories of their recent trials weighing heavily on his heart. "I just wanna go home, Professor."

"But we're so close, Ari," Raventhorpe pleaded, his eyes shining with determination and an almost desperate hope, making Ari feel the depth of his longing.

"Yeah right. We're not even close to close. The Tiara is with Blackbeard, and Beltoni wants it too," Ari retorted, frustration lacing his voice.

"Belzoni," Raventhorpe corrected. "And we have something he doesn't. Something no one else has. The Elevator."

"But it's gonna take a couple of days to fix it. We're sitting ducks until then," Ari pointed out, his fear of being hunted down creeping in.

Raventhorpe hesitated before touching the Elevator, which lit up instantly. "Yeah...about that..."

Ari's eyes widened, his heart thudding in his chest. "Wait--wait--wait, hold on...this thing's working? You--you...lied to me?"

"I prefer 'embellished a falsehood,'" Raventhorpe replied with a smirk, an attempt to lighten the mood.

"Dude...uncool. Really uncool," Ari grumbled, his disappointment evident in his tone.

"Listen, if I had told you the Elevator was operational,

you wouldn't have come with me. Ari, I need you. I need to see this through. I'm an old man, and this might be my last shot to do something great for the woman I love," Raventhorpe pleaded, his vulnerability breaking through.

"C'mon, you're not that...old," Ari teased, despite the ache in his chest at seeing the professor's raw emotions.

Julius squeaked in agreement.

"Zip it, Julius," Raventhorpe grumbled. "All I've ever had was my work, Ari. My best years have passed me by. I sunk everything I had into building the Anytime Elevator. I have no woman, no money, and I'm staring down the barrel of bankruptcy. I could lose everything. Help me. Please."

Ari considered the professor's words, his heart aching for the lonely old man. Maybe Raventhorpe had a heart after all. "You really love Dolores, huh?" Ari asked, his voice softening.

"More than science...okay, maybe not more than--I--yes, I love her," Raventhorpe admitted with a tremble.

"And this...Tiara thingy would mean a lot to her?" Ari inquired, trying to grasp the depth of their connection.

"It would," Raventhorpe confirmed with a desperate hope.

"Then let's go get that sucker," Ari declared, his smile growing as he felt a newfound determination.

Raventhorpe's face lit up with excitement. "Ari, my boy! Get on in."

As the Elevator doors closed, Ari felt the weight of their decision settle on his shoulders, his thoughts filled with the dangerous path that lay ahead. Glancing at Raventhorpe and Julius, he recognized the unspoken bond that had formed between them. In that moment, Ari understood that their journey was more than just a quest for the Tiara—it was a journey of the heart.

Raventhorpe bustled around the elevator, flipping switches. "Next stop: Blackbeard's hideout -- Floor 1712," Raventhorpe announced with a twinkle in his eye.

Raventhorpe furrowed his brow as he consulted the floor guide, his finger tracing the different levels of the universe in search of the exact floor for Tortuga, 1712. "Ah HA," he exclaimed triumphantly. "Found it." He punched in the coordinates and hit the red button. The Elevator hummed to life, the white light and crackling electricity enwrapping them in its embrace. And then WHOOSH - they were off, hurtling through time and space towards their destination.

Ari watched in awe as the floors of the universe rushed past them, the colors blending together in a blur of motion. "This is insane," he breathed, his fear and exhilaration mingling.

"It's science, Ari," Raventhorpe replied, his eyes glued to the floor guide. "Pure and simple."

Julius let out a series of squeaks and chirps, clearly excited by the journey. "I second that," Raventhorpe

chuckled, patting the chinchilla on the head.

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But unbeknownst to them, they were being watched. From a hiding spot behind a large rock, Belzoni, Sarah, and James Curtin observed their departure with interest, their gazes as sharp as the desert winds. "What? Where did they go?" Belzoni murmured, a sly grin playing on his lips, like a snake waiting to strike. James Curtin nodded in agreement, but Belzoni silenced him with a sharp "Shut up, Jim."

Sarah's eyes were fixed on the spot where the Elevator had vanished, her curiosity and greed simmering beneath the surface. "How is that possible?" she asked, her voice a low, dangerous whisper.

"I don't know," Belzoni's expression hardened as he turned to the Egyptian horizon, his eyes resting on Mahgdi, who was wandering the desert with his two camels. A sinister resolve settled over Belzoni's features. "But I'm going to find out," he growled.

Pirates

Ari felt as though he were trapped in a dream, or perhaps a nightmare. The day had begun in his own time, the year 2023, but somehow he found himself transported back to the year 1817. And now, as the elevator continued its descent through the many layers of the universe, the professor was sending them back even further - to the year 1712. The thought of traveling further back in time, further away from Glendale and his friends in 2023, who were so distant, was overwhelming. As he looked at

Raventhorpe, who was practically bursting with excitement, Ari found a sense of calm. The professor was now more than his high school physics teacher; he was his guide, his mentor, and his friend. Ari remembered how, at the beginning of the journey, he had been skeptical of the professor's intentions, but now, after all they had been through, he began to trust him more. Would he steer him wrong? Ari didn't know, but he trusted the old man with his life. And now, as they hurtled through the universe towards the unknown, he realized that was exactly what he was doing - trusting his life to the professor and his crazy contraption.

A sudden jolt interrupted Ari's thoughts as the elevator came to a stop. Peering out the window, he saw they had arrived at the floor marked "1712." The ancient past of the pirate islands of the Caribbean was now their present.

Raventhorpe turned to them with a wide grin on his face. "Here we are, my boy! The year 1712. It's time to go meet Blackbeard and get that Tiara!"

Ari couldn't help but feel a sense of excitement as well. This was a once-in-a-lifetime adventure, and he was part of it. However, he couldn't shake the feeling that they were in danger, that something was watching them, waiting for the right moment to strike.

His mind crept back to the giant Belzoni and wondered what he wanted the Tiara for and apparently Blackbeard was interested in the tiara too. Why did everyone seem to

want this tiara? Ari wondered if the Tiara held special powers, and if that were the case, the thought of it falling into the wrong hands was terrifying.

The professor seemed to sense his unease. "Don't worry, Ari. We'll be fine. We have the Elevator, after all. And besides, we have each other."

Ari nodded, feeling a bit better, "Yeah, you're right."

He trusted the professor, and he knew that they had to stick together if they were going to make it through this. They stepped out of the elevator and into the dense humidity and bright light of the Caribbean island. The air was thick with moisture and the scent of salt and seaweed. The lush green foliage of the island was dotted with vibrant red and yellow flowers, while the distant sound of parrots squawking overhead filled the air. The sun glistened off the crystal-clear turquoise waters, creating a breathtaking scene that seemed almost surreal.

It was a stark difference from the dry, golden hues of Egypt, with colors so vibrant and plentiful that it almost seemed fake. Everything looked as though it had been scrubbed with Clorox bleach.

Ari had never seen so many variations of palm-looking plants and trees. Life of all kinds thrived here.

Raventhorpe took a deep breath and exhaled, feeling the weight of the situation. "Breathe in that nice clean air, Julius." The chinchilla's chest expanded and exhaled, looking back up at Raventhorpe's face, squeaking with

satisfaction.

The professor pulled Saturno's book out of his yellow trench coat, flipping through the pages quickly. "Okay, now we just have to find Blackbeard's hideout," he said with a determined voice, scanning the surroundings for any clues.

Ari looked around, taking in the sights and sounds, noticing what appeared to be a bustling port town through a thicket of jungle and brush. The sound of waves crashing against the rocky shoreline mingled with the chatter of merchants hawking their wares and sailors calling out to each other as they unloaded cargo from the ships.

Julius squeaked excitedly, hopping up and down on Raventhorpe's shoulder. The professor chuckled at the little chinchilla's enthusiasm. "Easy, Julius," he said, patting the small creature with affection.

Ari turned to Raventhorpe, his expression filled with concern. "Do you really think we can find Blackbeard's hideout, Professor?" he asked, unsure of their chances of success.

Raventhorpe flashed him a reassuring smile, "Of course we can, my boy. With Saturno's book, nothing is impossible."

Ari nodded, his doubts easing slightly. They had come too far to give up now. Together, the group shimmied through the brush and set out into the vibrant and bustling streets of the port town, determined to uncover the secrets

of Blackbeard's hideout and claim the Tiara for themselves.

Raventhorpe scanned the pages of the worn book, tracing his fingers over the yellowed parchment as if it held the secrets of the universe. Saturno's book had been his constant companion throughout their journey, a treasure trove of knowledge and insight into the pirate culture of the time. "Here," he said, pointing to a diagram. "Blackbeard's secret hideout was in a cave in Tortuga, but it doesn't say where the cave is."

Ari leaned in, squinting at the diagram. "So what do we do now?"

"We'll have to ask around," Raventhorpe replied, tucking the book back into his trenchcoat. "But we'll need to keep our distance from the locals. We stick out like a sore thumb dressed like this."

Ari looked down at his clothes, feeling self-conscious. He had thought his outfit was appropriate for the time, but now he could see how out of place they must look. "Got it," he said, following Raventhorpe as they made their way through the bustling town.

As they walked, Raventhorpe offered insights into the pirate culture, pointing out the symbols and markings on the buildings and ships that hinted at their allegiance. Ari listened intently, fascinated by the intricate web of alliances and rivalries that governed the world of piracy. As they moved through the town, carefully avoiding drawing too much attention to themselves, Ari felt a growing sense of

certainty that they were on the right path to finding Blackbeard's hideout.

Finally, Ari couldn't resist asking the question that had been on his mind. "So, professor, how do we find this cave? What if it's hidden?"

Raventhorpe chuckled. "Saturno wouldn't have written about it if it was impossible to find. We just need to keep our eyes and ears open."

For the first time, Ari started to feel the strain of this journey on his body. As he walked, he could feel the muscles in his legs begin to strain, which extended down through the bones in his feet.

Out of the corner of his eye, he noticed two pirates arguing over something. He couldn't be certain, but it sounded like the pirates said the word, "Blackbeard." Ari stopped, straining his eyes and ears but couldn't make out what the pirates were arguing about, so he strode closer to the commotion. The professor, realizing the potential danger, called out a warning to him.

"Be careful, Ari," Raventhorpe cautioned.

"I got this, professor."

But it was too late. The pirate who wasn't arguing noticed Ari and approached him with a hand on his cutlass. The pirate's suspicious gaze was fixed on Ari as he asked, "Hey you - what's your business here?"

The professor stepped in, using his quick wit to diffuse the situation. "We have knowledge of a great treasure and

are looking for a fleet interested in a great bounty. We've heard that such a fleet is here on Tortuga in the caves."

The pirate's demeanor shifted, his eyes now filled with interest instead of suspicion. "Treasure? What treasure?"

"Yes," Raventhorpe replied confidently. "And we're willing to share it with the right partners."

The pirate considered for a moment before nodding. "I know of such a fleet. Follow me."

Ari breathed a sigh of relief as they followed the pirate to a nearby tavern. As they entered, Raventhorpe glanced around, sizing up the rough-and-tumble crowd. It was clear that they didn't belong there, but they needed to blend in if they were going to find their treasure.

"Stay alert, Ari," the professor whispered. "We don't want to draw too much attention to ourselves."

"Aye aye, cap'n," said Ari with a grin.

As soon as they entered, Raventhorpe and Ari were surrounded by a group of fierce-looking pirates, their cutlasses already drawn. The leader of the group, a tall, burly man with a grizzled beard, eyed them suspiciously.

"Who's the dead man that mentioned treasure?" he growled.

"We seek a fleet interested in a great bounty," the professor said smoothly, holding up Saturno's book for emphasis.

The pirate leader narrowed his eyes. "And what do you know about this... bounty?"

"Have you ever heard of Treasure Island and young Jim Hawkins?" said the professor. He proceeded to explain the plot from the book and waited in hopes the pirates bought the story hook, line, and sinker.

"You're lying," the burly pirate spat, lowering his cutlass. "And now you're a dead man." He began advancing on them.

Raventhorpe was quick to react. He grabbed a nearby crate and threw it at the pirate, knocking him off balance. "Run!" he yelled to Ari.

"Ya think?" Ari yelled as he slammed his shoulder into a pirate blocking his path to the door.

Ari's heart was pounding as they raced through the streets, the sound of angry pirates hot on their heels. He couldn't believe they had almost been caught, but the professor seemed unfazed.

"We'll find Blackbeard's hideout on our own," Raventhorpe said confidently, clutching Saturno's book tightly. "At least we know for sure it's here now."

As they ducked down a narrow alleyway, Ari looked back over his shoulder, half-expecting to see the pirates closing in on them. But all he saw was the empty street, save one drunken singing pirate, and the distant sound of angry shouts slowly fading away.

Breathless and sweating, they finally slowed to a walk towards the edge of the town, and Raventhorpe gave Ari a pat on the back.

"Well done," he said. "You're a quick thinker in a tight spot."

Ari grinned, feeling a surge of pride at the compliment. The Professor was looking for somewhere to hide, and Julius began squeaking, pointing to an opening on the outskirts of the village, leading out into the jungle.

"Great thinking, Julius," said Raventhorpe, and they ducked between the bushes.

As they journeyed into the jungle, the sounds of civilization slowly faded into the distance. The rustling of leaves, the hum of insects, and the occasional screech of a bird were the only things that accompanied them on their journey.

"Man, there's a lot of bugs here," Ari said, swatting at mosquitoes.

"We're gonna have to find a place to camp soon. Maybe make a fire to keep the bugs away," Raventhorpe replied.

The sun began to dip below the horizon, and Ari grew increasingly worried. Nightfall in an unfamiliar jungle was the last thing he wanted. Julius became extra alert, scanning any movement or sound for potential predators. But just as their concern turned to panic, they stumbled upon a clearing.

"What's that over there?" asked Ari.

In the center of the clearing, a group of pirates sat around a large campfire, singing and drinking. Raventhorpe's eyes widened in excitement. "Pirates!" he

exclaimed. "This is perfect."

"Pirates? Last time they almost killed us," said Ari as he chased after the professor.

Raventhorpe sauntered up to the group of pirates, a charming smile on his face. "Excuse me. Excuse me. Good evening, gentlemen. Might I join in on your song?" he asked, his voice smooth as silk.

The pirates eyed him warily at first, but as Raventhorpe began to sing along, his baritone voice filling the air, they began to warm up to him. They clapped and cheered as he finished the tune, slapping him on the back.

"Come 'er and grab a seat by me fire," a grizzly, very drunk pirate called out, looking in the wrong direction entirely.

Ari watched in amazement, his heart pounding with a mixture of excitement and fear, as his professor seamlessly blended in with the pirates, his yellow trenchcoat a stark contrast to their ragged garb. He had to admit, Raventhorpe had a way with people, but he couldn't shake the lingering worry about what could happen if their true intentions were discovered.

After many more rounds of songs and more drinks for the pirates, Raventhorpe leaned in towards the pirate, his voice low and direct. "We are in search of Blackbeard's hideout," he said, "and we were hoping you could provide us with some information."

The pirate scowled at Raventhorpe, clearly annoyed by

his directness. "And why would I help ye?" he growled.

Raventhorpe remained unfazed. "Because," he said coolly, "we have something that you want."

The pirate raised an eyebrow, intrigued. "And what might that be?" he asked as he took a large swig of rum.

Raventhorpe reached into his pocket and pulled out a small, shiny object. "This," he said, holding up the object for the pirate to see. "It's a rare jewel, worth a fortune."

The pirate's eyes widened at the sight of the jewel. "Alright, I'll help ye," he said, grabbing the jewel, a grin spreading across his face. "But you have to promise me a share of the treasure."

Raventhorpe nodded. "Of course," he said. "Now, can you tell us where the hideout is?"

The pirate scratched his head, thinking. "I don't know the exact location," he said, "but if ye follow the path through that thicket o'r there. Soon'r or lat'r, you'll find it."

Raventhorpe smiled. "That will do just fine."

The pirate chuckled. "Good luck finding it," he said, before stumbling off drunkenly holding the jewel up to the moon to look at it.

Ari gave the professor a grateful hug, his heart pounding with excitement and fear. "How did you do that? You were incredible back there."

They were so close now, but anything could happen. "Thanks, Ari. We can do this," Raventhorpe whispered to

him, patting his back.

"Professor, but where did you get that jewel for the pirate?" asked Ari.

"It was rock candy, Ari. Let's get out of here before he sobers up." replied the Professor.

They pushed through the thick brush, following the path that the pirate had pointed out. The humid air clung to their skin as they moved, the thick foliage around them casting deep shadows that danced in the light filtering through the trees. Julius hopped in the professor's front coat pocket to avoid the branches slapping him in the face.

"Sorry, Julius, it's thicker than I thought it would be," said Raventhorpe as he released a branch right into Ari's face.

"Hey, what about me?" Ari said, only half-kidding.

As they walked, Raventhorpe flipped through Saturno's book, his eyes scanning the pages for any hints or clues that might lead them to the pirate hideout. "Look here," he said, pointing to a sketch of an ancient tree. "This is the marker we're looking for. It should be close to the entrance of the cave."

They pushed through a thicket of branches and emerged into a small clearing, the massive tree looming over them like a sentinel. Raventhorpe pulled out Saturno's book once more, his finger tracing over a map. "This is it," he said, his voice low. "This is where we need to go."

Ari nodded, his eyes scanning the area for any sign of

danger. He felt a twinge of unease in his gut, but pushed it aside.

"We've come this far. Failure is not an option," said Raventhorpe, sounding more than ever like the physics teacher Ari knew from Kasdan High School.

With a deep breath, Raventhorpe led the way towards the tree, his eyes scanning the ground for any hidden markers or signs. They reached the base of the tree, and Raventhorpe began to circle around it, his fingers tracing the bark.

Suddenly, he stopped and let out a whoop of excitement. "Here it is!" he cried, pointing to a small crevice in the trunk. "This is the entrance to the cave!"

"Look, it opens here," Raventhorpe spread the crack open, and they went inside.

Ari's face broke into a wide grin, his heart pounding with anticipation. They had made it this far, and now, with the entrance to the cave in front of them, anything was possible.

Raventhorpe led the way, his torch casting flickering shadows on the cave walls. "Be careful where you step," he warned. "There could be traps. Clearly, the pirates are touchy creatures."

Ari followed closely behind, his heart pounding in his chest. "Traps? What kind of traps?"

Julius began squeaking, and the professor nodded in agreement, listing them out for Ari.

"Pressure-sensitive plates, tripwires," Raventhorpe explained. "But don't worry, Saturno's book has been invaluable so far. It should guide us through this safely."

As they ventured deeper into the cave, they encountered the first trap. Julius began to screech. "Stop," Raventhorpe commanded, holding up a hand. "Look down."

Julius was on the ground pointing to some inconsistencies in the flooring.

Ari peered at the ground and saw a series of small indentations. "What are those?"

"Pressure plates," Raventhorpe replied. "Step on one and who knows what will happen. Let's follow Julius."

Ari gulped and followed Julius's lead as they carefully navigated around the trap. They encountered several more traps along the way, including tripwires that could set off deadly traps. Each time, Julius expertly guided them around.

At one point, Ari accidentally brushed against a tripwire. "Stop!" Raventhorpe shouted, but it was too late. A loud click echoed through the cave, and Ari braced for impact. Ari's heart raced as he realized the danger he had put them in. He glanced nervously at Raventhorpe, whose eyes were wide with alarm.

But nothing happened.

"Maybe they're broken," said Ari, looking up in embarrassment at the professor, but the professor was already walking into a large cavernous room.

Ari joined him and stared in awe at the vast chamber, filled with glittering gold coins, jewels, and an array of pirate relics. The room was eerily silent except for their heavy breathing and the faint creaking of their footsteps on the wooden planks.

“This must be it,” Raventhorpe whispered in awe.

Ari nodded, his eyes scanning the room. “This is incredible.”

But their moment of triumph was short-lived. The professor flipped through Saturno’s book, trying to find the next clue, but it was then that they both heard a low rumble coming from deep within the cave. Ari’s heart quickened with fear as he turned towards the sound and, in doing so, stepped on a pressure stone.

Julius shrieked, but it was too late. Suddenly, they felt the ground shift beneath them, and they were jerked upward. In a split second, they found themselves entangled in a net, suspended in the air like trapped fish.

“I thought this was the treasure room, but it was a trap,” snarled Raventhorpe. “Those pirates tricked us.”

“Ya think? What do we do now?” Ari asked in a hushed tone.

Ari’s heart raced as he struggled to get free, but it was no use. He looked at Raventhorpe, who was frantically flipping through the book, trying to find a way out of their predicament.

But before the professor could answer, they heard the

distinct sound of a peg-legged pirate's footsteps getting closer, followed by a deep and menacing laughter that reverberated off the cave walls.

"It's Blackbeard," Raventhorpe breathed out, his face turning pale.

The Tides of Time

The chamber was embedded in the heart of an ancient Egyptian temple, its sandstone walls adorned with magnificent carvings that told tales of gods, pharaohs, and the eternal Nile. A flickering torch cast a warm glow over the breathtaking artifacts that surrounded them, from golden statues to delicate pottery. The air was thick with the dust of centuries, each particle a testament to the countless lives that had played out within these hallowed chambers. Their presence there was a fleeting moment in

the grand tapestry of history, yet what they sought held the power to change the course of time itself.

Henry Salt hunched over a large stone tablet, his eyes carefully tracing the intricate hieroglyphs etched into the surface. The dimly lit room was filled with the scent of ancient treasures and the whispers of long-forgotten secrets. So focused on his work, he didn't notice Giovanni Belzoni storming into the room with the bound Mahgdi in tow. Giovanni slammed a hand down on the table, making Salt jump in surprise.

"Where is it, Salt?" Giovanni demanded, his face twisted in anger. "The tiara wasn't in Nefertari's tomb. You were so certain it would be there!"

Taking a deep breath, Salt calmly replied, "Giovanni, I never guaranteed it would be there. I simply said it was our best lead."

Sarah chimed in, her voice dripping with disdain, "Giovanni, you know we can't trust Salt. He's always been the snake lurking in the shadows, taking credit for your discoveries."

James Curtin nodded in agreement, his Irish accent adding a lively tone. "Sarah's right. We need to be cautious with the likes of Salt."

Giovanni scowled but seemed to calm down slightly at Salt's words. "Fine. But we need to find that tiara soon. The longer it takes, the more likely it is that someone else will get to it first."

Belzoni's eyes narrowed as he leaned in closer to Salt, his hands gripping Mahgdi's shoulder. "Did you send him?" he demanded, gesturing to the fearful-looking man.

Salt held his ground, meeting Belzoni's gaze with a steely resolve. "I have never seen him before in my life," he replied evenly.

Sarah stepped forward, her expression one of concern. "Henry, what's going on?" she asked.

Belzoni didn't take his eyes off Salt. "I saw Mahgdi with two strange men and the rat in the desert," he explained. "They were searching for the tiara as well."

James Curtin chimed in, his Irish accent making his question sound more animated. "And you think Salt sent them?"

Belzoni nodded. "It's the only explanation," he said firmly.

Salt shook his head in disbelief, the shadows in the room accentuating his furrowed brow. "I would never do such a thing," he protested.

Belzoni furrowed his brow, recalling the strange encounter. "We saw them vanish right before our eyes, like magic, in some odd metal box."

Belzoni reached into his pocket and pulled out a gold compass with an intriguing engraving on the back. He tossed the compass to Salt. "Got this from one of those peculiar fellas inside the Tomb of Nefertari. He was a short, fat, bald man in a yellow coat," he said with a sly grin.

Salt examined the compass, his fingers tracing the engraved image on the back: an X made out of lit matches. "Fascinating," he mused, a playful smile dancing at the corners of his mouth.

Sarah stepped forward, her expression a mix of curiosity and concern. "What's it mean, Salt?"

James Curtin chimed in, with a touch of suspicion. "Who in the devil are these people, and what do they want with the tiara?"

The atmosphere in the room grew heavier, as if the weight of a hidden truth was pressing down on them. Salt's smile widened, his eyes gleaming with excitement. "I've got a feeling we haven't seen the last of our friends," he said.

Salt looked at them, clutching the compass tightly. With a sly smile, he added, "I'm not entirely sure, but I reckon I know just the person to ask about this." He paused, then confidently continued, "Rest assured, we'll stay one step ahead of them."

Blackbeard's Hideout

Ari, Raventhorpe, and Julius hung suspended in the cage, their bodies pressing against the rough netting that bound them. The damp cave walls dripped with moisture, echoing the sound of their rapid breathing. The faint light of their torches flickered against the darkness, casting ominous shadows on the rough-hewn stone walls.

The air in the cave was damp and heavy, carrying the scent of wet earth and mold. Stalactites hung from the ceiling like jagged teeth, while the floor was littered with

sharp rocks and slippery puddles. The walls glistened with condensation, and the sound of water dripping echoed in the darkness, adding to the eerie atmosphere.

The silence was broken by the sound of heavy footsteps approaching. The clank of boots on stone grew louder, and Ari could feel his heart racing in his chest. Their eyes widened, and their hands trembled as they clung to each other.

Suddenly, the silhouette of Blackbeard appeared in the dim light, his long black beard swaying as he walked. He stopped in front of the cage, looking them over with a sneer.

Raventhorpe surveyed their situation, his expression grim. "Well, this can't be good," he muttered.

A deep, menacing voice boomed. "I should say not."

They whirled around to see Blackbeard, a hulking figure with a long, multi-pigtailed black beard, and a band of cutthroat pirates, weapons at the ready. Julius scurried for cover in Raventhorpe's coat.

"Well, that's really not good. Run, Ari!" Raventhorpe urged.

Ari surveyed the cage, panicked. "How?"

Blackbeard approached them, smoke emitting from beneath his hat. "Deary deary me, what do we have here?" he growled.

"Just mundane travelers, looking for a little beach time. Fun in the sun, you might say," Raventhorpe gulped.

"Might I?" Blackbeard said skeptically. "Looks like critterly little spies to me, trying to espy Blackbeard's hideout."

Raventhorpe feigned ignorance. "Well, that's--that's just preposterous. And who's Blackbeard? Never heard of the guy."

The pirate's eyes flashed with anger, and he moved closer to the cage. "I'm the most feared pirate on the Seven Seas. The scourge of the West. The unmovable stone upon which ships wreck. The fire that consumes all that dare cross its path."

"Ohhhh, that Blackbeard. Yeah okay, I've heard of you." Raventhorpe turned to Ari. "We need to make a run for it."

Ari's breath hitched, his eyes darting between the cage and the approaching pirates. "Uh...Professor...we're still in the cage."

"On my signal," Raventhorpe said, kicking sand in Blackbeard's face to buy them a moment. "Now!"

He shoulder-rammed the cage, toppling it over, and the group bolted with the pirates in hot pursuit. The sound of pounding footsteps grew louder and louder, bearing down on them like a relentless predator.

Ari groaned as he hit the ground, his body aching from the fall. He looked up to see Raventhorpe pointing frantically in the direction that led deeper into the cave.

"We have to go that way," Raventhorpe said urgently,

"Blackbeard's hideout must be down there."

Ari was hesitant. "But it looks like a dead end," he said, pointing to the rough stone wall that blocked their path. "We'll be trapped...again."

Raventhorpe shook his head. "No time to worry about that now. We have to try."

The sound of Blackbeard's voice echoed through the cavern, growing louder with each passing second. Ari could feel the pirates' breath on his neck, their menacing laughter ringing in his ears. His heart raced as he realized they were running out of time.

"Come on," Raventhorpe urged, grabbing Ari by the arm and pulling him towards the wall. "Help me look for a way through."

Together, they scanned the wall, searching for any sign of an opening. But it seemed solid and impenetrable.

"We're never going to make it," Ari said, his voice trembling with fear.

Raventhorpe turned to him, his eyes blazing with determination. "We have to keep trying," he said firmly. "For the treasure. For our lives."

Ari nodded, steeling himself for what came next. He glanced at Raventhorpe and Julius, grateful for the companionship and support they'd provided throughout this harrowing journey. He knew that if they didn't find a way through, they would be caught by the pirates, and the thought of losing Raventhorpe and Julius filled him with

dread.

As they continued their daring escape, Ari couldn't help but steal a glance at Raventhorpe. The short, round, balding physics professor was an unlikely hero, yet there he was, fearlessly leading them through the treacherous caves and facing down the most notorious pirate in history. Ari was struck by a newfound sense of admiration for Raventhorpe, who was putting everything on the line for the success of their mission. He had never expected his unassuming physics professor to display such selflessness and bravery. In that moment, Ari felt grateful to have Raventhorpe by his side.

Raventhorpe let out a triumphant cry. "Look!" he exclaimed, pointing to a small crevice in the wall. "I think I see a way through!"

"Where? In there?" Cried Ari. He felt a surge of hope as he saw the opening, but also a sense of dread. It was narrow and dark, and he had no idea what lay on the other side.

He had no choice.

"Yeah, I'll go first to check it out," said Raventhorpe.

He followed Raventhorpe into the crevice, the darkness enveloping him. The walls pressed in on all sides, making it difficult to breathe.

"Where are we, Professor? No way Saturno has anything about this," said Ari, but the professor was in his own world, lost in discovery.

Ari's heart pounded in his chest, each step feeling like a

gamble.

"Look, we've come too far to turn back now," said the professor after what seemed like an eternity.

And then the walls gave way, opening up into a vast cavern. They had made it through.

"Well, would you look at that," said Raventhorpe, keeled over and panting.

But as they caught their breath, they heard the sound of approaching footsteps. Blackbeard and his pirates were closing in on them.

"Great. Now we're really trapped," Ari groaned, leaning against the wall in frustration.

But Raventhorpe's sharp senses had picked up on something. "Do you feel that?" he asked, his brow furrowed in concentration.

"Yeah, it's cooler down here," said Ari.

"Air coming from over there," Raventhorpe replied.

Ari followed him to the back of the cave, where Raventhorpe pointed out a small hole in the rock. "Don't tell me we're going down there," Ari said with a grimace.

Raventhorpe nodded resolutely. "Okay...but we are. It's either down the hole or walk the plank." Ari turned to the direction of the oncoming pirates.

"Alright, but give me a —" He grabbed Ari by the arm and jumped down the hole, with Julius following close behind.

Ari felt like he was falling for an eternity before he

landed on a rough surface, tumbling to the ground. He looked up to see Raventhorpe and Julius already on their feet, scanning the area around them.

"Second to get ready," Ari said.

Ari stood up, brushing himself off, and surveyed their surroundings. They were in a small cavern, with a tunnel leading off to one side. The air was thick with dust, and the walls were covered in a thin layer of moss.

"Where are we now?" Ari asked, looking to Raventhorpe for guidance.

"We're deeper in the caves," Raventhorpe replied, a determined glint in his eye. "And we're not stopping until we find a way out."

"Hey, genius, I'm smart enough to figure that much out," said Ari. He thought he saw Raventhorpe smile.

Raventhorpe's hands ran across the stone precipice, feeling for any indication of their next move. He paused as his fingers brushed against a rough edge, a glint of hope flashing in his eyes. Pushing on the rock wall, it gave way with a soft creak, and they slid down even further into the bowels of the cave.

The trio hit the stone precipice with a resounding thud, the air knocked out of them. Ari groaned in pain, rubbing his bruised ribs as he muttered, "Not gonna lie, that hurt. Remind me why we're doing this again?"

Raventhorpe, however, was already on his feet, his eyes fixed on something below. He peered out into the gloom,

the light flickering on the distant waters, and his heart leapt with joy. "It's the Queen Anne's Revenge," he exclaimed, "Blackbeard's ship. He must be hiding it in here until his next plunder."

Ari squinted in the direction of Raventhorpe's gaze, his breath catching at the sight of the massive pirate ship. "So...what do we do?" he asked, his voice laced with trepidation.

The Queen Anne's Revenge was an impressive sight to behold. Its immense size and heavily armed exterior spoke of its power and the terror it must have inspired in its victims. The sails were tattered and stained, bearing the marks of countless battles, while the hull was adorned with intricate carvings of sea creatures and mermaids. The ship's figurehead was a menacing, grinning skull, a clear symbol of the dread that Blackbeard's name carried.

Raventhorpe's eyes gleamed with determination as he met Ari's gaze. "We board the ship," he declared, his voice full of conviction.

Julius squeaked from atop Raventhorpe's shoulder as they climbed the ship's ladder. "I know, Julius, I can't believe we're here either."

"Ari, be a dear and look around for his treasure hold."

Ari was on the deck of the ship, admiring the craftsmanship of the pirate ship, and he wasn't watching where he was going. He stepped onto a thin board and cracked it, falling through and landing with a thud onto

something hard with a clang.

Raventhorpe rushed to the hole and peered in, "Ari, are you alright? Let me see if I can find something to pull you out of there."

Ari stood up and brushed himself off, laughing as he surveyed the area, "Hey, Professor, you and the squirrel should get down here. You're not gonna believe this."

"Chinchilla, not a squirrel, Ari," said the professor as he shimmied down into the hidden room.

The wealth on display was a testament to Blackbeard's success as a pirate. Gold and silver coins were piled high in every corner, glinting in the dim light. Jewels of every color adorned ornate goblets and platters, while intricately carved statues and artifacts from various civilizations filled the room. The hideout had a chaotic yet organized feel to it, with treasures grouped by origin and value. The walls were adorned with maps and charts, tracking the movements of merchant ships and rival pirates across the seas.

"This must be Blackbeard's hideout," Raventhorpe exclaimed.

Ari marveled at the abundance of riches. "Wow, check out all this stuff. The Tiara's gotta be here somewhere."

Raventhorpe nodded in agreement. "Let's start looking."

They scoured the room, but the Tiara remained elusive. Despite the vast collection of Egyptian treasures, their prize was not among them. "Well, at least we were right that

they had gone to Egypt.”

“Yeah, looks like they scored pretty big,” said Ari.

Raventhorpe's mood began to sink when Julius drew his attention to a collection of papers pinned to the wall with knives.

Julius squeaked in excitement, prompting Raventhorpe to take a closer look. "Wait a minute," he said as he examined the papers. The drawings depicted the Tiara and were accompanied by a map with several arrows pointing towards a forest in Yucatan, Mexico.

Ari peeked over his shoulder. "So, Blackbeard never had the Tiara in the first place. It's been in ancient Maya all this time."

Raventhorpe nodded. "You're getting good at this, Ari." He retrieved Saturno's book on treasures and flipped to a section on Yucatan civilizations. There he found a picture of The Missing Crown of Princess Namine. "Only thing in Saturno's book about tiaras in Yucatan is Princess Namine's," Raventhorpe explained. "This has to be Nefertari's tiara. It must have somehow fallen into the hands of the Mayans at some point."

Ari looked uncertain. "How are we going to find it if the most notorious pirate in history couldn't even do it?"

Raventhorpe smiled. "Blackbeard never had a time-traveling elevator at his disposal, not to mention Saturno's book. If the Tiara's in Mexico, we'll find it. Let's figure out the exact time period we need to travel to."

As Ari stared at the map, a mixture of excitement and anxiety stirred within him. He thought about the risks they had taken so far and the challenges that lay ahead. For a moment, he found himself questioning his own motivations for embarking on this treacherous journey. Was it the promise of an unimaginable fortune that drove him, or was it something deeper? A sense of purpose, a desire to prove his own worth, and a yearning for adventure that he had never dared to pursue before. As he stood there, contemplating his path, he realized that regardless of the outcome, this journey had already changed him, tested his limits, and shown him the depths of his own courage. With newfound determination, he nodded at Raventhorpe, ready to face whatever challenges awaited them in Mexico.

He read further into the book. "It says here the crown was only ever seen publicly on the night of the Princess's crowning ceremony. The same night she was promised to marry an Egyptian. 900 AD. After that, it was never seen again."

The room shook, Ari, Raventhorpe, and Julius turned to see Blackbeard and his band of blood-thirsty pirates barging in. The air turned thick with the stench of unwashed bodies and saltwater as the pirates approached with their weapons drawn.

Blackbeard towered over them, his eyes cold and merciless, his beard adorned with burning fuses that filled

the air with an acrid stench. His pirates were no less fearsome, each one a brutal and battle-hardened predator, their faces covered in scars and tattoos that spoke of a life filled with violence and ruthlessness. The air crackled with tension as the pirates' weapons glinted menacingly in the dim light, each blade promising a swift and brutal end for the trio. In that moment, Ari couldn't shake the feeling that their chances of making it out alive were dwindling rapidly. Yet, despite the overwhelming odds, he knew they had no choice but to face the danger head-on and fight for their survival.

"I see you've stumbled upon my secret hideout," Blackbeard says, his voice dripping with malice. "Not many people are privy to its whereabouts. Those that were, now sleep at the bottom of Davy Jones's locker. Care to join them?"

As Blackbeard cocked his sword back, Julius screamed and jumped across his face and scurried down his long, multi-pigtailed beard. Blackbeard yelled and flailed, clearly terrified.

"Ari, that's our cue," said Raventhorpe as they both turn to run directly at Blackbeard. The diversion gives Ari and Raventhorpe the opportunity to slide between Blackbeard's legs and fly out of the room, barging through his gang of pirates.

As they ran down the narrow passageway, the sound of Blackbeard's angry curses followed them. "Ahhh rat, rat,

rat! I hate rats!" he bellowed.

Once they are a safe distance away, Raventhorpe yells, "Chinchilla!" as Julius caught back up with them.

Ari looks over at the indicated ledge, his heart racing. It's a long shot, but it's their only chance. He nods to Raventhorpe, who pulled out the grappling hook and aimed for the ledge. The hook soared through the air and latched onto a rock, and Raventhorpe swung across the gap effortlessly. Ari followed, heart in his throat, as Julius clung to his shoulder for dear life.

"Julius, remind me to thank you for saving my life," said Ari, and Julius squeaked in thanks as he hugged his shoulder.

They landed on the ledge and looked back at the ship, where Blackbeard and his crew were now in hot pursuit. Raventhorpe wasted no time and quickly led the way, his short legs covering as much ground as they could as he sprinted towards the Elevator.

As they ran, Ari could hear the sound of the pirates' footsteps getting closer and closer. He glanced back; they were gaining ground. Panic rose in his chest.

"After you," said Raventhorpe, standing by the open door of the elevator as Ari and Julius dove in headfirst.

They all piled inside just as the pirates reached them.

"Close the doors!" Ari yelled, his heart pounding.

Raventhorpe hit the button to close the doors, and they slid shut just as Blackbeard's sword smashed into the side of

the elevator.

Through the doors, they could hear the unmistakable laugh of Blackbeard, and they all looked at each other as if not to believe what just happened. He was standing no more than a foot from the elevator doors.

"I've had enough of floor 1712. Going Down." He punched 900 into the floor guide.

The Elevator hummed as the timing belt started up.

"Wait!" Ari cried, holding out his hand.

"What?" said Raventhorpe.

"Can I press it?" Ari asked, his eyes shining with excitement.

Raventhorpe smiled wryly, passing the device to his eager companion. "Be my guest," he said as he and Julius shared a glance. "But please, soon, as I fear if we wait any longer we'll be pirate stew."

With a sense of elation, Ari pressed the button, and the elevator was engulfed in a blinding burst of white light. Electricity crackled around them as the machine sprang to life, hurtling them back in time.

The elevator whooshed away, leaving the pirates to tumble and fall over themselves in frustration. The thrill of victory surged through Ari and Raventhorpe as they disappeared into the many floors of the universe, leaving Blackbeard and his pirates in 1712.

Champollion

The vast halls of the British Museum loomed above Henry Salt, Giovanni Belzoni, and their motley crew, the stench of musty tomes and priceless artifacts filling the air. The grand architecture of the museum, with its high ceilings adorned with intricate frescoes and towering marble columns supporting its magnificent structure, emphasized the importance of the treasures it held. Dimly lit corridors, lined with glass display cases, showcased delicate ceramics and statues from various civilizations, their stories waiting

to be told.

Mahgdi, hands bound and face etched with fear, was led by Belzoni to an ornate table laden with ancient scrolls and mysterious relics. Salt couldn't help but feel a sense of apprehension in the presence of such knowledge, the secrets of the past whispering to him from every corner. His heart raced, knowing the importance of what they were about to uncover.

With a flourish, Salt produced the golden compass Belzoni had retrieved from the short fat bald man in Nefertari's tomb. Its polished surface gleamed in the museum's dim light. "This compass," he began, excitement lacing his voice, "may hold the key to finding the tiara. And there's someone here who can help us unlock its secrets."

Curiosity piqued, the group watched as Salt beckoned to a young man standing in the shadows. With a hesitant step, the prodigy emerged, revealing a face that seemed to be an enigma of youth and ancient wisdom. "This is Jean-François Champollion," Salt announced, pride swelling in his chest. "He is a genius, a prodigy who has nearly deciphered the Egyptian language using the Rosetta Stone as his guide. His groundbreaking work has the potential to unlock countless secrets of this ancient civilization."

Belzoni eyed the young man with a mix of suspicion and intrigue. "And he can help us with this compass?" he asked, his voice betraying a hint of doubt.

"I believe so," Salt replied, a determined glint in his eye.

He handed the compass to Champollion and asked, "Tell us, what should we be looking for?"

Champollion examined the compass with great care, his fingers tracing the intricate markings etched into its surface. He turned it over, revealing the X made out of two match sticks. His eyes suddenly lit up with understanding, and he declared, "I know exactly how to find the tiara."

The air in the room grew thick with anticipation as Champollion continued, "This compass would have led anyone who found it to Blackbeard and his pirates. They were once here, searching for the tiara, but they left Egypt empty-handed. The tiara had already been taken from the tomb centuries before their arrival." The faint sound of footsteps echoing through the museum's halls and the distant ticking of an ancient clock heightened the tension as the group listened intently to the young prodigy's revelation.

Belzoni's fury erupted like a volcano, his voice booming through the halls of the museum. "How does this help us find the tiara, boy?!" His impatience was driven by the constant pressure he felt to prove his worth and secure his place among the elite explorers of the time. The tiara represented more than a treasure; it was a symbol of validation and success, a goal he'd pursued relentlessly throughout his life.

Champollion remained surprisingly calm, his gaze steady and unwavering. "If it is true that time travelers left with

this clue, then I can only imagine where they will end up," he said cryptically.

He leaned forward, his voice barely above a whisper. "If you want the tiara, then I know exactly what you'll need to do."

With a snarl, Belzoni strode towards Champollion, towering over him like a tempestuous storm. He grabbed the young prodigy by the neck, his breath hot with rage. "The next words out of your mouth had better lead me to the tiara, boy."

Before the situation could escalate further, Salt intervened, pushing Belzoni away from Champollion. "Let the boy speak," he urged, desperation lacing his voice.

Belzoni released Champollion with a growl, his eyes never leaving the young man's face.

Champollion, seemingly unfazed by the confrontation, leaned back in his chair and readjusted himself, a glint of confidence in his eyes as he continued, "In fact, what you need is right here in this very museum, in a section you know very, very well and have helped create and add to."

Belzoni's gaze shifted from Champollion to the British Museum's collection of Egyptian antiquities, and he began to laugh, a mixture of relief and excitement bubbling within him.

Namine

The Elevator's floor indicator read "900 AD" as it emerged from a blinding column of light, its metallic frame hissing and crackling with electric energy. A familiar ding to indicate the floor destination had been reach rung out into the night air. The doors slid open with a mechanical hum, and Raventhorpe and Ari stepped out, their eyes adjusting to the dimness of their surroundings. A sudden shrill screech from Julius jolted them back to reality, and they peered over the edge of the precipice they found

themselves on. They were at the summit of El Castillo in Chichen Itza, a vertiginous drop to the jungle floor below. A giant, now famous pyramid built by the ancient Mayans.

"Whoa, whoa, whoa..." Raventhorpe muttered, gripping the frame of the Elevator to steady himself. Ari gulped, his face pale as he stared at the yawning abyss beneath them. "We have to figure out how to steer this thing," he said, his voice trembling with fear.

Ari peered out, "That's a long way down," said Ari.

Taking a deep, steadying breath, they cautiously stepped out onto the ancient stone platform, scanning their surroundings.

"We need to get our bearings to find the Princess," said the professor.

He scanned the horizon from the top of the pyramid. The breathtaking view revealed a vast sea of trees and vines stretching out to the horizon, seemingly endless in the moonlit night. The treetops of the dense jungle canopy below glistened with dew, and they could make out the tops of Mayan ruins hidden among the foliage. Flickers of torchlight illuminated areas within the tangled mass of trees and vines, adding an air of mystery and foreboding to the scene. It was difficult to comprehend that they had traveled back in time nearly a thousand years.

"Okay, I see it, watch your step," Raventhorpe warned, cautiously edging towards the steep, winding staircase that led down the side of the pyramid. His movements were

deliberate, his eyes scanning each step for loose stones or hidden hazards. "We have to climb down."

Raventhorpe led the way, navigating the treacherous descent with ease, his keen senses attuned to the environment. Ari and Julius trailed behind, their movements clumsy and uncertain in comparison. As they exited the pyramid, Raventhorpe was already ahead of them pointing at what appeared to be a royal mayan structure, the moon cast an ominous glow on the impressive structure, casting eerie shadows that sent shivers down Ari's spine.

"That's it," Raventhorpe said, pointing to the palace. "The stone palace where Princess Namine was just coronated. That means the Tiara should be in there."

Ari looked up at the towering structure, the intricately carved stone reminded him in some ways of what he saw in Egypt. "Okay, so what's the plan?" he asked, turning to Raventhorpe.

"We storm the castle," Raventhorpe declared, a hint of excitement in his voice.

Ari and Julius exchanged worried glances. "Uh, maybe we should sneak in instead?" Ari suggested, hesitant to take such a reckless approach.

Raventhorpe rolled his eyes. "Fine, we'll sneak in. Jeez, you two have no sense of adventure," he replied, his tone dripping with sarcasm.

They approached the palace walls, darting from shadow

to shadow, careful not to attract attention. As they crept closer, Ari's heart raced with anticipation. They were so close to finding the Tiara.

"Alright I'll climb up there first and get a look at it," said Raventhorpe turning back to Ari but Ari was gone. He turned back to the palace to see Ari half way up the wall.

"Slow down Ari we're coming up behind you," said Raventhorpe.

They toppled over a stone wall into the room and joined Ari he was waiting for them.

"About time," he said with a smile.

"Very funny," Raventhorpe replied.

The room was bathed in the soft glow of the moonlight, the silvery rays reflecting off the ornate, hand-carved furniture. They searched frantically for the elusive Tiara, their hands moving over every surface, their eyes scanning every corner of Princess Namine's room.

"It's got to be here. Look for any royal cases or stashes with this emblem on them," the professor said holding up a page of Saturno's book.

"There aren't many places to look in here and I see nothing," said Ari

Raventhorpe slammed his fist against the wooden table, sending a quiver through the delicate items that adorned it. "Darn!"

Ari shook his head, his voice tinged with disappointment. "Maybe we're too late. Or maybe she's

wearing it.”

“Could be but,” Raventhorpe insisted, his eyes narrowing with determination. "This is the date, it has to be here. We're missing something."

The faint sound of murmuring voices drifted down the hallway.

“Is that what I think it is?” Asked Ari his eyes widening.

Raventhorpe's head snapped up, his keen ears catching the sound of approaching footsteps. "Quick, hide!" The trio scrambled to find cover behind the elaborate furniture.

"I'll be in my room," came the voice of Princess Namine, her footsteps growing louder as she neared.

The door creaked open, and the seventeen-year-old princess stepped into the room, a beautiful gold amulet draped around her slender neck. The unique ankh symbol with an eye at the center was engraved on it, shining brightly in the moonlight. Her delicate hands fidgeted with the amulet as she sat down at her desk, her shoulders shaking as she began to sob.

Julius squeaked something into Raventhorpe's ear, and the scientist's eyes widened in realization. He whispered urgently to Ari, "You're right. That amulet - it has the same symbol as the Tiara. I'm sure of it."

"So what does that mean?" Ari asked, his brow furrowed in confusion.

"They're connected somehow," Raventhorpe explained, his voice low and urgent. "The Tiara isn't here, so we need

to get that amulet."

Ari's eyes widened with disbelief. "That's crazy. She's wearing it."

Raventhorpe gave him a knowing smile. "You're going to have to charm her. But remember, Ari, if you fail, we might not get another chance at this. The fate of ur quest lies in your hands."

Ari swallowed hard, realizing the gravity of the situation. "Uhhhh..."

"That natural talent you have, time to put it to use."

Before Ari could protest, the princess called out, her voice filled with suspicion. "Who's there?" They froze, their hearts pounding in their chests.

Princess Namine moved cautiously toward the source of the noise, her eyes searching for an intruder. Ari took a deep breath and popped up from his hiding place, causing the princess to startle.

"Hi there," he greeted, his voice smooth and disarming.

"Who are you?" Namine demanded, her eyes narrowing with suspicion.

"My name is Ari Buktu," he replied, his tone charming and disarming.

"What are you doing in my room?" she asked, her voice wavering with fear.

Ari hesitated, his nerves getting the better of him. "Fair question. Ummm...I simply had to see you in person. I had heard of your beauty...being so...great. And your

eyes...flooding like...water mains? So...I--uh--there you go."

Raventhorpe exchanged a puzzled glance with Julius, who shrugged helplessly. "What's he talking about?"

"I should call the guards," Namine threatened, her hand reaching for the door.

"Wait, wait, no," Ari pleaded, his voice desperate. "I'm sorry. We're travelers. Explorers. That amulet you're wearing, it might be a clue to what we're looking for."

"So you are thieves?" Namine accused, her eyes narrowing further. "Did you take my Tiara?"

"No, no," Ari hurried to explain. "We're looking for your Tiara. We know it came from Egypt—"

"It was a fake," Namine interrupted, her voice bitter. "A ploy to impress my father. And enough to fool the thieves who stole it."

"Oh..." Ari faltered, unsure how to proceed. "And your amulet?"

"Seems real enough..."

"Can I...may I see it?" Ari asked, his voice gentle and persuasive. "If you say no, we'll get out of here and leave you alone."

"Why do you need my amulet?" Namine inquired, her eyes searching Ari's face for any hint of deception.

"My friend..." Ari trailed off, gesturing to Raventhorpe, who reluctantly stood up from his hiding spot. "He's in love with this woman, Dolores. Your amulet might help us

find this Tiara so he can show her how much he loves her."

"So you do this for love?" Namine asked, her expression softening.

"Yes," Ari confirmed, his voice filled with sincerity.

After a moment's hesitation, Namine removed the amulet from around her neck. "This was gifted to me by the man I am to marry. A man from Egypt who has wooed my father but failed to win my heart." She handed the amulet to Ari, her gaze resolute. "Here. Take it. I no longer want my life decided for me."

Ari accepted the amulet with a grateful nod. "Thank you, Princess."

"I hope you find what you are looking for," Namine said, a small smile playing at the corners of her lips.

Their moment of connection was shattered by the sudden arrival of two Mayan guards, who burst through the door with spears raised. "Princess Namine, we heard voices."

"That's our cue Prof, let's get outta here," said Ari.

The guards spotted Ari and Raventhorpe and lunged toward them, their weapons gleaming dangerously in the moonlight. Raventhorpe acted quickly, kicking a wooden stool at the guards with enough force to splinter it on impact. He grabbed Ari by the arm, pulling him toward the window.

Outside, they found themselves on a narrow, crumbling ledge, a dizzying drop below them. Ari glanced nervously

over the edge, his heart pounding as he saw the jagged rocks waiting far below. "Got any of those fancy gadgets on you, by chance?"

Raventhorpe patted his pockets, shaking his head. "Fresh out, Ari. Guess we'll have to jump."

Ari's eyes widened with fear. "Think I'll stick to climbing."

As they made their daring escape, Ari couldn't help but feel a renewed sense of determination. Raventhorpe and Ari clung to the rough stone exterior of the palace, their fingers clinging to narrow crevices as they descended. The wind whipped around them, the ground far below a terrifying reminder of the danger they faced.

Ari reached the bottom first, his feet touching solid ground with a sigh of relief. "Alright come on Professor they're gonna be here any second with like spears and stuff."

Just as he turned to look up, Raventhorpe's scream filled the air. The eccentric scientist had abandoned his climb, choosing instead to leap from the ledge with Julius clinging to his head for dear life.

Ari watched in horror as Raventhorpe plummeted toward the earth, only to be caught at the last second by the outstretched branches of a nearby tree. Shaking his head in disbelief, Ari waited as the scientist shimmied down the tree trunk, brushing leaves and sticks from his hair before joining him on the ground.

"Let me see that amulet," Raventhorpe said, his eyes gleaming with curiosity. Ari handed it over, and the scientist examined it closely. He pulled out his Saturno book and flipped it open, comparing the amulet to the images within.

"Just as I thought," he declared triumphantly. "This amulet belonged to Nefertari." He showed Ari a picture of the Tiara, pointing out the same ankh symbol that adorned the amulet. "See the unique ankh symbol with the eye in the center?"

"Yeah," Ari replied, nodding in understanding.

"Very few Egyptian artifacts have been found with that exact symbol," Raventhorpe continued. "These were forged by the same craftsman."

"Great," Ari said, his voice tinged with frustration. "Then just give this amulet to Dolores and she'll fall in love with you and I can stop climbing down every structure in the history of the world."

"No," Raventhorpe insisted, his voice firm. "It has to be the Tiara. I can't settle. Would you settle for anything but the best for your life Ari? For your future?"

Ari hesitated, then shook his head. "No."

"Exactly," Raventhorpe said, his voice filled with resolve. "Now, the next plan..."

Ari's rolled his eyes as took a step closer to hear Raventhorpe out.

"It says here that this symbol only appeared one other

time in history," he continued, scanning the pages of his book. "An artifact was sold in an auction to a P. Sampson. A royal bust with a setting for the amulet. Once the amulet is placed in the bust, it should point the way to other artifacts with that symbol. Like the—"

"Tiara," Ari finished for him, his determination renewed. "So where's this Sampson?"

Raventhorpe's finger traced a line of text on the page. "He had a castle in Italy."

"Any chance it's in 2023?" Ari asked, hoping for an easier journey.

"Sorry," Raventhorpe replied with a slight grin. "1819."

Ari sighed, steeling himself for the next leg of their adventure. "Well, let's go storm a castle."

"Thataboy, Ari," Raventhorpe said, clapping him on the shoulder.

Before they could make their escape, a shout from behind them stopped them in their tracks. "Stop!" A group of Mayan guards appeared outside the palace, their spears, blowguns, and bows and arrows at the ready.

"Whoops," Raventhorpe muttered, his eyes darting around for an escape route. "Almost forgot we're being chased. We'd better get moving."

With that, the trio took off through the jungle, their hearts pounding in their chests as they raced toward their next destination, the guards hot on their heels.

An arrow whizzed past Ari's head. "Professor they're

shooting at us!”

They sprinted through the dense jungle, their breaths coming in ragged gasps as they evaded the relentless pursuit of the Mayan guards. Arrows, spears, and blow darts whistled through the air, narrowly missing the trio as they dodged and weaved, their eyes set on the towering structure of El Castillo.

The ancient stone pyramid loomed before them, and they charged up its steep steps, their muscles burning with the effort. Reaching the top, they made a desperate leap into the Elevator, the door sliding shut just as the guards closed in.

“I’m gonna be dynamite on a stair master after this whole thing,” said Raventhorpe as they reached the top of the pyramid.

Julius squeaked and frantically entered the new coordinates, his paws shaking with adrenaline. Raventhorpe entered out of breather and gasped, “Going up,”slamming his palm down on the red button.

"You got it, Professor," Ari replied, his heart still racing.

The familiar white light enveloped them, electricity crackling through the air as the Elevator whirred to life. The sensation of time slipping away washed over them, and in an instant, they were whisked away from the jungles of the Yucatán and into the unknown.

As they prepared to face the challenges that lay ahead in 1819 Italy, Ari couldn't help but feel a surge of excitement.

He pulled the amulet from his pocket and looked at it, each new discovery brought them one step closer to the elusive Tiara.

P. Sampson

The elevator hissed and stuttered as it came to a rest and the Professor and Julius got out to make sure everything was ok. A couple arrows from the mayan warriors were stuck in its side from floor 900.

Julius looked at the elevator and squeaked at the professor emphatically.

The professor careened his neck inspecting a specific spot.

“Shouldn’t be a problem. She’s seen a lot of action as of

late. We'll take good care of her when we get back."

Julius insisted with more emphatic squeaks.

"Now now Julius she'll be alright. She's designed to withstand temperatures from the ice age."

As Ari emerged from the elevator their focus all turned to the biting cold of the Italian Dolomites. The snow-covered mountains stretched out as far as the eye could see, their beauty marred only by the chilling wind that howled and whipped around them. The mountains' jagged peaks pierced the sky, their icy surfaces glittering in the sunlight. Snow-blanketed slopes swept downward, forming a breathtaking landscape of pristine white. The crisp, alpine air stung their lungs, a stark reminder of the altitude at which they now stood. Ari shivered, pulling his hoodie on his blue sweatshirt over his head.

"Next time we time travel, let's pack for all seasons," he said, teeth chattering.

Raventhorpe grinned. "Next time, Ari?"

"I'm starting to get the hang of it." Said Ari as they exchanged a brief, knowing smile - the thrill of their adventure temporarily pushing away the cold.

"You sure the elevator is going to hold up in this weather?" Asked Ari as he looked at the snow building up around the base of the elevator.

"She'll be fine. Besides, I can fix anything. We've got work to do my boy." Said Raventhorpe.

Raventhorpe turned his attention to the castle that

loomed in the distance. The castle perched precariously on a rocky outcrop, its dark stone walls and imposing towers seeming to merge with the mountainside. A sense of foreboding emanated from the fortress, as if daring intruders to challenge the treacherous terrain that lay ahead. The castle's towering silhouette cast a shadow over the valley below, a chilling reminder of the power and influence that once resided within its walls. The jagged, treacherous mountains stood between them and their destination, an imposing sight that would force them to climb once more.

"Now if we're right then the Tiara is in that castle. Ready for some more climbing?" Raventhorpe asked, amusement in his voice.

Ari pulled out his grappling hook, resigned to their fate. "Do I have a choice? Hey, in the future, can we just land in the castle?"

He had taken a liking to the grappling hook. His hands were starting to form calluses from all of the action and his feet felt like he could use a week's vacation. As he stood up his back pinched and throbbed like he had carried 50 pound sacks up and down a mountain for an entire day.

Raventhorpe shook his head. "Too dangerous. We need to land somewhere with a lot of space, otherwise we might end up inside a wall...or a person."

Ari grimaced. "Gross."

Ari aimed and unleashed the hook. "Here goes nothin."

He hesitated, assessing the sturdiness of the grappling hook before trusting his full weight to the rope. He glanced back at Raventhorpe and Julius, who had already commenced their ascent through some rocky outcroppings. They tackled the rocky mountainside, each adopting their unique rhythm and pace. Each undoubtedly sore from the previous floors of the universe. Though Ari could never tell Raventhorpe was feeling anything at all. The wind roared around them, yet they persisted, their muscles straining and their breaths growing more labored. Julius, with his small size and agility, climbed with ease, occasionally squeaking in encouragement.

As they approached the castle, the imposing fortress seemed to grow even larger, its shadow stretching out over the land. The path to the castle wound its way up the steep mountainside, each step bringing them closer to the forbidding structure. The stone walls loomed ever larger, ancient and weathered, their surfaces covered in a thick layer of frost that glistened in the sunlight. The castle's intricate architecture hinted at its storied past, with elaborate carvings and gargoyles that seemed to watch them with unblinking stone eyes.

The entrance was a massive wooden door, reinforced with iron, that appeared to have stood sentinel for centuries, barring passage to any who dared approach. Raventhorpe studied it, trying to discern the best way to gain entry.

"So..." he mused, "why don't we just knock on the front door?"

Ari snorted. "Sure he'd be more than happy to allow us to ransack his priceless artifacts."

Raventhorpe continued to size up the castle. "How tall are you, Ari?"

"Hey now that's personal," Ari replied, a hint of sarcasm in his voice.

"Do you think you could hop from window to window?" Raventhorpe asked, a plan forming in his mind. His back was arched and he was following the row of windows toward what looked like a room large enough to treasures of all sizes and shapes.

"Awww man..." Ari groaned.

Julius, however, found the situation amusing and laughed. Raventhorpe pointed to a nearby ledge. "Here, get up on this first ledge and see."

Ari was getting used to being Raventhorpe's Guinea pig and in some way he took pride in being integral and valuable to some cause greater than playing video games with his friends. As he hung from a window near the entry point, Ari and Raventhorpe exchanged glances of mutual understanding and pride, their thoughts briefly drifting to the impact this discovery would have on their lives and relationships. Julius, perched on Raventhorpe's shoulder, squeaked excitedly as they examined the artifact.

"Alright I'm gonna go in now." Said Ari. "Wait for me

and I'll find a way to let you guys in ok?"

Inside P. Sampson's castle, Ari arrived, panting, in a dimly lit room. Before he had time to even take in the room, Raventhorpe and Julius entered through a door, much to Ari's disbelief.

"Are you kidd--" he began, but Raventhorpe cut him off.

"What? Julius found an open door. Okay now, if I were a royal Egyptian bust, where would I be? We're on the verge of actually accomplishing something. It doesn't get much better than this."

Together, they began searching the castle, their footsteps echoing in the vast, halls decorated with artifacts from all over the world. P. Sampson had collected near and far and the collection could fill several museums. The castle's interior was a labyrinth of dimly lit corridors, grand rooms, and hidden passages, all adorned with intricate stonework and rich tapestries that had faded with the passage of time. The air was cold and musty, filled with the scent of decay and the weight of history. The rooms they explored seemed long abandoned, their once-opulent furnishings now covered in layers of dust and the tattered remnants of their former splendor. The castle felt as if nobody ever lived here. A storage facility of some sort.

As Ari, Raventhorpe, and Julius approached what appeared to be some kind of research room, adorned with maps and variations of Earth globes from centuries past, a

wave of excitement washed over them. They could sense that they were on the cusp of a monumental discovery, one that would ultimately help Raventhorpe win back Dolores's heart in the present day.

The research room was a cavernous space, its high ceilings supported by towering stone columns that disappeared into the shadows above. Bookshelves lined the walls, sagging under the weight of countless volumes, while tables and cabinets overflowed with a dizzying array of artifacts and curiosities. The room's only source of light was a series of narrow, arched windows that cast long, eerie shadows on the stone floor. A palpable sense of history and knowledge seemed to hang in the air, as if the secrets contained within the room's myriad objects were waiting to be unlocked. The air was thick with dust and the scent of old parchment.

“Ari this has to be the place.” Said the professor. “Keep your wits about you. Julius move to level nine recon mode. And uh...”

“And uh what?” Said Ari.

“Watch out for traps.”

Ari's heart raced in his chest, his eyes wide with anticipation as they now stood in the center of the room. He couldn't help but imagine the joy and gratitude that would light up Dolores's face once they retrieved the tiara. He glanced at Raventhorpe, noticing the professor's usually stoic expression now softened by a hint of

giddiness.

“Professor you’re going to have the record for best first date gift of all time.” Ari said jokingly.

Raventhorpe, too, felt a surge of emotion as they moved closer to their goal. “I don’t mess around Ari.” He said with a grin already allowing himself to feel the glow of victory.

The weight of their past struggles seemed to lift ever so slightly from his shoulders, and he allowed himself a small, hopeful smile. Deep down, he wondered if this moment would finally bring him the chance to woo Dolores with the tiara, the ultimate statement of love.

Julius squeaked so loud and excitedly it almost knocked Ari to the ground, when they turned to see him he as standing atop the bust of Nefertari. Ari and Raventhorpe exchanged a look of pure elation. Their hands trembled with excitement as they examined the artifact, and they couldn't contain their enthusiasm any longer.

Ari's eyes immediately fell from the bust to the unique ankh symbol engraved on the bottom right portion of it.

"Is that it?" he asked, excitement creeping into his voice.

“Ladies and gentlemen it appears we’ve found the bust. Great job Julius,” chuckled Raventhorpe his ear to ear smile hidden under his large white beard.

They stepped closer, examining the bust.

“Ari the amulet please,” said Raventhorpe. Ari’s palms were sweaty. His heart was pounding. He reached in his

sweatshirt and pulled out the amulet, studying it for a moment before placing it in a setting around Nefertari's neck. It seemed to be the perfect size but he just had to fit it into the right place. Carefully, he rotated the amulet into the setting.

"I think I got it," said Ari.

They all stepped back to observe fruits of their efforts but nothing happened.

Their shock was palpable. "What? Impossible. You must've put it in wrong," Raventhorpe said, frustration coloring his voice.

Ari hated when he got like this, like they were back in class and he was correcting him without considering the fact that Ari did do it correctly.

He snatched the amulet away and attempted to place it back into the setting himself, but to no avail. He tried spinning it and jamming it in, but nothing worked.

"Julius I don't understand. This is supposed to work," he muttered, growing more agitated.

"Maybe Saturno was wrong," Ari suggested, watching Raventhorpe's fruitless efforts.

Raventhorpe snapped straight up and looked sternly at Ari, "Saturno's never wrong," Raventhorpe snapped.

Ari sensing that he hit a sore spot continued on, "Hey, maybe this is it. This is where the adventure ends."

"No, it's gotta work!" Raventhorpe insisted as he tried other combinations. He pulled out Saturno's book and

began to rifle through it frantically.

Defeated, Raventhorpe lowered the book and hung his head. They were at a dead end, with no choice but to give up. Julius, however, had other ideas. The small creature scurried around the room, searching for something - anything - that could help.

Ari placed a hand on his shoulder. "Hey come on Professor I was only kidding we'll figure this out."

"It's no use, Julius. We should just go home," Raventhorpe said, his voice heavy with disappointment. "And why would you kid in a time like this. Nefertari's tomb or Blackbeard's hideout sure, but now after all of this?"

"Hey take it easy professor," said Ari.

Julius spotted something in a crack of an armoire and scrambled inside, reemerging with something in his mouth. It was too big to fit through the small hole. He began to squeak.

"What is that?" Raventhorpe asked, curious.

Julius continued to try and tug the object free, but it remained stuck. Raventhorpe attempted to open the armoire, but it was locked.

"Quick, Ari, look for a key," he ordered.

Ari desperately searched the room for a key, while Julius watched them for a moment before looking up at the lock. An idea formed in his tiny mind, and he ran up the armoire to squeeze himself into the lock. After a tense moment,

there was a click and the door popped open.

Raventhorpe and Ari hadn't noticed Julius's success. "The key has to be here somewhere," Raventhorpe muttered.

Julius reappeared and cleared his throat, trying to get their attention. Raventhorpe didn't look up. "This isn't a joke. Keep looking, Ari."

"Ok, ok I'm sorry I joked around," said Ari now more agitated than anything else.

Growing more frustrated, Julius let out a squeak, finally catching Raventhorpe's attention.

"What — Oh look, the door's open. Ari you can stop looking," he said, nonchalant.

Julius rolled his eyes and hopped down as they opened the armoire. Inside was a beautiful gilded-edged box with intricate decorative details on all sides, the unique ankh symbol in the center. There was a setting on the front of the box that appeared to be the right size for the amulet.

"Holding the box out, Raventhorpe said, "Ari..."

Ari was almost hypnotized by what he had just seen.

"Yeah," he said and he reached in with the amulet, placed it in the setting, twisted it, and...click.

The ankh symbol began to rotate, gears clicking and whirring on the inside. The three adventurers watched intently as the box continued to make noises before suddenly stopping.

They stared at the box, then at each other, then back at

the box when the top suddenly popped open, startling them.

Inside was a detailed sculpture of an Egyptian temple. The miniature temple was a masterpiece of craftsmanship, its intricate details and lifelike proportions a testament to the skill of the artist who had created it. The temple appeared as it would have in ancient times, its sandstone walls adorned with colorful hieroglyphs and images of the gods. The sculpture seemed to transport them back to a time when the temple had stood proud and resplendent against the backdrop of the Egyptian desert, a monument to the power and wealth of its creators. The miniature began to move and shift, revealing a hidden room inside with a tiny tiara on a pedestal in the center.

"A hidden room in Nefertari's temple in Abu Simbel. Not her tomb, her temple. It was in Egypt the whole time!" Raventhorpe exclaimed, exhilaration in his voice.

Ari grinned, though his tone was sarcastic. "Wow, it's almost like we didn't have to time travel to three other periods in history and escape the jaws of death on multiple occasions."

Raventhorpe smiled back. "Oh, it'll be worth it, I assure you."

"So what's the difference between the tombs and temples anyways," asked Ari.

"Well according to Saturno the temples are like the homes of the gods and the tombs are where the royals are

buried with their riches,” Raventhorpe replied.

“But I don’t understand why would the tiara be in the home of the gods if it was one of her riches?” Ari Asked.

But before Raventhorpe could continue, Mahgdi, their cheerful Egyptian friend, burst into the room, locking it behind him, breathless and wide-eyed with panic. "Hurry, hurry!" he cried, "The bad man from Egypt is here! You must leave at once!"

Ari, surprised by Mahgdi's sudden appearance, asked, "Mahgdi, what are you doing here?"

Mahgdi, gasping for breath, quickly replied, "I was taken prisoner by the bad man just after you left Egypt. I just now escaped to warn you – it's a trap!"

“Oh I don’t believe this,” mutter Ari to himself.

The door blast open, ripped off on the hinges by a single blow and fell in a thud. The unmistakable silhouette of The Great Belzoni entered through the doorway. Behind him Sarah, and James Curtin appeared, blocking the exit path for everyone inside. Belzoni cracked his whip menacingly, a sinister smile on his face.

"I see Mahgdi managed to slip away, but it seems he was too late to be of any help to you," Belzoni taunted. He then held up the golden compass from the tomb of Nefertari, smirking. "And this compass you left behind made things so much easier for us."

Raventhorpe's face flushed with embarrassment.

“How did you find us? We didn’t tell Mahgdi anything.”

Raventhorpe demanded, his voice low and dangerous.

"The owner of this grand castle..." Belzoni began, stepping into the room.

"It belongs to P. Sampson," Raventhorpe interrupted, his eyes narrowed.

Belzoni bowed, a wicked grin on his face. "The Patagonian Sampson at your service. That name served me well all those years in the circus. Guess you didn't read about that in your little book."

"I must have missed that part," Raventhorpe admitted, his voice dripping with sarcasm.

Ari couldn't help but ask, "So what were you, a clown?"

Raventhorpe hissed under his breath, "Don't provoke the giant, Ari..."

Belzoni glared at Ari, then suddenly picked up Mahgdi's miniature baklava stand and crushed it with his bare hands. The room seemed to shrink around them, the air growing heavier with tension.

"Yes, a very, very strong clown," Ari whispered to Raventhorpe.

The Great Escape

The air inside P. Sampson's castle was cold and damp, reminiscent of a tomb. Soft, dim lighting cast eerie shadows across the stone walls, as if the very building were a living thing, breathing and watching the tense confrontation unfolding within its bowels.

Ari, Professor Raventhorpe and The Great Belzoni stood facing one another. The distance between them seemed to stretch. Their breaths hung in the cold air, creating wispy clouds that seemed to dissipate as quickly as they formed.

Julius glanced back and forth between them.

"I think we got off on the wrong foot," Raventhorpe said, his voice strained. "How about we start over and be friends?"

Ari's eyes narrowed in suspicion. "Hey Beltoni. What do you want?"

At that moment, Belzoni stepped forward, his massive frame casting an ominous shadow across the room. "The box," he demanded, his deep voice reverberating off the stone walls. "Hand it over. The Tiara is mine. The power it wields belongs to me."

Ari's eyes widened in shock as Belzoni's whip cracked through the air, the sound like a gunshot in the confined space. "Power?" he asked, his voice barely above a whisper. "Wait, professor, wanna clue me in on what he's talking about?"

Belzoni smirked, a cruel glint in his eyes. "You didn't tell your little friend here?" He leaned in closer, his voice taking on an ominous tone. "The Tiara possesses a living force unmatched in this world. It's said that the one who unlocks it shall himself become the vessel of this power. Giovanni Battista Belzoni will be the strongest, most powerful man in the world!"

Sarah, standing nearby, cleared her throat pointedly. Belzoni glanced over at her and amended his statement. "Of course, and yes, you too, sweetheart. You shall be the strongest, most powerful woman in the world. Goes

without saying."

"Well, you should have said it," Sarah retorted, her voice dripping with annoyance.

"I'm sorry," Belzoni said, sounding anything but apologetic.

"I'm sure you are," Sarah replied, her eyes narrowing.

"Can we talk about this later?" Belzoni asked, eager to return to the matter at hand.

"Oh, we will," Sarah promised, her voice cold and hard.

Ari and Raventhorpe exchanged awkward looks as the tension between Belzoni and Sarah simmered. James Curtin, keen to establish his own place in this unfolding drama, piped up, "Can we also pencil in some time to talk about where I fit into this?"

Belzoni and Sarah both snapped at him in unison, "Shut up, Jim."

Refocusing his attention on Raventhorpe and Ari, Belzoni continued, "Two years I waited for you to reappear. To bring me the amulet, the last piece of the puzzle."

Raventhorpe's jaw clenched as he stared Belzoni down, determination etched on his face. "I'm not giving you the box."

"No matter," Belzoni growled, his eyes gleaming with malice. "I'll pry it from your cold, dead hands."

Julius squeaked in fear, causing Belzoni to lumber menacingly toward them, with travel-sized James

following behind as his "back-up." Sarah stayed by the door, smirking at their imminent demise.

Ari glanced at Raventhorpe, his voice rising in panic. "Plan?"

"Working on it," Raventhorpe replied, his eyes darting around the room for an escape route.

As Belzoni cracked his knuckles, Ari urged Raventhorpe under his breath, "Work faster."

He turned to Belzoni, "Hey no need to get all Knuckle cracky over this."

In a desperate attempt to slow Belzoni down, Raventhorpe flipped a chair in front of him. Unfazed, Belzoni brushed it off like it was nothing.

"That was the plan?" Ari said in disbelief.

"Run!" Raventhorpe shouted.

"Where?" Ari cried out.

"Anywhere!" Raventhorpe responded.

They scrambled around the room, narrowly staying ahead of Belzoni and James. As they split up, James pursued Raventhorpe, while Belzoni barreled towards Ari. With Sarah blocking the door, Ari had nowhere to run.

"Where are you going, little man?" she taunted, grabbing Ari and pinning him down.

"Yeesh, you're strong," Ari gasped, struggling under her grip.

"Did you think my husband was the only one to perform feats in the circus?" Sarah asked, her voice laced with

contempt.

Ari grunted, attempting to throw her off. "Ah, so were you the clown then. Professor, I hope this plan has an ending where we're still alive."

"Me too," Raventhorpe muttered as Belzoni stomped over to Ari, still pinned by Sarah. His wide grin stretched across his broad face, a sinister sight.

In that moment, Julius scampered up to the window, peering out before squeaking and pointing. Raventhorpe dodged James, who tumbled over the crushed chair on the floor, and joined Julius by the window. As he flung it open, he called out, "Ari!"

Ari managed to wriggle free from Sarah's grasp, barely escaping Belzoni's giant fist as he made his way to the window.

"Jump!" Raventhorpe yelled.

"What is with you and jumping off buildings?" Ari complained, though he knew there was no other option.

"It's the only way," Raventhorpe insisted, his eyes filled with determination.

Mahgdi, who had been sitting in the shadows joined them at the last possible second. They climbed up onto the window sill and jumped, Belzoni's whip cracking at their heels.

"They can't survive that sir." an out of breath doubled of Jim mustered.

Outside Belzoni's castle, a calm, peaceful mound of snow

lay undisturbed. Suddenly, screams filled the air, followed by a loud PLOP! PLOP! plip! Raventhorpe, Ari, Mahgdi, and Julius landed in the snow, shaking the powdery white from their hair and clothes.

Ari stuck his head out of the snow, exclaiming, "Whoa!"

Raventhorpe's head popped out next, his wild hair now coated in a layer of white. Julius's feet dangled, the only part of him visible. Raventhorpe grabbed them and pulled him out.

"Good thinking, Julius," he praised the small creature.

From the open window above, Belzoni's voice boomed, "Get them!" He directed his order at a crowd of henchmen on horses near the castle.

Jim stuck his head out in disbelief, "would you look at that?"

Belzoni turned to Jim, "You better lead the charge!"

With swords drawn, the henchmen spurred their horses into a gallop, giving chase.

"Run!" Raventhorpe yelled.

Ari shot back, breathless, "You gotta come up with better plans!"

They fled down the hills and mountains toward the Elevator, their hearts pounding as they raced to stay ahead of their pursuers.

"Oy vey, my feet are numb!" exclaimed Mahgdi. "Give me sand over this snow any day, I tell you!"

"We're here, everybody in," yelled Raventhorpe.

Inside the elevator, Raventhorpe slid to the floor guide in his usual manner, "Next stop —"

"Egypt! Hit it!" Ari interrupted, his adrenaline pumping.

Raventhorpe plugged in the coordinates and hit the red button, but nothing happened. He hit it again, with the same result.

"What's wrong?" Ari demanded, his voice filled with panic.

"I don't know," Raventhorpe admitted, his face a mask of confusion and frustration. He banged on what looked like a circuit breaker inside the elevator, shook it, but it still wouldn't respond.

He turned to Julius, "Take a look at the timing belt." Julius scurried out to investigate.

As the henchmen drew nearer, their menacing shadows cast by the sun, Ari's heart raced with the gravity of their situation. The Tiara, the key to not only Raventhorpe's chance at love but also an unparalleled power that could fall into the wrong hands, was now closer than ever before. With Belzoni's recent revelation of the Tiara's immense power, the urgency to prevent it from falling into his grasp intensified. The broken elevator posed a new challenge; success would mean overcoming yet another obstacle in their quest, while failure could leave them marooned in 1819 and at the mercy of Belzoni's ambitions.

Ari looked at Raventhorpe and felt a surge of confidence despite the dire circumstances. He had come to believe in

Raventhorpe wholeheartedly throughout their journey, and their bond had grown stronger with each passing moment.

Raventhorpe, sensing Ari's trust, gave him a firm nod. "We've got this, Ari. We'll fix the elevator and stop Belzoni."

Ari's eyes met Raventhorpe's, sharing a moment of understanding. "Hey, not only that, we're gonna get the tiara for Dolores. Eyes on the prize Professor."

The small creature squeaked and pointed, drawing their attention to sparks flying out of the crack in the Clock that Ari had caused when he tripped over it earlier.

"Ah," Raventhorpe said, realization dawning.

"Ah, what?" Ari asked, stepping over to look at the damage.

"Oh," he continued, seeing the problem. "I guess that thing did do something after-all."

Raventhorpe sighed, his expression grim. "Had a feeling that might come back to bite us in the —" The elevator fizzed and popped, going dark.

The sound of yelling henchmen fast approaching on their horses filled the air, their swords gleaming in the sunlight. Jame Curtain had now joined them leading their efforts.

"No time to waste," Raventhorpe declared, his voice tense. "Hurry, Mahgdi, get inside and stay there."

Mahgdi rushed into the elevator, and Raventhorpe slid

the doors shut.

He turned to Ari, "You're on."

"What do you mean Professor?"

"Get on top and you steer," he instructed Ari.

"How?" Ari asked, his voice high-pitched with fear.

"Use the steering wheel," Raventhorpe replied, his voice steady despite the chaos around them.

"Steering wheel?" Ari questioned, incredulous.

Sure enough, there was a steering wheel on top of the elevator. Ari scrambled up to it.

"How'd I not notice this before?" he marveled, gripping the wheel tightly. "Who puts a steering wheel on an Elevator?"

Raventhorpe pushed the Elevator into motion, and it began to slide forward. He pulled down a hinged platform, and he and Julius hopped on.

"Figured it might come in handy," he explained, his eyes focused on the path ahead.

"You figured we'd end up sliding down a mountain on an Elevator and need to steer it?" Ari shot back, holding on for dear life as they picked up speed.

"Julius and I will fix it while you buy us some time." Said Raventhorpe.

They zipped down the mountain, the henchmen hot on their heels, with James leading the pack on horseback. Their getaway was destined for failure.

Soon enough, Ari found himself clinging desperately to

the wing of the elevator, his fingers losing grip as Raventhorpe reached out to save him. With a sudden snap, the wing detached, sending Ari plummeting into the abyss below, his body tensing as he braced for the inevitable impact.

Ari lay in a messy pile of snow, barely conscious, the memory of his near-death fall still fresh in his mind. Raventhorpe crash-landed the elevator nearby and rushed to his side.

"Ari! Are you okay? Speak to me!" he cried out, his voice filled with concern.

The world around Ari faded to black as his consciousness slipped away, leaving him with only the sound of Raventhorpe's worried voice echoing in his ears.

Ari's consciousness flickered in and out, like a candle struggling to stay lit in a gust of wind. His perspective shifted and swirled, the world around him melting into a disjointed montage of images and sounds.

He caught glimpses of Raventhorpe and Mahgdi, their faces etched with concern as they tended to him. Mahgdi, having been freed from the elevator, wrapped Ari in a blanket, trying to warm his shivering body.

Raventhorpe and Julius worked together to fix the damaged elevator, their hands moving deftly as they

navigated the broken machinery. The wind howled around them, drowning out the clanking of gears and the whirring of mechanisms.

Ari's vision blurred, the scene shifting once more. He saw Belzoni and his henchmen closing in on Raventhorpe, their faces twisted with malice. The enormous man brandished the amulet and box that Raventhorpe had dropped in their haste to escape, his laughter booming across the mountainside as he patted the elevator, claiming it as his own.

Raventhorpe, desperation etched on his face, hoisted Ari onto his shoulder, and together with Julius and Mahgdi, they fled down the mountain. The world tilted and swayed around Ari, his body jolting with every step Raventhorpe took.

As they reached the bottom of the mountain, Ari caught sight of a river, its waters sparkling in the fading light. A boat awaited them, bobbing gently in the current.

Raventhorpe, his breath ragged from the harrowing descent, guided Ari and Mahgdi into the boat, settling them as comfortably as possible. They pushed off from the shore, their hearts pounding in their chests as they left the chaos of the mountain behind them, drifting into the unknown.

As Ari's consciousness continued to flicker in and out, the world around him a hazy blur, he caught a glimpse of Raventhorpe, his face etched with sorrow and defeat. The

brilliant scientist's shoulders slumped, weighed down by the crushing burden of responsibility for the events that had transpired.

"Mahgdi," Raventhorpe whispered, his voice barely audible above the gentle lapping of the river against the boat. "I've failed. I've injured the boy, I've cost you your business, Dolores will never know that I love her, we may be stuck back in 1819 forever, and a madman may have the power of the elevator and the tiara. I've lost everything."

As the words spilled from Raventhorpe's lips, Ari could sense the deep weight of his pain. Ari, though weak and unable to respond, felt a newfound determination rise within him. And then everything went black.

Back at Kasdan

Dolores Dabbledots's heart was now pounding, and she quickly threw on her favorite coat and grabbed her car keys from the bowl on the kitchen table. The phone call from principal Pellingbottom and the newscast from the night before were fresh in her mind, but a newfound sensation urged her to leave the safety of her home and venture into the darkness of the rain-soaked night. The illuminated dashboard clock read 2:03 am as she pulled into the empty parking lot, the drizzle whispering against the windows of

her car.

Dolores grabbed a flashlight, stepped out into the night, and made her way to the school's entrance. With a sense of purpose, she picked the lock with her knitting kit and entered the dimly lit hallways, the air heavy with a strange energy.

Dolores couldn't shake the deep sense of connection to this place as she stood before the locked laboratory door. As she unlocked the door and stepped inside, she was met with the chaotic aftermath of a science experiment gone wrong.

As she navigated the debris, Dolores pondered the connection between this place and the unknown force that had led her here. Her flashlight swept over the shattered remnants, revealing no clues. As she stood amidst the chaos, Dolores couldn't help but wonder why she was here. What purpose did this place hold for her, and why was every omen in the universe urging her to be here?

As her flashlight continued to search, it fell upon the tattered remains of a letter, partially burned away in the ashes. She carefully picked it up, her heart pounding in anticipation. The surviving portion simply said, "You are my destiny."

In that very instant, something within the universe seemed to shift and Dolores would never be the same again.

Abu Simbel

The sun hung high in the sky, casting a golden light across the sands of Abu Simbel. The air, hot and dry, seemed to shimmer in the afternoon heat, making the landscape appear like a mirage. The wind whispered through the desert, stirring up small eddies of sand, further obscuring the grandeur of the ancient site.

In the midst of this desolate expanse stood the colossal statues of Ramses II, mostly-buried beneath the ceaseless dunes. They were silent sentinels, guarding the entrance to

the great temple that bore witness to the passage of time. The sand had risen over the centuries, claiming the lower half of the statues and swallowing the grandeur of the past.

Despite the oppressive heat, a small group of Bedouin had gathered at the base of the statues, taking refuge in the shadows that stretched across the sand. The men, wrapped from head to toe in traditional garb, huddled together in the scant shade, their camels tethered nearby.

The men murmured in agreement, their interest piqued by the tantalizing possibility of hidden riches. But their conversation was interrupted by the appearance of another group of Bedouin, a more menacing-looking lot, who had gathered near the banks of the Nile. These men, with their dark eyes and sharp features, seemed to be waiting for something, their attention focused on the distant horizon.

Out of nowhere and in an instant, there was a white glow followed by a large metal box appearing from the ether. It slid right up to the feet of the menacing-looking Bedouin, screeching against the sand and rock.

It sat for a moment, smoke and sparks flying from random parts around it. A door seemed to slide open in the middle of it, and a large figure, too large to fit comfortably inside the box, lowered his head and stepped out.

It was the Anytime Elevator, and Belzoni had figured out how to work it to get to Abu Simbel.

The menacing-looking Bedouin quickly snapped to attention, recognizing their leader as he emerged from the

elevator. Belzoni surveyed them with a steely gaze, his authoritative presence commanding their respect.

"You've been waiting, I see," Belzoni said, his voice deep and resonant. "Good. We have much work to do."

He looked back inside the elevator and beckoned, "Bring the dynamite."

James Curtain emerged, hobbling and half the size of Belzoni, carrying a wooden crate propped against his hips. It was as if the crate was 20 pounds too heavy for him to carry comfortably. He dropped it on the sand. "You idiot, are you trying to kill us, James?" said Belzoni.

"Lemme remind you, Giovanni, that it would be much safer to dig the sand away from the temple. Blowing up the entrance on accident will seal the tiara in there for good."

Sarah Belzoni walked out of the elevator, half yawning and stretching. "Shut it, Jim."

She hugged Giovanni and looked up at him. "Do I get to throw the first stick?"

Belzoni's eyes glinted with determination as he gripped the wooden box, marching purposefully towards the sand-covered statues. He tore the lid from the box with a swift motion, revealing the packed sticks of dynamite. His fingers wrapped around the first stick, lighting it with a brief flicker from the striking surface of a match. The fuse hissed and spat sparks, the imminent explosion a mere heartbeat away. With a surge of adrenaline, Belzoni hurled it like a modern baseball outfielder, the stick arcing through

the air and landing with precision between the two statues.

The explosion was deafening, a monstrous roar that echoed across the desolate landscape. Sand evaporated and shot out in every direction, leaving a large hole where it had landed. The ground trembled beneath their feet, the sheer force of the blast a testament to Belzoni's resolve.

"See Jim, everything is fine. It would take months to dig out these temples."

Heart pounding, Belzoni lit three more sticks, his movements fluid and practiced. He chucked them at the sand, the detonations coming in rapid succession, each one more powerful than the last. The air was thick with dust and grit, the world around them transformed into a maelstrom of chaos.

"Soon, the tiara will be mine. Sarah with the tiara and the time box. We will be invincible." He looked up at the statue of Ramses II in defiance, "Our love will be invincible. I will be the true king of all the land."

His eyes glistened with anticipation, and he lit three more sticks, expertly judging the distance and angles needed for maximum impact.

As he threw them, a sudden and unexpected gust of wind blew from the direction of the Ramses II temple, threatening to affect the trajectory of the sticks.

The first two explosions erupted in the intended locations, but the third veered off course, landing dangerously close to the Anytime Elevator. The menacing-

looking Bedouin and Belzoni's crew gasped in unison as they braced for the impact.

“Take cover!” Jim yelled as he and Sarah dove away from the Elevator in safety.

Miraculously, the blast seemed to spare the elevator, but the near miss sent a shiver down everyone's spine. They exchanged uneasy glances, acutely aware of the delicate balance between success and disaster. The sand had piled up, burying the Anytime Elevator where it stood from the blast.

Belzoni stepped towards the statue of Ramses, “It’s going to take more than that to stop The Great Belzoni.” He continued his relentless assault on the sands, the explosions growing more frequent and intense.

With each stick Belzoni screamed, “Show yourself Ramses!”

Within the hour, the entire base of the Ramses statue was revealed as we know it to be today.

It would take him some time to figure out where Nefertari's tomb was and begin the same process, as it was completely covered in sand just a few hundred meters from Ramses ' statues. But with enough dynamite, it was only a matter of time before Belzoni and his crew of henchmen and raiders would uncover the tomb, locate the tiara and retain its power.

As Belzoni continued his relentless efforts to reveal the hidden entrance, the Bedouin watched in awe, captivated

by the sheer determination of this imposing figure. James and Sarah exchanged glances, their expressions a mix of admiration and concern, as they questioned the consequences of their actions.

"Is it worth the risk, Giovanni?" Sarah asked, her voice barely audible above the explosions.

Belzoni paused, his gaze fixed on a stick of dynamite still in his hand, and replied, "The power of the tiara, Sarah. Our future depends on it."

The battle between man and nature, the struggle for ultimate control, was unfolding before their very eyes. And in this unforgiving landscape, only the most resolute and daring would emerge victorious.

The Road Back

The sun's rays danced upon the water, creating a mesmerizing display of golden light as the modest wooden boat, occupied by Raventhorpe, Julius, Ari, and Mahgdi, swayed gently beneath the awe-inspiring Dolomite mountains. The peaks, adorned with a blanket of snow, were enveloped in delicate tendrils of mist, painting a picture of serenity that seemed worlds away from the treacherous escape they had just endured at the hands of Belzoni's henchmen. With determination burning in their

hearts, the trio understood the immense journey that lay ahead of them, leading to their ultimate destination: Abu Simbel in Egypt.

Ari lay unconscious, his chest heaving with shallow breaths as sweat-drenched strands of hair clung to his forehead. Mahgdi, his watchful eyes shadowed with concern, stayed close by his side. Raventhorpe, unable to resist the captivating sight of the majestic peaks that encircled them, felt the weight of responsibility for their safety pressing down upon him like an avalanche of snow.

Raventhorpe turned to Mahgdi, his voice taut with concern. "Is there a place in Egypt where Ari could recover? Somewhere safe, where we could regroup and plan our next move?"

Ari groaned in unconscious agony, and the professor leaned closer to him, murmuring, "It's alright, Ari. We're safe now." His eyes remained shut as if he didn't hear the professor.

Mahgdi's eyes softened, as he grasped Raventhorpe's apprehensions. With an attempt to lighten the mood, he replied in his distinct accent, "Yes, of course, my friend. My family home, it is in Cairo. Ari, he will heal there. My mother, she will take good care of him."

Raventhorpe acknowledged Mahgdi with a solemn nod, grateful for his willingness to open his home to them during their time of need.

They would first need to pass through Italy, sail the

Adriatic Sea, the Ionian Sea, and the Mediterranean Sea before reaching the Nile in Egypt. The journey would not be a straightforward one. During this time, Raventhorpe withdrew into himself, the weight of his failures and the worry for Ari's well-being bearing down on him. He barely spoke, his days spent staring blankly at the passing landscape, lost in his thoughts. Julius kept a watchful eye on Ari.

One particularly stormy evening, while they were still sailing the Mediterranean Sea, the skies opened up and unleashed a torrential downpour. The group was forced to take shelter in a small cave along the shore. As the rain lashed against the cave entrance, Ari's condition took a turn for the worse, his fever spiking as the damp chill seeped into their makeshift refuge.

"This isn't going to do," Raventhorpe said looking at the rain. "It'll take weeks to get to Cairo at this rate. Tomorrow morning, I'll go into the port for supplies. I think I can fashion a makeshift motor out of a steam engine. Something that really pops."

Raventhorpe's wondrous and inventive disposition turned to concern as he looked at Ari. He had managed to borrow a washcloth from a kind-hearted local who had passed by the cave, dampened it with water, and gently mopped Ari's feverish forehead as he shivered beneath a threadbare blanket. The tender care for his friend served as a rare glimpse into the nurturing side of the usually

impulsive Raventhorpe. Ari's eyes fluttered open for a moment, acknowledging Raventhorpe's efforts with a weak smile before drifting back into a restless sleep.

"Rest up Ari. We're going to get you home." Said Raventhorpe.

As the storm raged on outside, Raventhorpe remained by Ari's side, determined to see him through the fever. Mahgdi watched from the shadows, his heart heavy with concern for his friends.

In the days that followed, Raventhorpe devoted himself to the construction of a makeshift engine, a marvel of 19th-century ingenuity while Mahgdi cared for Ari. He scavenged for materials at port, drawing on his vast knowledge of mechanics, and devised a modified steam engine that would propel their modest vessel with surprising speed. Despite the limitations of the time, Raventhorpe's skilled hands fashioned a rudimentary yet functional machine, his brow furrowed in concentration as he labored over each delicate component. His passion for science shone through as he pieced together the engine, the flickering glow of a nearby lantern illuminating his determined expression.

As Raventhorpe worked, Julius took it upon himself to keep the scientist company, perching on a nearby crate and squeaking away with an air of authority. "Well, Julius, I'm doing the best I can with what we have," he retorted, not missing a beat.

Julius squeaked again, sounding indignant. "Oh, so now you're an expert on steam engines?" Raventhorpe teased, a smirk creeping onto his face.

The chinchilla let out a series of rapid squeaks, to which Raventhorpe chuckled. "Alright, alright, I appreciate your input, but I think I've got this under control."

Raventhorpe's spirits seemed to lift with Julius providing a welcome distraction from the weight of their situation.

The maiden voyage powered but the new engine went better than expected and they reached the Nile in Egypt after a few minor engine breakdowns and only a couple of days at sea.

Upon their arrival in Cairo, they were welcomed by Mahgdi's family, who opened their home to the weary travelers. Mahgdi's family was relieved he was still alive.

"Mahgdi where have you been?" His mother embraced him, kissing his forehead and Mahgdi told her of everything that had happened. About Belzoni and Ari and the Professor.

Ari was given a clean set of clothes and fresh bedding in a warm, naturally lit room facing the Nile.

She slapped both of her hands down firmly on her knees, "You must be starving." She exclaimed and the look of joy on her face to see her son alive and well gave Raventhorpe great satisfaction.

Ari continued to mend, his strength returning day by

day under the watchful care of Mahgdi's mother. As the days turned into weeks, his health steadily improved, and with each small victory, the group's hope and determination grew stronger.

One morning, Ari awoke to find himself in a warm, sunlit room, the golden rays filtering through the curtains and casting a soft glow on the walls. Mahgdi's mother bustled about the room with a warm, motherly energy, her hands working deftly as she changed the bandages on Ari's head.

From the corner of the room, Raventhorpe's voice, tinged with a hint of relief and amusement, broke the comfortable silence. "Worth the extra credit?" he asked, a small smile playing on his lips.

"Wha--how'd we--where--what happened?" Ari stammered.

"Relax, Ari. We're in Egypt," Raventhorpe replied, his voice soothing. "Little elbow grease and a dash of unfettered genius, and I was able to build an engine that turned a rickety old boat into a rocket on water."

"Where's the Elevator?" Ari asked, panic creeping into his voice.

"Oh yeah, forgot you were asleep for that part. Belzoni got it," Raventhorpe admitted with a grimace.

Ari's heart sank. "Oh-no-no-no-no, I'll be stuck back in 1800's Egypt just like I was stuck in Glendale!"

"Don't worry, Ari. I wasn't able to completely fix the

Elevator. It can't travel through time, only locations," Raventhorpe explained, hoping to reassure him. "That means Belzoni's in Egypt in this time, 1819. We just need to get there before --"

"He gets the Tiara," Ari finished for him.

"Yeah and --" Raventhorpe started.

Ari cut in, "Taps into the power of the Tiara that you failed to mention."

Raventhorpe chuckled nervously. "Yes, exactly. Guess we can rule out brain damage from your little spill. Side note, there's no power waiting to be unleashed in the Tiara. It's all a myth, so no need to worry."

"Somehow I feel less comforted," Ari muttered.

Mahgdi, who had been listening from the doorway, entered the room with a smile. "Hello, Ari! Welcome back to consciousness. We're going to Abu Simbel. Great treasures await, and I can finally restore my pastry business after bad man destroy." He patted his last sack of baklava with pride. "It will be a good day for Mahgdi and for Americans. Good day indeed."

"We have to find the Tiara first," Ari reminded them.

"We'll find it," Raventhorpe insisted. "Just pray we get there before Belzoni figures out how to program the Elevator."

Ari's brow furrowed with concern. "What happens if he gets his hands on it?"

Raventhorpe sighed. "He thinks it'll make him a

powerful god."

"Will it?" Ari asked, his voice barely above a whisper.

"Fairytale, Ari," Raventhorpe dismissed.

Mahgdi's brother, Amun, arrived at their home with a sense of urgency in his stride. Mahgdi immediately sensed that something was amiss and pulled Amun aside, speaking in hushed, anxious tones. Ari and Raventhorpe exchanged concerned glances as they watched the brothers converse, the tension in the air palpable.

Finally, Mahgdi turned to the others, his face etched with worry. "Amun has brought news about Belzoni. He is closer than ever to finding the Tiara, and his intentions are far more sinister than we could have imagined." Amun then shared the details of Belzoni's plan, his fervent belief in the Tiara's power, and the dangerous lengths he was willing to go to in order to secure it.

Raventhorpe slammed his fist on the table, the sound echoing in the courtyard. "Over my dead body," he growled, his eyes burning with determination. He dropped his already packed gear and looked at Ari, Julius, and Mahgdi. "We stop him. For all our sakes."

They pored over maps and researched the location of the Tiara, determined to beat Belzoni to it and reclaim the elevator. As they worked, Raventhorpe slowly emerged from his shell, his brilliant mind once more engaged and focused on the task at hand.

As the weeks passed, they continued gathering

information, planning, and preparing for the final leg of their journey. Eventually, the day arrived when they felt confident and ready to set out. They boarded a small boat, the sun casting a warm glow over the Nile as they traveled south toward Abu Simbel. As they journeyed, Raventhorpe confided in Ari and Mahgdi about his past failures, his voice tinged with sadness and longing for love. The three men shared stories of their lives before this adventure, forging an unbreakable bond as their boat glided through the waters.

Raventhorpe shared for the first time with Ari that he had been working on the elevator back at the university when there was an accident and it exploded.

“So that’s why you go by Professor? Why didn’t you just tell me that to begin with?” Asked Ari.

“You would have never got on the elevator if you knew the last one exploded,” he chimed in with a laugh. “Actually the first one was a cheaper consumer grade elevator, of course now the Anytime Elevator is a museum quality freight elevator.”

“Yeah where did you get that thing?” Asked Ari.

“Borrowed it from the old Breaker Lang hotel before they demolished it.”

“How’d you even get it out of there.”

Raventhorpe stared at him blankly, the look he gave him many times in class, expecting Ari to come to the conclusion through reason.

"Oh right forgot the whole interdeminsional traveling thing."

"The floors of the universe," Raventhorpe chimed in.

As their boat glided down the river, each day brought new sights and experiences, and with each small victory. The group's hope and determination grew stronger they marveled at the ancient ruins of Luxor, and the stunning beauty of the Nile as it snaked its way through the vast desert landscape. As the boat drifted further south, Mahgdi pointed out a significant site. "That is where we first met, in the Valley of the Kings." They all smiled and nodded. Ari then remembered Mahgdi's camels and asked how Thuya and Khalifa were doing. "Ask them yourselves," Mahgdi replied, pointing to the shore where the camels stood waiting. "We ride from here. Amun took care of them."

The camels were ecstatic to see Mahgdi and they made loud and strange noises as if to say hello in their own special way.

Raventhorpe couldn't help but let his academic sense start to take over. This time in this place, 1800's Egypt, was like no other in history. It was the time of the tomb raider, a simpler time, a more magical and majestic time. The Bedouin greeted them happily as they rode through the desert. It must have looked similar to the Romans he thought. Without out the modern technology.

As the temples of Abu Simbel materialized on the horizon, their ancient stone visages gazing out over the

Nile, bearing witness to the grandeur of a time long past, the sight instilled in the men a feeling of awe and a renewed sense of purpose.

Raventhorpe turned to Ari and Mahgdi, his eyes alight with determination. "We will redeem ourselves," he proclaimed, his voice unwavering. "We will retrieve the elevator, thwart Belzoni, recover the Tiara, and return to 2023. And Mahgdi, you will be wealthy beyond measure."

"My friend, I'm already wealthy." Mahgdi said as he smiled at them all in appreciation of their friendship.

Ari smiled and nodded, and then their faces mirrored Raventhorpe's determination. With their spirits reignited, they prepared to face their greatest challenge yet. As their boat drew closer to the temples, the sun cast a golden glow over the ancient stones, a symbol of hope in the face of darkness.

The Hidden Chamber

The sun seared down on the majestic sandstone statues of Abu Simbel, the ancient Egyptian site dedicated to pharaohs and gods. The first rays of sunlight illuminated the colossal statues of Ramesses II precisely with queen Nefertari's tomb. The sheer scale of the statues was humbling, and Ari couldn't help but feel like a mere speck in the grand scheme of history.

Ari stared up at the imposing figures, the awe in his voice palpable. "Incredible, isn't it?"

Raventhorpe gazed at the monuments with an air of wonder. Though he didn't have a formal background in Egyptology, he had a deep appreciation for history and its artifacts. "Indeed, Ari." Julius, Raventhorpe's chinchilla assistant, squeaked in agreement, his whiskers twitching with excitement.

As they prepared to enter the temple, Ari couldn't help but ask, "Where the heck is the elevator?"

Raventhorpe surmised, "Either Belzoni has it in the temple loading it with treasure, or we're already too late."

They passed by the temple dedicated to Ramses II and soon found themselves in front of Nefertari's Temple.

"This is it boys," said Raventhorpe. "This is what it's all about. Keep a look out for Belzoni and his henchmen."

They ventured inside the temple. The dimly lit corridors seemed to swallow them whole, the weight of centuries pressing down on them. Mahgdi led the way, his torch flickering against the ancient walls, casting eerie shadows that seemed to dance and sway with every step they took.

Ari marveled at the intricate hieroglyphics and paintings that adorned the walls, telling stories of long-forgotten pharaohs and gods. A particular painting caught his attention: it depicted the god Ra wearing a magnificent tiara, with a giant Key of Life and a bolt of lightning above it. "Professor, does Saturno's book say anything about this?"

Raventhorpe eyed the painting. "No, it doesn't. I

wonder what that lightning bolt means connecting the key of life and the tiara. Curious." Raventhorpe's voice echoed in the narrow space. "The tiara should be held in a room at the end this next corridor."

They followed the corridor which ended in a dead end, Ari frowned in frustration. "So where is it?"

Mahgdi peered at the wall, his brow furrowed. "Nothing here."

Julius squeaked insistently, and Raventhorpe translated, "Julius thinks it's a false wall."

Ari slammed his body against the wall and nothing happened. "Well how do get past it? Feels pretty real to my shoulder."

"Here, all three of us and you too Julius," said Raventhorpe. "On the count of three lets all ram it with our shoulders at the same time. Ok? Alright 1....2.....3"

A sense of anticipation washed over them as they entered the chamber. The room was immense, a testament to the grandeur of ancient Egypt. Opulent treasures filled every corner: gold chalices, intricately carved statues, and priceless jewelry. The sheer magnitude of wealth was nearly overwhelming, but what held their attention was the fact that several of the treasures seemed to be floating, suspended in midair by an unseen force.

Mahgdi's voice was hushed, filled with disbelief. "I have never seen such wonders in all my life." He began to sing and dance around the room in sheer joy and exuberance.

Ari, wide-eyed, could barely contain his excitement. "It's friggin' incredible."

Raventhorpe's expression, however, remained focused. "The Tiara has to be here somewhere. Start looking."

They began to search the chamber, each moving methodically through the floating treasures. They sifted through piles of gold coins, pried open ornate chests, and examined countless artifacts, all the while marveling at the invisible force that held them aloft.

As Ari moved through the room, he couldn't help but think of Raventhorpe giving the tiara to Dolores. He imagined her face when they returned with the tiara, and how the professor, a man he now admired, had accomplished the brave and unthinkable task of stealing a piece of history for the woman he loved.

As the search continued, frustration mounted. They found numerous treasures but no sign of the elusive Tiara. Ari tried to reason with Raventhorpe. "Let's just take one of these necklaces or something back to Dolores and call it a day."

Raventhorpe's voice was edged with desperation. "No! It has to be the Tiara. We have to find it! For Dolores and for our future!"

"But it's not here—"

"It's here! Find it!"

Ari, Julius, and Mahgdi exchanged uneasy glances, watching as Raventhorpe tore through the room in a panic,

his obsession with the Tiara consuming him. He had everything riding on this; his life's work, reputation, and love for Dolores were at stake. The tension in the chamber was palpable, and Ari knew that they couldn't give up. Not now, when they were so close.

As they continued their search, a maniacal laughter echoed through the chamber, sending shivers down their spines.

“What the heck was that?” Said Ari.

“I dunno. It didn’t sound like Belzoni.” Raventhorpe responded as he looked around to see if it was coming from their chamber. “Where’s did it come from?”

After a few moments they returned his attention to finding the Tiara, hoping that the treasure was still within their reach.

Ari's thoughts raced as he searched the chamber, the laughter echoing in his mind. He could see the strain on Raventhorpe's face, and he knew that they had to find the Tiara for his sake as well as their own. Failure was not an option.

As the group combed through the treasures, Ari couldn't help but marvel at the incredible artifacts that surrounded them. The ancient Egyptians had been master craftsmen, and their skill was evident in every piece. Each item seemed to hold a piece of history, a story waiting to be told.

But as time wore on, Ari's initial excitement began to wane. The Tiara remained elusive, and he couldn't shake

the nagging feeling that they were running out of time. The laughter came back and this time it was louder, more menacing, as if mocking their efforts.

"Who's there?" Raventhorpe yelled as he looked around.

Ari felt a wave of despair wash over him, but he forced himself to remain focused. "Don't listen to that, Professor. There has to be something we're missing, some clue that will lead us to the Tiara."

Raventhorpe's eyes were filled with anguish, and he broke down in tears. "My entire life has been a disappointment, Ari. If we don't find it, I don't know what I'll do."

Ari moved closer to Raventhorpe and put a reassuring hand on his shoulder. "We'll find it. We've come this far, and we're not giving up now. Let's sit for a minute and think."

Raventhorpe nodded, and the two of them sat down in a pair of throne looking seats. As they sat the chairs rocked backwards at a 45 degree angle and leaned against the temple wall. A soft click resonated through the space, and a hidden passage opened up behind them.

Ari glanced at the newly revealed passage, uncertainty in his eyes. "What the...?"

Then, the laughter grew louder and crisper, its sinister tone sending a shiver down their spines.

The group hesitated for a moment, the unknown passage

before them shrouded in darkness. But they had come too far to turn back now, and with steely determination. The Professor stood wiping his tears with renewed purpose.

Raventhorpe's gaze followed Ari's into the dark and he nodded, a flicker of hope returning to his expression. He took two steps in and stopped dead, slowly turning back towards Ari, his face more serious than ever,

"It's the altar room Ari."

The Alter Room

As they moved cautiously up the dark corridor from the hidden chamber, the sound of Belzoni's laughter grew louder. They followed the sound until they found themselves in a massive room, the likes of which they had never seen before. The Altar Room, as it was known, had an ornate gold altar in the center. The Great Belzoni stood before it, with Sarah, James, and a few henchmen to the side, all watching in wonder. The amulet, glowing with a radiant gold light, was draped around Belzoni's neck as he

performed some sort of ancient ritual. The Tiara of Nefertari was centered on the altar, ensconced in a golden glow.

The air in the Altar Room was heavy, almost palpable, as if the very breaths of countless generations were trapped within its ancient walls. The scent of long-forgotten incense and the unmistakable aroma of time itself mingled with the dust motes that danced in the dim light. The room seemed to hold centuries of secrets, and its very stones whispered with the echoes of long-lost prayers and hallowed chants.

As they entered the room, they couldn't help but be struck by its sheer size and grandeur. The walls stretched high overhead, adorned with intricate frescoes that depicted scenes of gods and goddesses, their vibrant colors still vivid despite the passage of time. The floor was a mosaic of precious stones, each placed with the precision of a master craftsman, forming patterns that spiraled outwards from the room's centerpiece: the ornate gold altar.

The altar itself was a work of art, a testament to the devotion and skill of its creators. It was adorned with intricate carvings of mythical creatures and sacred symbols, each one a link in a chain that bound the altar to the room and the room to the world beyond. The gold had been polished to a mirror-like sheen, reflecting the flickering light from the torches that lined the walls, casting a warm, golden glow across the room.

In front of the altar stood The Great Belzoni, his back to them, his hands raised in a gesture of supplication. The ancient scrolls of the Pharaohs floated effortlessly in front of Belzoni, as if suspended by some invisible force. He regarded them with the intense gaze of a maestro studying a complex musical score, his eyes darting back and forth as he deciphered the arcane script.

He was dressed in lavish robes, the cloth heavy with embroidery and beads, the colors as rich and dark as a midnight sky. The amulet around his neck seemed to pulse with an inner light, its glow complementing the golden aura that suffused the room. From where they stood, hidden behind the pillar, they could hear the low, rhythmic chanting of Belzoni's voice as he performed the ancient ritual.

To one side of the room, Sarah, James, and a few henchmen stood in rapt attention, their eyes fixed on the ceremony unfolding before them. The tension in the air was palpable, as if the very fabric of reality was being stretched to its limit, threatening to tear apart at any moment. The weight of history bore down on them, a tangible reminder of the countless souls who had stood in this very room, seeking the same power and immortality that now tantalized Belzoni.

Then, the atmosphere in the room grew heavier, the air seeming to thicken and constrict around them. It was as if the forces Belzoni sought to harness were resisting, pushing

back against his will and the desecration of their sacred space. A faint, otherworldly hum filled the room, vibrating through the stones beneath their feet and resonating in the very marrow of their bones.

Raventhorpe, Ari, Mahgdi, and Julius hid behind a large pillar, careful not to be seen. Mahgdi peered around the column to get a closer look at Belzoni.

"That is the man who took me prisoner and destroyed my life," Mahgdi whispered bitterly. "Evil, bad man."

Belzoni's voice boomed through the room and he turned in the direction of the pillar. "Tonight, Giovanni Battista Belzoni becomes the most powerful man in the world! Who do you think you are?"

The Tiara emitted an intense light that formed ghostly images of the people Ari and Raventhorpe loved, hovering above Belzoni's head. Raventhorpe and Ari saw Dolores, her eyes pleading for him to save her. The images shifted and wavered, as if the very fabric of their existence was threatened by Belzoni's quest for power.

A surge of defiance rose within Ari, and he stepped out from behind the pillar, into Belzoni's gaze, heart pounding, to shout, "I'm Ari Buktu!" His declaration echoed throughout the room.

Belzoni responded with a sinister laugh, seemingly unfazed by Ari's defiance. He raised his arms, and the amulet around his neck began to pulse with an even stronger light. Suddenly, the room shook violently, as if

responding to Belzoni's command, and the walls seemed to close in on them. Ari stumbled back, feeling the overwhelming power emanating from the ritual, and took refuge behind the pillar once more.

Ari looked at Raventhorpe, his eyes wide with fear. "Uhhhh, what's going on? Professor, this looks pretty real to me."

Raventhorpe tried to sound confident, although he was clearly shaken. "The legend says the Tiara contains a mystical power that turns its wielder immortal and without limit of strength, but like I said, it's just a myth. As a man of science, I'm telling you, it's all fairytales."

Ari wasn't convinced. "Then why's that thing glowing?"

"Uh... light refraction," Raventhorpe stammered. "See? A perfect scientific explanation."

Just then, the Tiara shot out a beam of light that filled the room. Ari glared at Raventhorpe. "Light refraction, my butt."

Raventhorpe glanced around, searching for Mahgdi. "Mahgdi, why don't—"

But Mahgdi was gone.

"Where'd he go?" Raventhorpe asked, as Julius pointed something out to him.

As Belzoni prepared to take possession of the Tiara, Mahgdi appeared, riding both camels, Thuya and Khalifa, and screaming at the top of his lungs. "Fastest camels in all of Egypt!"

He charged toward Belzoni, leaping off the camels and in mid-flight swinging his sack of baklava like a weapon. "Noooo! No more taking!"

James Curtain tackled Mahgdi, but the sack still struck the Tiara, knocking it off the altar. Beams of light ripped through the room, surging with energy, and the group ducked and dodged to avoid being sliced in half. Belzoni's henchmen weren't so lucky.

The Tiara cut a hole in the ground, opening a vast crater that appeared to be miles deep. The Tiara's light died out and it began to slip into the crater.

"No!" Belzoni roared, diving for the Tiara just as it went over the edge. He vanished into the abyss, followed closely by the Tiara, which settled on a jagged stone jutting out from the edge of the crater.

"Oh no, you don't," Sarah snarled. "You're not leaving without me." She blindly jumped in after her husband, disappearing into the darkness.

James, ever the loyal servant, followed suit. "Mr. and Mrs. Belzoni!" he cried as he leaped into the abyss.

Raventhorpe's eyes locked onto the dangling Tiara, burning with the desire that had driven him this far. "No, it's mine!" he exclaimed, running to jump towards the crater.

Just as Raventhorpe reached the edge, Ari grabbed hold of him. "No, Professor. It's not worth it."

"But we've come all this way," Raventhorpe protested.

"It's right there."

Ari reasoned with him. "Think about Dolores. You can't be with her if you're dead."

Raventhorpe mulled this over for a moment, torn between his obsession and the truth of Ari's words. "You had to hit me with reason and logic, Ari."

He looked down into the crater, where the Tiara seemed to taunt him. Slowly, it slipped off the stone and fell into the black shroud below, leaving only a glint of its golden glow visible.

"You're right," Raventhorpe finally admitted. "Let's go home."

As if on cue, the room began to fall apart. "Must hurry!" Mahgdi urged them, and the group sprinted, narrowly avoiding a large section of collapsing temple.

More of the room began to crumble around them, they knew they had to get out of there. Mahgdi hurriedly mounted Thuya and Khalifa, urging the camels onwards with every ounce of his soul. Ari, Raventhorpe, and Julius followed, their hearts pounding in their chests.

The entire temple seemed to groan and shudder, as if it were a living creature wounded and dying. Massive stones broke free from the walls and ceiling, crashing down around them, filling the air with choking dust and debris. The once-majestic mosaic floor cracked and split beneath their feet, threatening to swallow them whole.

They raced down the collapsing corridor, their eyes

fixed on the rapidly shrinking patch of sunlight that marked their only chance of escape. Mahgdi's camels, Thuya and Khalifa, were now screaming, their hooves pounding against the fractured stone with a desperation Mahgdi had never seen before from them.

Ari glanced over at Raventhorpe, who was running with surprising agility for a man of his age and stature, his eyes filled with determination. Julius, the ever-loyal chinchilla, clung to the professor's shoulder, his tiny body trembling with the effort of holding on. He couldn't tell but he thought he saw the professor grin.

They could see the ground outside falling away, leaving only a small slab of stable land. With a final surge of adrenaline, they leaped from the collapsing temple onto the solid ground, narrowly escaping the jaws of certain death.

They landed in a heap, a tangle of limbs, camels, and one small chinchilla and rode a wave of debris like surfers for what felt like minutes and then they stopped. As they caught their breath and looked back at the ruins of the ancient temple, they knew that they had just experienced something they would never forget.

Farwell Mahgdi

The desert air was dry and hot, making the group of adventurers gasp for breath. They stood before the Temple of Nefertari, its majestic golden sandstone facade gleaming under the relentless Egyptian sun. The temple stood tall, a testament to perseverance and the brilliance of ancient architecture. The outer rooms, adorned with intricate carvings and hieroglyphs, had withstood the collapse that had sealed the Tiara of Nefertari within the now-hidden internal chambers. The splendor of the remaining structure

served as a somber reminder of the tantalizing treasure forever entombed within its walls.

Raventhorpe, Ari, Julius, and Mahgdi brushed sand from their clothing, trying to regain their bearings. Raventhorpe's eyes scanned their surroundings, searching for any sign of the Anytime Elevator.

"Now we just gotta find where Belzoni hid the Elevator so we can get out of here," Raventhorpe mused, scratching his head in thought.

Julius glanced down at the ground beneath them. He tugged on Raventhorpe's coat, trying to get his attention.

Raventhorpe waved him away, saying, "Not now, I'm thinking. Would he hide it in plain sight? Sure hope it wasn't in the temple."

More insistent, Julius tugged on Raventhorpe's hair, forcing him to look down and realize they were standing on the Elevator all along.

"Oh, there it is," Raventhorpe exclaimed, feeling slightly foolish.

A sense of relief washed over the group as they carefully stepped off the Elevator, their feet sinking into the warm sand. Ari, feeling sorry for Mahgdi, said, "I'm sorry we couldn't get anything to pay you, Mahgdi."

Raventhorpe suddenly remembered something and reached into his pocket. "Oh, I almost forgot," he said, pulling out a gold coin. "Got this from some friendly pirates."

He tossed the coin to Mahgdi, who caught it with a smile. "Most generous," Mahgdi said, revealing a handful of solid gold treasures hidden in his sack, adding the coin to his collection.

Raventhorpe laughed. "Slick, Mahgdi. I respect that."

"With this, I will create a pastry empire. Mahgdi is going to be rich!" Mahgdi declared, his eyes sparkling with excitement.

"Empire, huh?" Raventhorpe mused, considering the possibilities.

Ari turned to Raventhorpe, a concerned look on his face.

"So, how are you going to fix the Elevator?"

"That's a good question," Raventhorpe replied. "The problem is in the clock. We need a new one."

Mahgdi, never one to disappoint, pulled out a gold sundial clock from his baklava sack. "Will this work?" he asked, holding it out to Raventhorpe.

"Mahgdi, my friend, that is perfect," Raventhorpe exclaimed, grabbing the sundial and immediately getting to work on repairing the Elevator.

As the sun hung just above the horizon, casting its golden light on the temple of Nefertari, it appeared as if the statue of Ramses was watching the temple intently. Only the Elevator, positioned in front of the temple, seemed to stand in the way of his eternal gaze.

As the sun began to set, painting the sky with shades of orange and pink, Raventhorpe successfully affixed the

sundial where the clock had once been. "Finished," he said, sighing with relief.

Ari put his hand on Raventhorpe's shoulder, offering his support. "I just wish we got our hands on the Tiara," Raventhorpe lamented.

"I know," Ari sympathized. "But Dolores has to love you for you, not some overhyped jewelry."

"You're right, Ari," Raventhorpe conceded, a small smile forming on his lips.

As the sun dipped lower in the sky, bathing the majestic Temple of Nefertari in a warm glow, Raventhorpe disappeared into the elevator, saying, "Now I brought something for an occasion just like this." He reappeared carrying a Polaroid camera. They positioned it on a sand dune in front of them, ready to capture their moment together. Smiling before the Elevator and Abu Simbel, Raventhorpe clicked a button, and the photo was taken. Raventhorpe scribbled, "Floor 1819, Mahgdi" on the photo, and passed it around, with everyone cherishing the moment.

After sharing a nostalgic chuckle, Raventhorpe carefully taped the Polaroid onto the inside panel of the Elevator, a memento of their adventure and camaraderie. "My favorite floor so far," said Raventhorpe with water welling in his eyes. Julius lept onto Thuya and Khalifa hugging them and squeaking. They seemed to laugh and smile in response.

Ari had never felt this feeling before. Never in his entire

life had he felt a sense of unity so strongly growing within him. Victoria and Glendale seemed like a distant memory. He wondered if he'd ever see Mahgdi again, even if he didn't he could never imagine forgetting his warmth. How his family nursed him back to life and how against all odds Mahgdi charted The Great Belzoni with the fate of the Universe on the line without fear.

Everything in Egypt seemed settled and back to normal. He inhaled deeply, feeling that the time had come to part ways, Ari turned to the Raventhorpe and asked, "Ready Professor?"

"Ready, come on Julius," he said and Julius hopped onto Mahgdi's hand and scurried over to Raventhorpe.

The stepped onto the Elevator and glanced back at their Egyptian friend, standing with his camels on the other side of the door in Egypt, 1817.

"Goodbye, Mahgdi," Raventhorpe said, his voice filled with gratitude.

"Goodbye, friends," Mahgdi replied, bowing his head and winking at Julius.

Ari entered '2023' into the floor guide as Raventhorpe shared a knowing glance. The two exchanged a heartfelt chuckle before Ari pressed the red button. In an instant, a brilliant white light enveloped them, whisking them away to their next destination.

As they traveled through time, Ari looked down and noticed something on the floor of the Elevator. "What's

that?" he asked.

Raventhorpe recognized it as one of Mahgdi's treasures. "Looks like we've got a little souvenir from our adventure after all," he said with a grin.

The radiant white flash subsided and the elevator was gone, leaving the statue of Ramses to bear witness to a solitary Bedouin on camelback traversing the desert landscape towards the north. The eternal gaze of Ramses returned to its original focus, as the sun's final golden rays bathed Nefertari's temple in a warm, ethereal glow.

A New Beginning

Dolores walked through the dimly lit halls of Kasdan High School, her thoughts consumed by the partial letter she had glimpsed in the science lab. As she neared the front doors, the words danced in her mind, tantalizing her with their mystery.

With a deep breath, she pushed open the heavy doors and stepped into the waning light of day. The brightness of the sun was almost too much, momentarily blinding her as her eyes struggled to adjust. Then, suddenly, the harshness

of its light was broken by a figure standing between her and the sun.

Before she could make out who it was, Dolores noticed a commotion to her left. Principal Pellingbottom was barking orders at a group of firefighters to retrieve her once-colorful caged bird from the top of a tall tree. "You incompetent buffoons! Get that bird down this instant and return it to its cage!" she demanded, her voice booming.

As one of the firefighters climbed the tree and got close to grabbing the bird, it let out a beautiful sound, spread its wings wide, and swooped down toward Pellingbottom as if to return to her comfort. "That's right, come to mama," she said, arms outstretched, her tone momentarily softening.

Except at the last moment, the bird revealed its talon-like feet, causing Ms. Pellingbottom to flinch and back up in fear. "You wretched creature!" she screamed, her voice returning to its usual harshness. She lost her balance and fell feet over head into a trashcan. The students laughed and cheered at the sight of the bird soaring up and high in the direction of sun as their dreaded principal lay defeated in the trash.

As her eyes followed the beautiful free bird Dolores's eyes came to rest on the figure in front of her. "Raventhorpe?" she asked, her voice uncertain.

The man's face came into focus, his bright yellow trenchcoat making him stand out like a beacon. Somehow, the sight of his trenchcoat felt warmer than the sun itself.

"Dolores," he said, his voice tinged with excitement. He stepped closer, revealing a small rock in his hand and a small creature balanced on his shoulder.

"Oh hi, Lionel," she said. Her tone was polite, but there was a hint of caution in her voice.

"I got this for you," he said, extending the rock toward her.

She looked at the rock, then back at him. "Oh...thanks?" Her voice was uncertain, but she took the rock anyway.

"No, you see, it's a rock from ancient Egypt," he continued, clearly excited about his gift.

Dolores raised her eyebrows. "Oh..." she said, her voice still laced with uncertainty.

Raventhorpe pressed on, oblivious to her hesitation. "Because you love ancient Egypt..."

"I do?" she asked, her voice bemused.

"The painting of Nefertari's tiara on your wall --"

"Oh, that gaudy painting?" Dolores interrupted. "That came with the classroom. I keep trying to get them to take it down. Not really my thing."

Raventhorpe's face fell. "Not really your thing?" he muttered under his breath. "You gotta be kidding me."

"But thanks for the rock," Dolores said, attempting to smooth over the awkward moment. "It's great." She glanced at him, her gaze lingering a little longer than necessary.

Raventhorpe hesitated, then began to speak. "Listen, I

was wondering if --"

The sudden sound of a car horn cut him off. They both turned to see the same handsome man from days before waiting in a sleek car nearby. Dolores' face lit up with a warm smile.

Raventhorpe's face fell again. "Oh...never mind," he said, his voice heavy with disappointment.

But Dolores wasn't ready to let him go just yet. "Wait, what were you going to ask me?" she asked, her curiosity piqued.

He turned back to her, his expression sullen. "It's fine. I guess you have to get to your boyfriend." He started to turn away, but Dolores' laughter stopped him in his tracks.

"That's not my boyfriend," she said, still chuckling. "He's my brother."

Raventhorpe's face brightened. "Your brother? Of course! Your brother!" He took a deep breath, then plunged ahead. "In that case, Dolores, would you like to have dinner with me?"

Dolores smiled, her eyes twinkling. "Lionel, I would love to."

He couldn't contain his excitement. "Yes! Yes! Yes!" he exclaimed, pumping his fist in the air.

She waited for his celebration to end, then said, "Great. Pick you up Friday at eight, your place?"

"Sounds wonderful," Dolores agreed.

As she walked toward the car, she called back, "Thanks

for the rock. I like your chinchilla, by the way."

Raventhorpe looked at the creature on his shoulder, then back at Dolores. "Actually, he's a -- wait, yes, he is a chinchilla! Thank you."

The creature, Julius, squeaked excitedly as if to say, "Finally!"

"See you Friday, Lionel," Dolores said, climbing into the car.

As they drove away, Raventhorpe stood on the sidewalk, still clutching the rock. "Friday..." he murmured to himself.

He pulled a sheaf of bankruptcy papers from his pocket, the word "FRIDAY" stamped across them in bold red letters. As he stared at them, a gust of wind tore the papers from his grasp. He chased after them, but they spiraled up into the air, just out of reach.

As the wind carried the papers away, they slapped against a nearby billboard. Raventhorpe stopped running and stared up at the sign:

"We Buy Gold and Other Valuables. TOP DOLLAR EVERY TIME"

His thoughts wandered to the treasure Mahgdi left for him in the elevator. An idea began to form in his mind, growing and expanding until it struck him with the force of a lightning bolt.

"An empire indeed, Mahgdi," Raventhorpe said, his face lighting up with determination and newfound hope.

Anytime Inc.

Ari had eagerly anticipated this day, having removed all of Victoria's paintings from the walls in his bedroom and replacing them with posters of ancient treasures, long-lost artifacts and exotic places. He knew that he had not only survived the harrowing journey of his time-traveling adventures but also had ignited a new passion: uncovering the secrets of the universe.

As Ari admired the new posters in his room, Victoria barged in, her eyes wide with fury. "What have you done

to these walls? Where are my paintings? They are priceless, you know!"

Ari, unfazed by her outburst, stood his ground. "Why did you never tell me who my real parents were?" he asked, cutting her off before she could continue.

Just as Victoria was about to answer, the strange sound of an elevator echoed through the room, growing louder and more insistent. The walls seemed to vibrate with the force of the noise, as if the very fabric of reality was being stretched and reshaped. As the sound reached its crescendo, a brilliant white light flashed, momentarily blinding everyone in the room. When the light dissipated, the sleek, futuristic form of the Anytime Elevator stood before them, its doors sliding open with a soft hiss. Revealed within were Raventhorpe and Julius, both dressed in matching all-blue jumpers with the words "Anytime Inc." proudly emblazoned on the breast. Julius, the fearless chinchilla, seemed to have taken on an air of authority as he stood by Raventhorpe's side, his bright eyes gleaming with intelligence and determination.

"Ah, Ari, there you are," said Raventhorpe, stepping out of the elevator and into Victoria's mansion.

Victoria, dumbfounded and threatening to call the police, stared at the intruders. "Who are you?"

Raventhorpe calmly replied, "Relax, Victoria. I'm Ari's physics teacher, and Ari here is the brightest young mind I've ever encountered."

At this, Victoria's knees buckled, and she fainted onto the floor.

Raventhorpe, seemingly unfazed by the question, thumbed through Saturno's book. "We've got unfound treasures waiting for us on floors 1920, 1612, 1350 and, with Belzoni meeting an early demise, there are plenty of other temples he failed to plunder and destroy. So add 1820 to the list -- "

Ari looked at the uniform, then back at the unconscious Victoria. His thoughts wandered back to his encounters with Belzoni, Princess Namine, and Blackbeard, which already seemed like a distant dream. The idea of embarking on new, untold adventures throughout the many floors of the universe felt like the life he had always wanted, filled with excitement and discovery.

"Professor, wait, but what about Dolores?" Ari asked, suddenly concerned.

"Dolores is fine, Ari," Raventhorpe reassured him. "She's the new chief historian of Anytime Inc., and she's waiting for us."

Ari could see it in the Professor's eyes. He had found love, and that love had inspired a new chapter for them all – the dawning of Anytime Inc.

Just as Ari was about to step into the elevator, Victoria stirred, groggily coming back to consciousness. "Ari, get out of that thing this instant!" she demanded, her voice a mixture of anger and concern.

Raventhorpe glanced at Ari. "Ari, be polite," he said, a gentle reminder of the unresolved tension between them.

Ari looked back at Victoria, and before the elevator doors closed, he said with a confident grin, "Your favorite time-traveling mailman, at your service!"

Raventhorpe looked at him and said, "Funny, my mother wanted me to be a mailman too." Ari laughed and smashed the red button, and a dazzling white light enveloped them. In an instant, they vanished, leaving Victoria frozen as stiff as a statue.

Epilogue

In the heart of a hidden chamber, tucked away from the prying eyes of the world, maps and newspaper clippings adorned the walls, while artifacts and treasures – the spoils of a lifetime of daring heists – were scattered across the floor. The air was thick with dust and secrets, the lair of the infamous tomb raider Belzoni a testament to the man's relentless pursuit of ancient knowledge and the wealth it brought him. The low flicker of candlelight danced on the walls, casting shadows that seemed to bring the room to

life.

The giant, familiar frame of Belzoni moved methodically through the dimly lit room, his eyes scanning the documents laid out before him. Years had passed since his last encounter with Ari and Raventhorpe, but the burning desire for revenge still coursed through his veins, driving him to continue his search for any clue that might lead him to his adversaries. The air was electric, as if he could sense that he was on the brink of a breakthrough.

As if possessed by a sudden burst of energy, he beckoned wife Sarah to join him at the table. "Sarah, come quickly!" he urged, his voice filled with excitement. "This may be the lead we've been waiting for."

She hurried to his side, her eyes following his finger as it traced a line of text on the piece of paper before them. "This merchant claims to have seen two oddly dressed men fleeing for their lives, one an old man, another a younger man." He read on, "it was if they were from another time." Belzoni declared, his voice filled with conviction. "I've found them."

With renewed determination, Belzoni gathered his gear, kissed Sarah goodbye, and mounted a camel, the beast snorting in protest as it bore the weight of the hulking man. As they rode off into the sunset, the vast desert seemed to swallow them whole, the wind whispering secrets that only the sands knew.

Days later, when Belzoni finally found the merchant, he

demanded his story. "Tell me everything you saw," he ordered, his voice low and commanding.

"I saw a short, round, balding man running through the streets, yelling at a mouse," the merchant recounted nervously.

"A rat," Belzoni corrected.

"Right, a rat. Followed by a younger man, maybe 18 years old."

Belzoni began to smile, his heart racing. "What did they say?" he asked, his voice barely concealing his excitement.

"Well, the older man said something about a diamond. The younger man seemed to be only half listening to the older man and was more interested in whoever was chasing them. Sure enough, a group of mercenaries came through a few moments after them. They looked like they weren't from around here."

"Did the mercenaries say anything?"

"No, but I got one's name."

"What was it?"

"Mehmet."

Belzoni's eyes grew wide, and he stood up, towering over the merchant. "I am The Great Belzoni. If anyone ever comes here asking for me, you tell them that I vanished here in this city."

"Ok, Mr. Belzoni," the merchant replied, trembling slightly. "Lots of people vanish here in Timbuktu."

Belzoni was already walking away, his eyes locked on

the rising sun. He let out an angry growl, the rage and determination to find his enemies boiling within him. With a snarl, he bellowed one last word.

"BUKTUUUUUU!"